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Happening today

● **ALL SIKH MLAs** and cabinet ministers of Punjab are set to appear before the Akal Takht, which has summoned them regarding the anti-sacrilege law.

● **THE SUPREME COURT** is set to hear a petition seeking a CBI-led SIT probe into the alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya.

● **HEALTH MINISTER** J P Nadda will release the Anaemia Mukh Bharat Abhiyaan Operational Guidelines, marking a significant milestone in India's fight against anaemia.

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NATION PAGE 12

TET PAPER LEAK: PROBE WIDENS TO DELHI, BIHAR, UP, HARYANA

IRAN TARGETS U.S. MILITARY SITES IN KUWAIT, BAHRAIN

Ceasefire falters as Iran and US exchange fresh strikes, threats

US may militarily complete the job, if that happens, Iran will no longer exist: Trump

Tala Ramadan, Eman Abouhassira & Phil Stewart
Dubai, Washington, June 28

IRAN LAUNCHED missiles and drones at US military sites in Kuwait and Bahrain early on Sunday, shortly after President Donald Trump threatened to wipe out the Iranian leadership if they did not stick to the interim agreement to end their war.

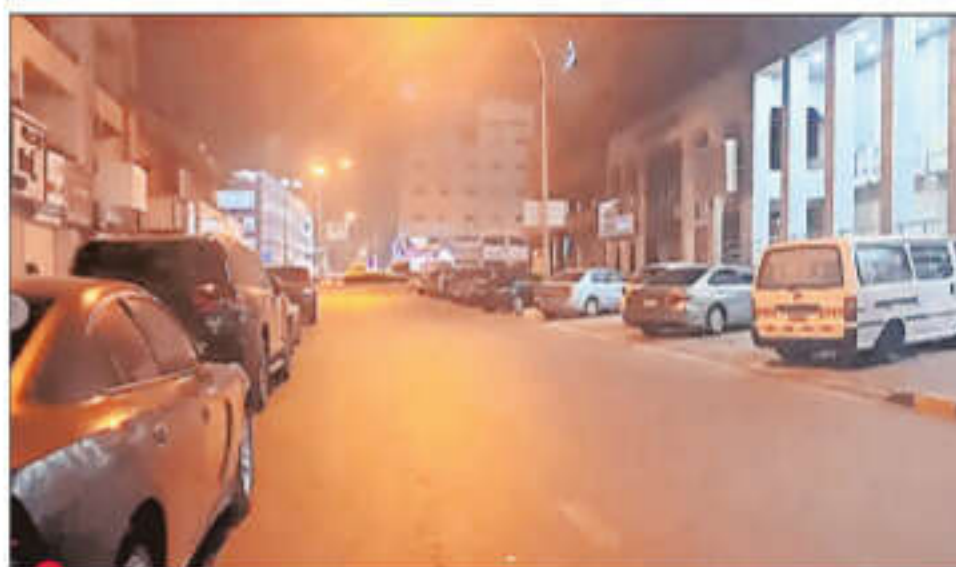
Israel said on Sunday it had struck Iran-backed armed Hezbollah militants in Lebanon on Saturday, just a day after it agreed to the latest ceasefire deal with Lebanon to calm

THE WORLD PAGE 14

TRUMP PRESSES SYRIA TO TAKE ON HEZBOLLAH; ISRAEL ALARMED

fighting that Iran says must end if the wider agreement is to stick.

The US military said earlier it had struck Iran again, hours after a tanker was hit in the Strait of Hormuz, the world's most important energy shipping route, which Tehran has



Sirens sounded in Kuwait City early Sunday after Kuwait said Iran had fired drones and missiles. AP

largely closed for most of the conflict. "There may come a point when we are no longer able to be reasonable, and will be forced to militarily complete the job that we very success-

fully started," Trump said on social media. "If that happens, the Islamic Republic of Iran will no longer exist!" he added.

The 14-point interim peace accord was meant to halt the

fighting, which the US and Israel started on February 28, and reopen the strait while talks proceeded on issues such as Iran's nuclear programme.

One round of mediated talks, led by US Vice President JD Vance and Iran's Parliamentary Speaker Mohammad Baqer Qalibaf, was held in Switzerland a week ago and Washington waived sanctions on Tehran, but fighting has since resumed and intensified.

About an hour after Trump's post, Kuwait's army said its air defences were responding to missile and drone attacks, while Bahrain said sirens had sounded there. Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps said in a statement its Navy and Air Force had

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

MODI AWARDED 'GUARDIAN OF THE BLUE HORIZON' TITLE BY SEYCHELLES



PM Narendra Modi with Speaker Azarel Ernesta at the National Assembly of Seychelles in Victoria, Sunday. ANI [RELATED REPORT, P 6](#)

Indian Ocean links India, Seychelles... want to make it ocean of opportunity: PM

In address to National Assembly, Modi calls for 'climate justice' for Global South

Divya A
New Delhi, June 28

INDIA ENVISIONS an Indian Ocean where maritime security is ensured alongside economic prosperity and where partnership is not based on size, but on mutual respect and trust, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who is on a three-day visit to Seychelles, said on Sunday.

"Our vision is to make the Indian Ocean an Ocean of Opportunity," he said, after delegation-level talks with Seychelles President Patrick Herminie, during which the two sides re-

Business as Usual
By EP UNNY



viewed the full spectrum of bilateral cooperation and exchanged views on regional and international issues of mutual interest, including challenges in the Indian Ocean Region like illegal fishing, drug trafficking and piracy.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Police personnel conduct a search operation at the residence of one of the arrested accused in Ayodhya, Uttar Pradesh, Sunday. PTI

Ram temple donation 'theft': Police search houses of 8 arrested men in Ayodhya

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, June 28

TWO DAYS after arresting eight people on allegations of theft and embezzlement of funds and valuables donated to the Ram temple in Ayodhya, police on Sunday carried out searches at the residences of all eight accused, who are currently in judicial custody.

"The searches were carried out as part of the investigation to gather evidence," a senior police officer said.

This came a day before the accused, identified as Avinash Shukla, Lavkush Mishra, Anukalp Mishra, Manish Kumar Yadav, Karunesh Pandey, Ramashankar Mishra, Ram Shankar Yadav alias Tinnu Yadav, and Subhash Srivastav, were due to be produced before the

POLITICS PAGE 6

TIME TO TALK ABOUT MATHURA, SAYS YOGI AMID AKHILESH BID TO CORNER BJP

court after their three-day judicial custody. Police said they had previously recovered Rs 79.8 lakh from seven of the eight arrested men during the course of the investigation.

On Sunday, eight police teams searched the premises where the accused had been living in Ayodhya. Police teams verified their addresses before carrying out the searches.

They first reached the residence of the main accused,

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NATION PAGE 9

RAIN HAVOC: RAIL BRIDGE COLLAPSES IN ASSAM, FLOODS IN ARUNACHAL

EXPRESS special

LUCKNOW TO GORAKHPUR: A TALE OF FIVE CITIES, THE YEAR BEFORE POLLS

Echoes from UP in wake of test, retest, protest: Hum kattar Bhajpai hain par...

Support for Yogi's 'tight prashasan' even as murmurs among party faithful on prices, jobs, 'mahaul' of fear; but Opposition yet to find resonance

Vandita Mishra
Lucknow, Kanpur, Prayagraj, Varanasi, Gorakhpur, June 28

TRAVELLING ACROSS Uttar Pradesh earlier this month, from Lucknow to Gorakhpur through five cities, is to bump up repeatedly against people's discontents.

Months ahead of the assembly election, notwithstanding the downsizing of the BJP tally in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, UP remains a state for the

three-term-Modi-two-term-Yogi BJP to lose, more than for the SP-led Opposition to win. But listen carefully, and there are newly audible murmurs on the ground of BJP vs BJP.

Anxieties touched off by the NEET cancellation-retest among students, their families and a penumbra of empathetic others, have joined with long-playing insecurities due to the recurring irregularity-leak-cancellation-delay syndrome in state-held exams in UP.

Spiralling prices exacer-



A protest against NEET-UG leak in Lucknow on June 12. VISHAL SRIVASTAV

bated by a distant war are pressing down more heavily upon household budgets, forcing large numbers at lower ends of the caste and class echelons to make sapping either-or

choices. Many speak of shrinking opportunities, defined in an economy beset with uncertainties as jobs that are secure and "sarkari".

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 8

BEAT UZBEKISTAN 3-1; QUALIFY FOR ROUND OF 32 FOR FIRST TIME

The night of No. 20: Wissa power propels Congo into knockouts



Sandip G
Boston, June 28

THE CONGO fans, attired in traditional *kanzaku* and leopard-printed hats, perhaps knew that it was their night. They had stocked adequate No. 20 jerseys too — for they knew that if it was to be their night, it also had



Yoane Wissa scored twice against Uzbekistan, Saturday. AP

to be Yoane Wissa's. It played out to the perfect script as Wissa pinched a brace

to complete a stirring comeback against Uzbekistan on

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'We do not want the anti-defection law to be misused by either side'

P P CHAUDHARY
SENIOR ADVOCATE AND BJP MP
PAGE 16

● RESIDENTS IN CHHATTISGARH VILLAGE STRUGGLED TO EXPLAIN A STRING OF SUDDEN DEATHS BEFORE ONE SURVIVOR TRIGGERED POLICE PROBE

They thought the Gods were angry; then a village joined dots between 8 murders

Jayprakash S Naidu
Baloda Bazar, June 28

IN FEBRUARY, 58-year-old Badri Patel was found motionless on a cot in his courtyard, dead before his family could take him to a hospital. In March, 59-year-old former sarpanch Chhatuam Sahu complained of queasiness while overseeing funerary preparations and collapsed. Later that month, 38-year-old Vinod Sahu was found slumped in his house.

These were three of the eight deaths that Kharve in Chhattisgarh's Baloda Bazar district — a village of 1,000

people — has seen over the last four months. They all had one thing in common — they went drinking with Ramsahay Jaiswal, a local grocery shop owner who was arrested on June 22 for the deaths of all eight people.

According to investigators, no postmortem were conducted because the deaths were initially believed to be due to natural causes.

On June 22, police arrested 46-year-old Ramsahay for the eight killings allegedly committed between February and May. Police allege Ramsahay laced bottles of locally brewed alcohol with a potent rat poison called *Suhaga*,



(Clockwise from left) Accused Ramsahay Jaiswal; the eight dead — Badri Patel, Butlu Ram Sahu, Chaturam Sahu, Budhram Jaiswal, Vinod Sahu, Gajanan Manjhi, Chaituram Sahu and Mahetru Sahu

killing unsuspecting victims within 15 minutes of consumption. Most victims were in their 50s and were allegedly regular

drinking companions whom investigators say he targeted over accumulated slights — from trivial personal disputes

to property troubles.

For a village that sees few crimes — and fewer heinous ones — the murders came as a

massive shock.

The killings have now settled in every corner of the village — it hangs about the peepal tree that is the village meeting point, slipping into everyday tasks, conversations and silences. "We felt the gods were angry with us," says Bagram Sahu, son of Butlu Ram Sahu, one of the victims.

The deaths that shook the village

Situated next to the river Mahanadi, Kharve is divided into old and new Kharve, with a peepal tree forming the central part of the village. Surrounded by numerous multi-storeyed brick-and-mortar houses, the

circular concrete platform around it forms the village's centre, where all village roads lead: it's where friends meet, exchange news and make promises. It is also here, right next to the tree, that Ramsahay ran his grocery shop.

According to investigators, most deaths went undetected because they were put down to natural causes, sometimes by doctors.

It began on February 7 with 58-year-old Patel. That evening, Patel had gone drinking with Ramsahay — as he had done many times before — and returned home at 9 pm. When his daughter found him two hours later, he was lying motionless

on his cot in the courtyard.

Doctors put it down to a heart attack. "My father and Ramsahay were childhood friends. My father used to keep money with Ramsahay for safe-keeping and asked for it whenever he needed it. Even now I don't know why he did it," his son Vikram, a mason who works in Jammu, says.

Over the next few weeks, three others followed: 60-year-old Butlu Ram Sahu on February 20, 59-year-old Chhatuam Sahu on March 2, and 60-year-old Budhram Jaiswal on March 12.

Former sarpanch Chhatuam, too, had drinks with Ramsahay. "He had not been staying

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

JHARKHAND

100 schoolgirls fall ill after drinking water kept in plastic tank, three suspended



Officials visit the hospital where the schoolgirls were taken for treatment, in Jharkhand's Garhwa district.

Shubham Tigga
Ranchi, June 28

MORE THAN 100 girls studying at the Residential Girls' School in Kharaulndhi block of Jharkhand's Garhwa district fell ill after allegedly drinking water from the overhead storage tank, leading to the suspension of the warden, a teacher and a cook.

The incident occurred on Friday at the Kasturba Gandhi Balika Vidyalaya (KGBV), which has 300 girls. According to the district administration, around 100 students were affected and rushed to hospital. The DC said six girls remained under observation on Saturday and were in stable condition, while the others had been discharged.

Kharaulndhi Block Pramukh Abha Rani, who visited the school and hospital, alleged that students had repeatedly complained about poor food and inadequate water facilities. "As a result, many girls were forced to drink hot water stored in the overhead plastic tank during the day's intense heat," she said.

Soon, students began complaining of stomach ache, vomiting, dizziness and weakness.

CHHINDWARA, MP

Woman gives birth while being carried on cot across river, video goes viral

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, June 28

A WOMAN gave birth while being carried on a cot across a river in Madhya Pradesh's Chhindwara district after ambulances failed to reach her remote hamlet, with local residents saying the area remains cut off during the rainy season as repeated demands for a bridge and a proper road have not been met.

The incident took place in the Lohri Mohalla area of Hathoda Hiri village in Amarwara block, where around 20 families remain cut off during the monsoon as the only approach road is interrupted by a rain-fed river. A video of villagers carrying the woman on a cot through the river surfaced on Sunday, drawing attention to the hardships faced by residents of the area.

According to the family, 35-year-old Savita Vishwakarma, wife of Shankar Vishwakarma, developed labour pains on Wednesday evening. Her relatives immediately called the 108 ambulance service, but the vehicle could not reach the hamlet because of the swollen river.

With no other option, family members and villagers placed her on a cot and started carrying her across the river on foot. During the crossing, her labour pain intensified, and she delivered the baby on the cot itself.

Villagers then managed to take the mother and newborn across the river and waited for an ambulance. However, when no ambulance arrived even after a long wait, they transported both on a motorcycle to Amarwara Civil Hospital. Hospital authorities said both the mother and child are healthy.

Gopal Vishwakarma, the woman's brother-in-law, said the village remains inaccessible every monsoon because vehicles cannot cross the river.

"My sister-in-law was in severe labour pain. We called an ambulance, but during the rain, no vehicle can reach our

hamlet because of the river. We had no choice but to carry her on a cot. While crossing the river, she delivered the baby on the way," he said.

He claimed that villagers have repeatedly appealed for a bridge and an all-weather road, but their demands have gone unheard.

"Such situations arise every monsoon. We have repeatedly demanded a bridge and a proper road, but neither officials nor public representatives have paid attention. School-children also have to cross the river every day. We have submitted complaints to the Janpad Panchayat, the SDM and informed elected representatives, but nobody has taken any action," Vishwakarma said.

Residents said the absence of a bridge means emergency services, including ambulances, are unable to reach the settlement during the rainy season, forcing patients to be carried manually across the river.

Responding to the incident, officials at the Amarwara Civil Hospital said the Health Department had no immediate information on why the ambulance failed to reach the patient.

"We do not know why the ambulance could not reach the pregnant woman on time. The 108 ambulance service is operated from the Bhopal control room. The mother and newborn have reached our hospital, and both are healthy," said a health official.

The incident has once again highlighted the challenges of last-mile healthcare delivery in remote parts of Madhya Pradesh. While emergency ambulance services have expanded across the state, inaccessible roads continue to prevent timely medical assistance in several villages, particularly during the monsoon.

Following the incident, villagers renewed their demand for the immediate construction of a bridge and an all-weather road, saying the lack of basic infrastructure continues to put lives at risk every rainy season.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

US-Iran

launched missile and drone operations targeting US military sites in Kuwait and Bahrain.

The Guards said US strikes had violated the ceasefire and "will result in the complete halt of all diplomatic processes", state-run *Press TV* said. The IRGC Navy command said American bases in the region "will experience hell in the coming days". A US official, confirming Iran had targeted US facilities, told *Reuters* there were no reported US casualties or major damage to US sites in the Middle East but the situation was still unfolding.

Hours later, alarms sounded for a second time in Bahrain, where authorities said an Iranian attack damaged a residential building in Muharraq province, with no casualties reported. Bahrain urged the UN Security Council to hold an urgent session to hold Iran accountable.

The Kuwaiti Army said it had intercepted two ballistic missiles with no damage or casualties. Separately, Qatar said one of its nationals had died after sustaining injuries from shrapnel aboard a vessel that had gone missing on Saturday. A second person was injured in the inci-

dent, which was due to "military operations in the area", the interior ministry said, without giving a location or apportioning blame.

US Central Command said its forces had carried out the new strikes after a Panama-flagged tanker was attacked by an Iranian drone on Saturday. "Iran was given a chance to honor the ceasefire agreement but elected not to," Central Command said in a statement. US strikes were "in direct response to continued Iranian aggression against commercial shipping" and targeted Iranian military surveillance, communications, air defence, drone storage and mine-laying facilities, it said.

Explosions were heard in Sirik in southern Iran, Iranian state broadcaster IIRB said without providing details. The Guards said, "America's blind shots at Sirik will not resolve our dominance over the Strait of Hormuz. But our shots at violators will remind the rest of the vessels of the clear passage route."

Saturday's tanker attack in the strait followed one on a cargo ship on Thursday that triggered the latest escalation. Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araqchi said responsibility for returning maritime traffic in the strait to pre-war levels lay solely with

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Eight murders

in the village and had come back for Butlu Sahu's funeral. He went for a drink with Ramsahay, then went to oversee food preparations for the funeral when he felt queasy. He lay down and was dead by the time we took him to the hospital," his 29-year-old son Harish says.

It wasn't until Vinod Sahu's death on March 31 that concerns began to grow. His family says that morning, 38-year-old Vinod headed to the Mahanadi for a bath — his usual morning routine — and later went drinking with Ramsahay. He died at home 15 minutes later.

"We later learnt that Vinod told someone that he had bought desi liquor for Ramsahay that morning and they had plans to share it," his brother Pramod Sahu, a lawyer, says.

For the village, 38-year-old Vinod's passing was particularly concerning. Unlike the others before him, Vinod was relatively young and healthy. "We felt so many deaths in the village was a bad omen," Dilharan Jaiswal, a former sarpanch and Ramsahay's neighbour, says. "In April, we consulted a *baiga* (local priest) and a *gunia* (traditional healer who also practises omen reading) in our village and conducted poojas on two occasions."

In the following weeks, two more died in quick succession — 55-year-old Gajanan Manjhi on April 28 and 59-year-old Chaitram Sahu on April 30 — and even though it disturbed them, villagers didn't think to link the deaths.

Then Mahetru Sahu died, and the village finally realised something was wrong.

The turning point

When he died on the morning of May 14, 40-year-old Mahetru was perfectly healthy and had headed down to the river to bathe.

"Someone saw him speaking with Ramsahay. He drank alcohol and left to take a bath in the

river. Minutes later he collapsed by the river," his son Divyanshu says.

The death rattled the village, and discussions began under the tree. It was then that they learnt something startling: a few days earlier, one of them, 23-year-old daily wager Kartik Kumhar, had fallen ill after drinking liquor Ramsahay had offered.

"I came home in the middle of the day and asked my friend Pramod Sahu if he had any liquor. He said he had half a bottle of liquor that Ramsahay had given him. I drank that, and within 20 seconds I vomited and fainted, regaining consciousness only 5-6 hours later," he says.

Alarmed by the story, villagers began joining the dots. On June 6 — some 20 days after Mahetru's death — they filed a police complaint naming Ramsahay. Eight FIRs were registered later in the month.

Those who knew Ramsahay paint a very different picture: an affable, social and god-fearing man who made friends easily and got along with everyone. Short, thin and haggard, the 46-year-old Ramsahay was the youngest of eight siblings — four brothers and four sisters — and belonged to a well-respected, landed family.

A Class 7 dropout, Ramsahay has two sons — one running another grocery shop after graduation and the second still studying in college. Ramsahay's was the first grocery shop in the village, residents say.

The sons could not be contacted for a response. But his brother says the family is shocked by the allegations.

"Our father died when Ramsahay was a child, and our mother five years ago. He was always helpful, and no one ever said no to him. Fifteen years ago, he built two small temples in the village. We're all shocked. We kept asking him to tell us the truth, but he kept pleading his innocence," his brother Shiv-

Tehran and urged others not to intervene "in Iran's administration of the strait".

Washington has been promoting a southern lane along the coast of Oman, while Tehran, which ultimately aims to charge fees for use of the strait, wants ships to use a northern route through its waters and under its control.

Hundreds of ships stranded in the strait, including tankers laden with oil, began leaving over the past two weeks, sending oil prices back close to pre-war levels. Even as attacks continued on Sunday morning, CMA CGM's Galapagos container ship exited the strait in what the shipping giant called "an important milestone in a regional context".

In Lebanon, Israel said on Sunday it had killed Hezbollah militants armed with rocket-propelled grenades and struck a rocket launcher in the Nabatieh area. There was no immediate response from Hezbollah.

Israel, which is not a party to the US-Iran deal, and Lebanon have repeatedly agreed to US-brokered ceasefires, the latest on Friday. But these have had limited effect, with Israel insisting it will not withdraw from Lebanese territory it has seized and Hezbollah rejecting calls to give up its arms as long as Israeli troops remain in place. **REUTERS**

charan says.

Villagers say it wasn't unusual to see him sharing drinks or chatting with neighbours late into the evening. But while he was seemingly friendly, some also recall how he cut people off over disagreements.

"He used to drink beer with me. But ever since I opened a grocery shop right next to him, he's stopped talking to me," former sarpanch Dilharan says.

The villagers' complaint prompted police to take a closer look at the deaths. Ramsahay was arrested on June 22.

Investigators say Ramsahay offered his victims a locally made liquor called Goa, sold at Rs 120 a bottle. He would allegedly lace it with rat poison before offering it to unsuspecting victims, sometimes for free.

"We have strong circumstantial evidence in the case," Deputy Superintendent of Police Kaushal Wasnik says. "We are also depending on forensic evidence. After exhuming the bodies of seven victims, samples were taken by forensic experts and sent to the Forensic Science Laboratory [FSL] to see if traces of Suhaga are found in them."

Investigators claim the alleged motives varied from personal taunts and jibes to land disputes, suspicion of occult practices and, in at least one case, an unpaid loan. In at least one case, the poison allegedly went to unintended victims.

"After questioning, we found out that the accused held grudges over petty things," one officer says. "He also believes he's done much for the village but has never been given the respect he deserved."

Back in the village, Ramsahay's family has since left. Life has returned to its staid pace: villagers continue to gather under the large peepal tree for their evening gossip, and children play next to Ramsahay's padlocked home and shop.

But beneath the seeming normality, undercurrents of tension lie. "Nobody wants to talk about Ramsahay anymore," Kishan Sahu, a villager sitting by the tree, says.

Seychelles

Addressing the National Assembly later in the day, Modi said the Global South, especially island nations, was the most impacted by climate change, and called for climate action guided by "fairness, responsibility and equity". He said those who had contributed the least to climate change should not bear the greatest burden of its consequences. "This is the essence of climate justice," he said.

Modi, the guest of honour for Seychelles' National Day celebrations, was also conferred the honorary 'Guardian of the Blue Horizon' title for his commitment to environmental conservation and sustainable development.

The key outcomes of talks between the two sides reflected the broadening of New Delhi's engagement with the strategically located Indian Ocean archipelagic nation, expanding cooperation across defence and maritime security to connectivity, capacity building, development partnership, digital payments, space, healthcare, agriculture and education.

"We believe the Indian Ocean is our shared home. Its security, sustainability and prosperity are our shared responsibility," Modi said after the talks. He said the two sides discussed making bilateral economic cooperation more resilient and future-ready.

"We will continue to explore new opportunities for the industries of both our countries. Work will also be done to enhance connectivity between India and Seychelles," he said.

In his statement, Herminie said: "As maritime neighbours, security in the Indian Ocean Region remains central to our relationship. We reaffirmed Seychelles' special place in India's Mahasagar vision. We affirmed our commitment to counter piracy, drug trafficking, illegal fishing, and cross-border crime."

He also acknowledged India's support in strengthening the country's maritime capabilities through surveillance, hydrography and defence capacity building.

"Development partnership

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First IBG next month

23 Division — by September. However, this is now learnt to have been advanced to July 1.

The Indian Express had first reported in January this year that the long-drawn plans to create IBGs had gathered pace and may be implemented soon.

According to the existing plans, four IBGs and a fire support group will be created under the XVII MSC. Each of the five will be commanded by a Major General rank officer. Each IBG will comprise over 5,000 troops, with 12-13 units, and may have a Brigadier-rank officer as the Chief Operations Officer.

While the four IBGs will be created from the two divisions of the XVII MSC, the fire support group comprising artillery platforms will likely operate directly under the corps headquarters. The newly created Divyastra batteries of the Army could be placed under this group.

Each IBG will have battalions of infantry, artillery regiments, as well as elements of the Corps of Electronics and Mech-

has been a strong pillar of India-Seychelles relations, guided by Seychelles' priorities. I was especially pleased to pursue discussions on the announcement of the Special Economic Package of \$175 million (Rs 1,651 crore) from the Government of India, comprising \$125 million in a rupee-denominated Line of Credit and \$50 million in grant assistance," Herminie said.

In his address to the National Assembly later in the day, Modi again underlined the shared vision regarding the security and sustainability of the Indian Ocean, affirming that it "connects" the two countries.

Calling it his "special honour" to be the first Indian PM to address the Assembly, he said: "The Indian Ocean does not separate India and Seychelles. It connects us. That is why we meet not as strangers, but as old friends."

"As maritime neighbours, we recognise that the security of one adds to the security of the other. The prosperity of one contributes to the prosperity of the other. The stability of the region benefits us all," he said. "Our cooperation in maritime security and capacity building reflects our shared commitment to a safer and more secure Indian Ocean Region," he added.

He said the Global South, especially island nations, was bearing the brunt of climate change, as he underlined the need for equitable climate action. "The Global South, and especially the island nations, are the most impacted by climate change. Its effects are already visible on our coastlines, in the marine ecosystem, in weather patterns, and in our communities," he said.

He further said that India and Seychelles shared the vision of a world where development was more inclusive and reaffirmed their commitment to advancing the interests of the Global South. "This is the spirit that unites the Global South. And this is the vision that India and Seychelles will continue to advance together," he said.

"The connections between our cultures are visible in everyday life. They can be felt in the flavours of kharik, samosa and chutney. They can be found in the celebrations of Deepavali, Thai Pongal, and the garba

dance during Navratri. This is the Creole spirit that gives us great confidence in the future of our friendship," Modi said.

Noting that Seychelles' maritime territory is spread over 1.4 million square kilometres of the western Indian Ocean, Modi said this makes it "not a small island State but a large ocean country."

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said the outcomes of the talks between the two sides included an extradition treaty aimed at strengthening cross-border crime cooperation, an agreement on cooperation in the peaceful uses of outer space, an agreement to advance UPI-based digital payments in Seychelles, an umbrella line of credit agreement with the Export-Import Bank of India, and an agreement for preliminary preparations for a new Seychelles National Hospital.

Responding to a question at a media briefing on speculation over India's role on Assumption Island, Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri said the issue was not specifically discussed. But, he said, India would be "open to hearing about this" should Seychelles government officials raise the matter.

"Any project that we undertake in Seychelles or for that matter any foreign country, is ultimately guided by the priorities and the interests of the host government and the authorities in the host country," he said.

The two sides also announced the gifting of a fast patrol vessel to Seychelles, the handover of 10 utility vehicles and five Laser Radial class boats to the Seychelles Defence Force, the completion of the refit of PS Zoroaster for the Seychelles Coast Guard and the upgradation of a Dornier aircraft with a glass cockpit.

Other development initiatives included the handover of six ambulances, 500 metric tonnes of rice and 8,500 metric tonnes of cement, the launch of a commemorative logo marking 50 years of diplomatic relations and the virtual ground-breaking ceremony for a Professional and Technical Education Centre, the MEA said on X.

Meanwhile, Leader of Opposition of Seychelles, Bernard Georges, also called on Modi.

and defensive roles against an adversary's attack.

The concept was test-bedded at the IX Corps on the western border with Pakistan around 2019, but remains to be implemented. The IBG concept was also experimented with multiple exercises conducted in the eastern theatre, including Exercise Him Vijay in 2019.

The IBGs can be rapidly deployed in the mountainous areas, thus reducing the time for an entire corps to mobilise. A corps comprises up to a lakh troops and takes a longer time to get deployed.

Sources had earlier indicated that the strength of an IBG lies in its swift application and flexible nature, and its creation would ensure better cohesiveness for various combined arms operations. Once established, they can also be deployed under specific theatre commands.

Over the last decade, China, too, has transitioned from older divisions to smaller, more versatile Combined Arms Brigades (CABs), integrated with tanks, artillery, air defence and support units, designed for joint operations.

Ayodhya

Tinnu Yadav, who worked as a driver for Champat Rai. Rai had recently stepped down as general secretary of the Shri Ram Jambhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust.

Another accused, Srivastav, a retired bank employee, reportedly supervised donation-counting shifts in the temple's Pilgrim Facility Centre. The other six accused counted the cash and valuables offered by devotees.

During Sunday's searches, which continued till evening, police sources said they seized a number of documents from the homes of the accused. While declining to reveal the nature of the documents, a senior police officer said the documents would now be examined to assess their relevance to the investigation and their potential evidentiary value.

"If the documents are found to have relevance to the allegations under investigation, they will form part of the case record, and further action will be taken accordingly," the officer said.

Smart buildings that alert the Fire Control Room even before someone can dial the fire helpline number 101.

Artificial intelligence systems that identify and dispatch the nearest available fire truck to the location within seconds.

Drones that stream live visuals to fire-fighters as they race to the scene.

These are among the proposals in a 25-year roadmap drawn up by the Delhi Fire Services (DFS), a blueprint for the future of firefighting in the Capital that calls for a significant expansion in the number of fire stations, and the recruitment of more than 25,000 additional personnel over the next quarter century.

The plan has been drawn up in response to the rapid and continuous expansion of the city, its changing lifestyles, the use of modern construction material that often overlooks fire safety considerations, and increasingly complex building designs which have stretched the DFS's ability to respond to emergencies – even as the numbers of fire incidents and emergency calls continue to rise every year. (See table)

According to the DFS, the changing nature of fires has exposed critical gaps in infrastructure, manpower, communication systems and emergency response — shortcomings that the department says call for a unified, technology-driven, fire safety framework for the capital.

“The changing nature of fire emergencies necessitates a paradigm shift in the functioning of the fire service,” the document states. The roadmap, it says, seeks to move the DFS from a largely reactive fire-fighting system to one that is centred on prevention and early detection of fires.

Three tragedies, one reckoning

The plan was prepared in the aftermath of the Palam, Vivek Vihar, and Malviya Nagar fires, which together claimed more than four dozen lives in March, May, and June this year, and laid bare serious gaps in Delhi's emergency response system, officials said. The 23-page blueprint, accessed by *The Indian Express*, was drawn up after Chief Minister Rekha Gupta directed relevant government departments to formulate a long-term firefighting master plan to tackle similar incidents in the future.

The document has proposed a series of measures aimed at cutting casualties and building a faster, technology-driven emergency response system — they include mandatory smoke detectors and sprinkler systems, drones for fire assessment, Internet of Things (IoT)-enabled fire alerts, an expanded network of fire stations, specialised response units, a massive modernisation of equipment, and large-scale recruitment of Fire personnel.

DFS officials said the plan has been submitted with timelines of five, 10, 15, and 25 years, aimed at bringing Delhi's fire and emergency response up to “an advanced, global standard”.

A city outgrowing its fire cover

At the heart of the plan is a stark reckoning: For its size, the capital of India simply does not have enough fire stations.

Delhi is currently served by 71 fire stations, a third short of the requirement of 107 identified by the global tech solutions company RMSI in a 2011 risk analysis commissioned by the Union Ministry of Home Affairs. The firefighting master plan has proposed that the number of fire stations be raised to 100 by 2030, 120 by 2032, and to 196 by 2051, with 49 new stations coming up in the first six years alone, followed by four a year over the rest of the 25-year horizon.

The document envisages a response time of five minutes, even though it concedes that given the pace of the city's growth, “achieving [that]...continues to remain a distant goal”. The more immediate aim, officials said, is to bring the average response time down from the current 12-15 minutes to under seven minutes in congested areas.

The numbers behind the crisis

DFS data show the scale of the challenge. Emergency calls have jumped 135 per cent over the past two decades, from 15,718 in 2007-08 to 36,877 in 2025-26. Annual casualties have climbed even faster — up 4.2 times, from 351 to about 1,480 over the same period.

Most fire deaths, the document notes, occur from smoke inhalation within the first three to five minutes of an incident — a survival window that has shrunk in recent years because of changing building designs, the spread of modern construction materials and interior finishes, and contemporary living styles. Reducing fire incidents in the capital by 2030 is listed as a key objective of the plan.

An undermanned, overstretched force

The manpower numbers are perhaps the most alarming presented in the plan. The DFS has projected a need for 9,223 additional personnel over the next three years simply to roll out the long-pending “1+1” duty system — 24 hours on duty, 24 hours off — across its 71 existing stations.

Under the present arrangement, operational staff work 24-hour shifts followed by 24 hours off, while officers do 72 hours on duty for every 24 off, the document notes.

According to the department's own assessment, its current sanctioned strength of 3,051 personnel is barely a quarter of the



THE NEXT 25 YEARS

DELHI'S NEW FIREFIGHTING PLAN

A 23-page blueprint accessed by *The Indian Express* acknowledges that the Capital's unplanned growth has outpaced its firefighting capacity. It charts a 25-year fix — built around AI dispatch, drones, and a near-tripling of fire stations, reports Gayathri Mani

Delhi Fire Services' Expansion Plan

Key Objectives

CUTTING average response time in congested areas from 12-15 mins to less than 7 mins.

REDUCING fire deaths, most of which occur due to smoke inhalation within 3-5 mins.

BRINGING DOWN incidents of industrial and residential fires.

EXPANDING fire station network to 100 stations by 2030 to match Delhi's growing population and urban density.

STRENGTHENING fire safety by making smoke detectors and automatic sprinklers mandatory in new buildings this year; in existing buildings by 2030. Higher fire loads traced to modern interiors, synthetic furnishings and upholstery, toxic smoke.

PIVOTING to preventive deployment from reactive response through use of data-driven planning; aim to reduce major ('Make-6'-level and above) fires.

INTEGRATING automated fire detection at Fire Control Room with nearest fire station to cut delays in manual reporting.



12,274 required to run the proposed duty pattern without interruption — a roughly three-fold shortfall that would make this one of the largest recruitment drives ever proposed for the city's fire services. The gap is the widest among fire operators, the personnel who drive and operate fire engines, ladder trucks, and specialized rescue equipment — the DFS needs 9,553 of them but has only 2,367, leaving a shortfall of 7,186.

Wiring buildings to the Fire Brigade

A central plank of the long-term plan is to connect buildings directly to the Fire Control Room. Under a proposed IoT-based smart building integration system, to be rolled out over the next five to 10 years, buildings fitted with smoke detectors, sprinklers and hydrant systems would be linked to the Control Room through web-based technology — enabling real-time monitoring, faster alerts, and continuous health-checks on a building's fire safety systems to catch faults early.

The DFS has also proposed to make smoke detectors and automatic sprinkler systems mandatory in all upcoming buildings by 2026, and in all existing buildings by 2030.

“Valuable response time is often lost be-

tween the occurrence of a fire and its detection by occupants or observers, resulting in delayed reporting...and slower mobilisation,” the plan notes, arguing that a shift to automated detection and communication can sharply cut this delay.

Closer to the present, the DFS is upgrading its main Fire Control Room and equipping fire engines with Mobile Data Terminals for faster, real-time transmission of incident details — a modernisation drive officials say is already under way and expected to be completed within the current financial year. Looking further out, the plan envisages each of the DFS's operational divisions getting its own fully automated Fire Control Room within 15 years, working in tandem with the main control room to create a decentralised but integrated communication network across the city.

Drones, dead zones and a broken radio network

The 15-year plan also proposes inducting drones into the firefighting fleet, with live aerial feeds beamed directly to the Fire Control Room — giving senior officers a real-time view of how a fire is spreading, where the vulnerable zones are, and how best to deploy resources on the ground.

That vision contrasts starkly with the Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1



Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

DFS's account of its present-day communication network, which the document describes in unflattering terms. Fire stations in the outer parts of the city have become “virtual dead zones”, it says, with little or no wireless coverage, severely hampering co-ordination during emergencies.

The department currently relies on a patchwork of mobile and static wireless sets, hand-held walkie-talkies, towers and repeaters — of which, the DFS says, only one repeater is fully functional.

“The present arrangement suffers from signal obstruction, inadequate coverage in high-rise and basement structures, dependency on outdated analog systems, and the absence of resilient disaster communication capability,” the document states.

The fleet, the phases, and a new address

The plan also envisages a stronger first-response fleet. Quick Response Vehicles (QRVs), built for rapid initial response, especially in dense, congested neighbourhoods, are to be doubled from 100 to 200 by 2032, growing by 10 vehicles a year thereafter as a dedicated QRV wing.

The 25-year roadmap itself is broken into four phases: rapid expansion in the first five years; consolidation and upgradation over

Hands on hoses, boots on ground, next 25 years

Building Muscle 2026

3,051 personnel	191 fire appliances (145 pumping units, 46 specialised units)	100 Quick Response Vehicles (QRVs)
71 fire stations		
20 firefighting motorcycles	35 Command & Control Vehicles (CCVs)	



NEXT 3 YEARS

9,223 posts to be filled | 368 fire appliances
● Shortage of pumping units; aerial ladders; hydraulic platforms; rescue, Hazmat and command vehicles to be addressed

BY 2032

120 fire stations (49 new)	200 QRVs
960 fire appliances (720 pumping units, 240 specialised units)	130 firefighting motorcycles /e-bikes
	404 CCVs

2032 ONWARDS

4 new fire stations a year, based on projected annual addition of 10 lakh to population

BY 2041

156 fire stations	290 QRVs
1,248 fire appliances	175 firefighting motorcycles/e-bikes

BY 2051

28,783 personnel	390 QRVs
196 fire stations	225 firefighting motorcycles/e-bikes
1,568 fire appliances (1,176 pumping units, 392 specialised units)	8-HR, 3-SHIFT workdays eventually

the next five; optimisation and specialisation between years 11 and 15; and, in the final phase, the development of modern, GIS-enabled emergency hubs.

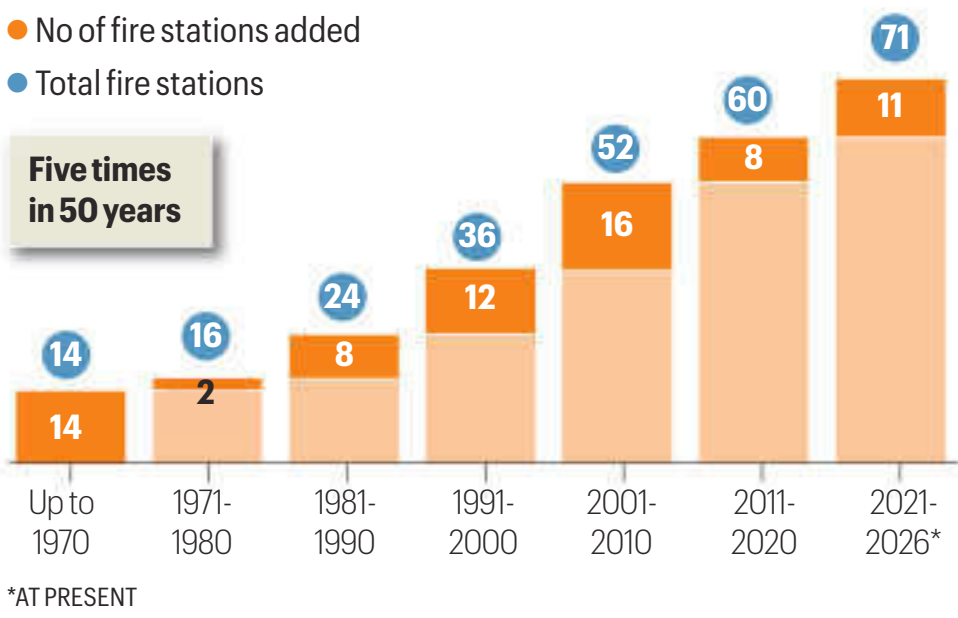
To find space for the new stations, the DFS has approached the DDA, the PWD and the Revenue Department for land, and has separately proposed a new headquarters at Connaught Place, to be built through NBCC — a proposal that will go before the Cabinet on its own.

Delhi Home Minister Ashish Sood, who attended a high-level meeting chaired by the Chief Minister after the Palam and Vivek Vihar fires, said the government planned to strengthen the DFS over the next 25 years “with modern machinery and advanced firefighting equipment”.

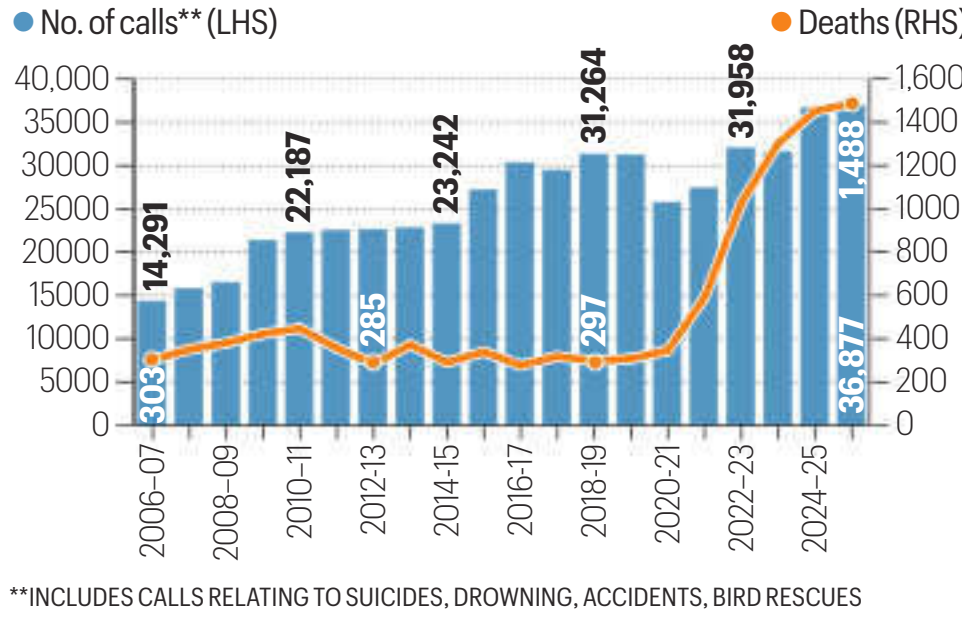
Asked about the plan, Sood said: “We have received the draft firefighting master plan from the DFS and are examining it.”

A senior DFS official said the department had been specifically asked to draw up a fire master plan for the next 25 years. “DFS has prepared a roadmap for strengthening the Delhi Fire Service to meet the immediate demands of fire emergency response and long-term plans for 10, 15 and 25 years. The report has been submitted to the Home department and the government,” the official said.

• Number of fire stations (1970-Present)



• Number of calls (2006-07-Present)



4-yr-old dies after falling from 10th floor in Govindpuri

New Delhi: A four-year-old girl died after allegedly falling from the 10th floor of Asha Kiran Apartments in South-East Delhi's Govindpuri area on Sunday, police said. A case has been filed and preliminary probe suggests that the girl might have fallen while playing. The police are yet to ascertain whether she fell from a balcony, a window, or if there was any other factor involved. Residents, however,

claimed that the girl might have fallen through the gap between the balcony grills. The family had recently moved into the apartment after being allotted the flat under the government's 'Jahan Jhuggi, Wahan Makaan' housing scheme. CCTV footage from the apartment complex is being examined, and statements of family members and neighbours are being recorded, an officer said. ENS

'INFLATED BILLS, MISSING FILES'

Former health services chief, ex-CPA official arrested in medical procurement scam

Alok Singh & Ankit Upadhyay New Delhi, June 28

X-RAY MACHINES at Rs 33 lakh each against an actual cost of around Rs 10 lakh, linen bedsheets at Rs 450 a piece against its original price of Rs 150, and ORS sachets at Rs 15 each against a market rate of around Rs 2.5 were among alleged procurements made by the Central Procurement Agency (CPA) under the Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS) earlier this year.

In connection with the alleged scam involving inflated procurement bills — that the Anti-Corruption Branch (ACB) has so far estimated to be worth around Rs 700 crore — the agency on Sunday arrested former DGHS Director, Dr Vatsala Aggarwal, and former Deputy Controller of Accounts (DCA), CPA, Neeraj Chopra, after they allegedly failed to provide “satisfactory explanations”. ACB officials also found that several files related to expenditure and procurement were “missing”.

The agency earlier on June 18 arrested Dr Vinod Kumar Ranga, former Head of Office of the CPA. Dr Ranga is currently in judicial custody.

According to official sources, around 10 more government officials associated with the CPA, whose names have surfaced during the investigation, are on the ACB's radar. Some have already been summoned for questioning. Besides, more than half a dozen individuals, including contrac-

• SIPHONING OF FUNDS, ILLICIT GAINS

PORTABLE X-RAY MACHINES Billed to the CPA at Rs 33 lakh each against a market price of around Rs 10 lakh per unit. The vigilance department estimates excess payment of around Rs 100 crore under this contract alone.

LINEN AND BEDSHEETS Retail price of hospital linen are estimated at around Rs 150 per piece. Vigilance department says the CPA paid Rs 450 per sheet through three linked suppliers. Rs 75 crore was allegedly paid in total against an estimated cost of only Rs 25 crore. The remaining amount was allegedly siphoned off.

C-ARM AND ANAESTHESIA WORKSTATIONS Vigilance department cited GeM bids for C-

arm units and anaesthesia workstations in which technical specifications were allegedly tailored to favour particular models. The equipment available in the market for only a few lakh rupees was invoiced to the CPA at several times the actual cost, resulting in alleged illicit gains worth crores

ORS AND SURGICAL CONSUMABLES 50 lakh ORS sachets were procured at Rs 15 each against a market price of about Rs 2.5 per sachet. Surgical dressings, sutures, cannulas and gloves were allegedly procured at highly inflated rates. The vigilance department says procurement worth around Rs 400 crore was made via hospital-level local chemist tenders. Funds worth nearly Rs 300 crore were diverted

tors and bidders, are also being questioned in connection with the alleged scam.

The alleged irregularities first came to light in May this year when the Delhi Directorate of Vigilance conducted raids at the CPA office over two nights following complaints regarding procurement tenders for medicines, surgical items and medical equipment. On June 2, acting on a complaint from the vigilance department, the ACB registered an FIR under provisions of the Prevention of Corruption Act.

According to the complaint, official sources said, Dr Ranga, a supplier-operator, several unidentified officials and private

persons allegedly operated a cartel that manipulated procurement by drafting tailor-made tender specifications, floating fake or front companies and submitting collusive bids to ensure favoured suppliers secured contracts at grossly inflated rates.

The complaint stated that the amount misappropriated could run into several hundred crores of rupees. It was also alleged that CPA officials repeatedly obstructed the vigilance department's attempts to obtain procurement-related files.

The vigilance department also alleged that manufacturers first agreed among themselves

to nominate specific distributors. These distributors allegedly drafted restrictive technical specifications and tender conditions suited to their nominees. According to sources, the complaint stated that the documents were then submitted to Dr Ranga and approved by DGHS officials.

The complaint further alleged that several companies were effectively controlled by a single distributor who was allegedly close to the officials under investigation. It also claimed that approvals were granted on the same day, financial bids were opened secretly, and purchase orders were issued without publishing contract awards on the Government e-Marketplace (GeM) or other e-procurement portals.

It was also alleged that the CPA deliberately kept the status of several tenders marked as 'Active' on procurement portals even after contracts had been awarded and payments released, thereby preventing competitors and the public from accessing the final contract details and rates, official sources said.

Sources also said that vigilance officers visited the CPA office on May 18 to collect procurement records only to find that key files were unavailable. CPA officials allegedly told them that the records were in the custody of Dr Ranga, who, they said, could not be contacted. Although the CPA later supplied some folders, vigilance officials found that the principal procurement files remained missing, sources added.

‘How can I stay silent’: Wangchuk on hunger strike at Jantar Mantar to back CJP causes

Express News Service New Delhi, June 28

PROMINENT ACTIVIST Sonam Wangchuk, along with six members of left-wing student group All India Students' Association (AISA), began a hunger strike at Jantar Mantar on Sunday, where the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) has been holding a protest since June 20, demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over alleged examination irregularities.

Wangchuk had also earlier joined the CJP's first protest held at Jantar Mantar on June 6. Before beginning his hunger strike, Wangchuk, along with CJP founder Abhi-jeet Dipke, visited Raighat and paid tribute to Mahatma Gandhi.

“I have been forced to sit here, I am not doing this happily. I am sitting on a fast in support of both issues. Many people ask me: You were doing a movement in Ladakh, why are you with CJP now?” Educa-



Sonam Wangchuk and (right) Abhiheet Dipke at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on Sunday. ABHINAV SAHA

tion, which is the issue here, has been close to my heart for the last 40 years, since I was a student,” Wangchuk said.

“I did engineering, but never took a job because I felt the key to all generations is in education. When some youth raise their voices on issues with the education system, how could I have remained silent? It was natural for me to support them,” Wangchuk added.

“When there is no accountability, we are forced to take the

only way possible in a democracy — peaceful protest, and we will do that,” he said.

He also appealed to people to make it a community hunger strike by observing at least a day-long fast.

He also pointed out that when a leader recognises their mistake, their stature does not become small or big. “They (leaders) become great,” he said. “I want to tell the government that if you are a leader of democracy, you should be

kind hearted and empathetic,” he said.

“There has to be accountability and someone should take responsibility,” he stated.

The development came days after Wangchuk posted a video on social media, stating that he would launch an indefinite hunger strike on June 28 at Jantar Mantar unless the government took action to address his demands for accountability in the education system and greater autonomy for Ladakh.

In the video, Wangchuk had said that he would wait until June 27 for progress on two issues: reforms in the education system or restoration of democratic and cultural protections in Ladakh.

If even one demand is addressed, he said, he would withdraw the plan to carry out a fast.

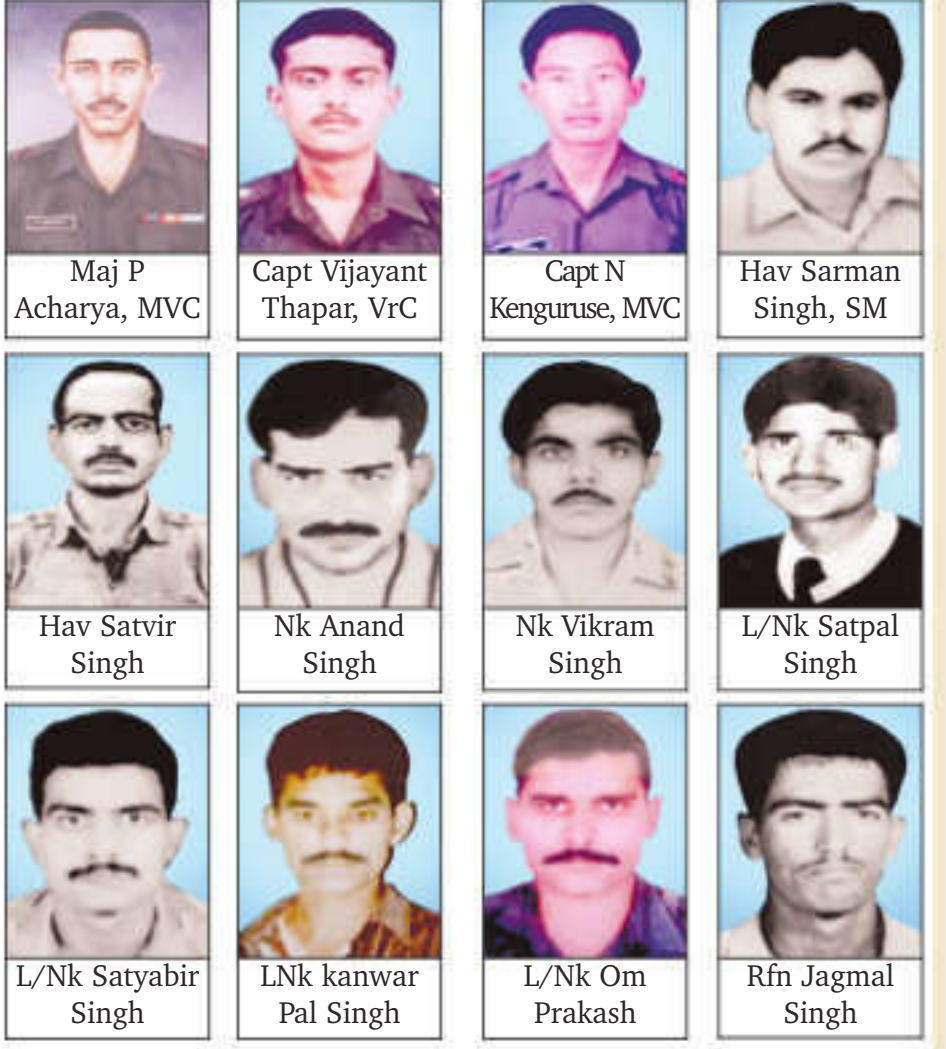
Meanwhile, the CJP protest at Jantar Mantar entered its ninth day on Sunday. This was despite the Delhi Police previously stating that the outfit only had permission to hold the protest till 5 pm on June 20.

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

29 JUN 2021 LEST WE FORGET

Twenty two years ago this day stood witness to the finest exhibition of bravery, valour and sacrifice in the history of Indian Army. On this day, during 'Op Vijay' the 2nd Battalion the Rajputana Rifles captured the area 'Black Rock' and 'Three Pimple' in the Drass (Kargil) sector which changed the tide in favour of Indian Army. Today, we venerate all those soldiers who, in the true traditions of the 'Ever Victorious' Battalion made the supreme sacrifice for the motherland while fighting the enemy and attained martyrdom. It is only because of you that every member of the 2nd Battalion the Rajputana Rifles family stands with his head high in glory.

'MAY THE ALMIGHTY CONFER EVERLASTING PEACE TO YOUR NOBLE SOULS'



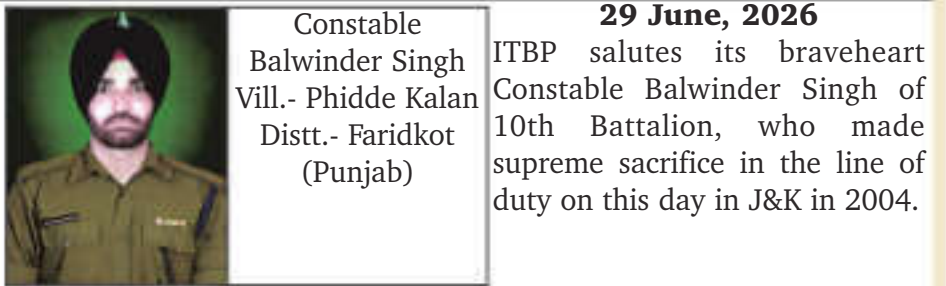
REMEMBERED AND REVERED BY COMMANDING OFFICER AND ALL RANKS 2nd BATTALION THE RAJPUTANA RIFLES (EVER VICTORIOUS)

BORDER SECURITY FORCE Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Manoj Kumar on his Balidan Diwas On this day, he sustained grievous bullet injuries during a counter terror operation in area of FDL CRP Dhok J&K and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

INDO-TIBETAN BORDER POLICE (ITBP) 29 June, 2026

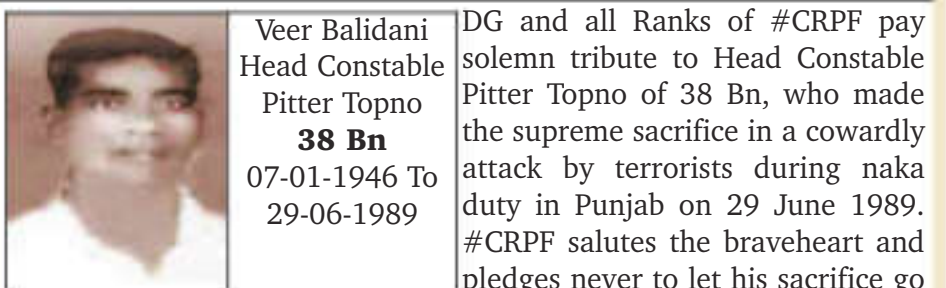


ITBP salutes its bravehearts Sub-Inspector Bijender Singh, Asstt. Sub-Insp. Vinod Kumar Meena, Head Constable Dhanjee Yadav and Constable Raju Kumar of Dte. Gen. & 49 Battalion, who laid down his life in the line of duty on this day in Arunachal Pradesh in 2018.

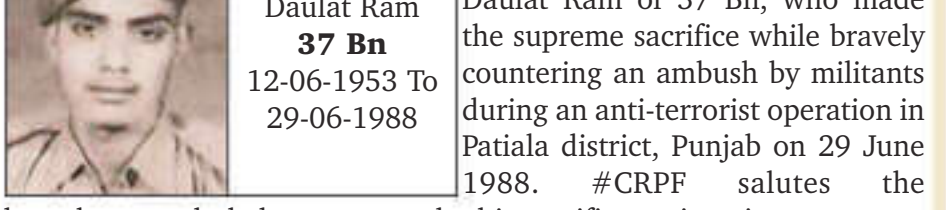


CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Head Constable/Radio Operator A. Sakthivel 78 Bn 13-06-1971 To 29-06-2005

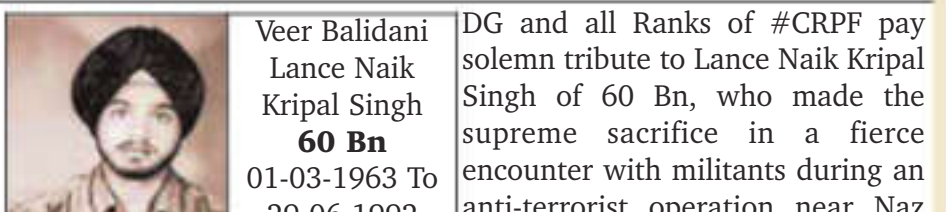
breathed his last on 29 June 2005. For his gallant action, he was posthumously awarded the President's Police Medal for Gallantry. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.



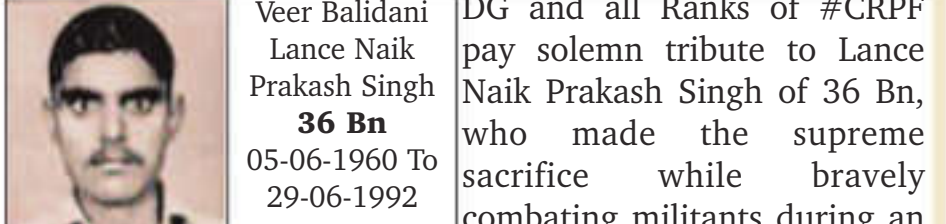
DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Head Constable Pitter Topno of 38 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice in a cowardly attack by terrorists during naka duty in Punjab on 29 June 1989. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.



DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Lance Naik Daulat Ram of 37 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely countering an ambush by militants during an anti-terrorist operation in Patiala district, Punjab on 29 June 1988. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.



DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Lance Naik Kripal Singh of 60 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice in a fierce encounter with militants during an anti-terrorist operation near Naz Chowk, Srinagar, Jammu & Kashmir on 29 June 1992. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.



Punjab on 29 June 1992. For his gallant action and devotion to duty, he was posthumously awarded the Police Medal for Gallantry. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE



DG and all ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to the 27 valiant troopers of 39 Bn who made the supreme sacrifice on this day in 2010 near village Mahimagawadi, Dhaudai, Narayanpur, Chhattisgarh. Led by AC Jatin Gulati, PMG (P), the outnumbered troops fought fiercely for 2 hours against a massive Maoist ambush. We salute the unmatched gallantry of AC Jatin Gulati and HC R. N. Das, both posthumously awarded the Police Medal for Gallantry, and all our bravehearts. Their sacrifice will never be forgotten.

कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, ड्रेनेज मण्डल, अलीगढ़ (E-Mail: sedrainage@gmail.com)

ई- प्रोक्वयेमेंट अति अल्पकालीन निविदा सूचना संख्या: 08/एस०ई०/डी.सी.ए./2026-27 महामहिम राज्यपाल, उत्तर प्रदेश की ओर से निम्नलिखित कार्यों हेतु ऑन लाईन निविदाएँ (http://etender.up.nic.in) सिंचाई एवं जल संसाधन विभाग, उत्तर प्रदेश में वर्गीकृत श्रेणी में पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से दिनांक 14.07.2026 अपराह्न 03.00 बजे तक आमंत्रित की जाती हैं। निविदा की प्री-क्वालिफिकेशन / टैक्नीकल बिड अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, ड्रेनेज मण्डल, अलीगढ़ के कार्यालय में मुख्य अभियन्ता (पीए) बैठक द्वारा गठित समिति के सदस्यों द्वारा दिनांक 14.07.2026 को अपराह्न 03.30 बजे खोली जायेगी। इसके अगले कार्य दिवस में, यदि इस सम्बन्ध में कोई आपत्ति हो तो, इस कार्यालय में आपत्ति प्राप्त की जायेगी। प्री-क्वालिफिकेशन / टैक्नीकल बिड में क्वालीफाईड पाये गये ठेकेदारों की ही फाईनैन्शियल बिड खोली जायेगी। कार्यालय बन्द होने अथवा अवकाश होने की दशा में यह निविदा अगले कार्य दिवस में उसी समय खोली जायेगी। अल्पकालीन ई- निविदा दिनांक 09.07.2026 को अपराह्न 02.00 बजे से दिनांक 14.07.2026 को अपराह्न 03.00 बजे तक डाउनलोड/अपलोड की जा सकती हैं। कार्य का विवरण निम्नवत है :-

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विस्तृत अल्पकालीन ई-निविदा सूचना का विवरण एवं नियम व शर्तें उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार की वेबसाइट (http://upgovt. up.nic/infotech) तथा सिंचाई विभाग की वेबसाइट (http://www.idup.gov.in) पर उपलब्ध हैं। उपरोक्त वर्णित सूचना तथा वेबसाइट पर प्रदर्शित सूचना में यदि कोई भिन्नता होती है तो वेबसाइट पर प्रदर्शित सूचना ही मान्य होगी। यह अति अल्पकालीन निविदा सूचना धनाचटन की प्रत्याशा में आमंत्रित की जा रही है, जो बिना किसी पूर्व सूचना के निरस्त की जा सकती है। इसके लिये किसी प्रकार का कोई दावा मान्य नहीं होगा

हस्ता./-

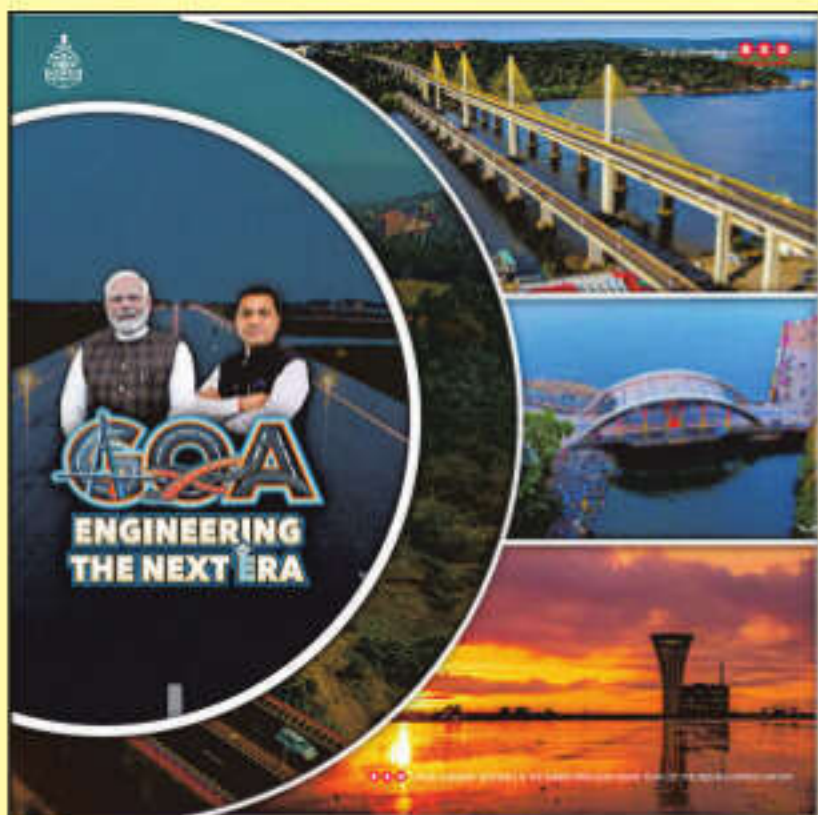
(प्रभात कुमार सिंह)

अधीक्षण अभियन्ता ड्रेनेज मण्डल, अलीगढ़

UPID-253093 Date 27/06/2026 www.upidadv.gov.in



ADVERTORIAL



The story of a rising Goa is written beyond concrete and steel, in the dreams fulfilled, opportunities created, and lives transformed through world-class infrastructure. This coffee table book captures a remarkable chapter in Goa's development journey driven by the vision of Viksit Goa and strengthened by the collective aspirations of our people.

For decades, Goa's growth was constrained by inadequate connectivity and limited infrastructure. Before 2014, many critical projects remained on the drawing board or progressed at a slow pace. Under the visionary leadership of Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi Ji, India embraced a new development paradigm where infrastructure became the foundation of economic growth and social progress. Goa has been a proud beneficiary of this transformative vision.

Today, modern highways, iconic bridges, world-class airport infrastructure, improved ports, mobility solutions, and enhanced public facilities are reshaping the way Goans live, work, travel, and dream. These projects are not isolated achievements; they are investments in the future of our youth, our farmers, our entrepreneurs, our tourism sector, and every family that calls Goa home.

As Chief Minister, I consider it a privilege to witness and contribute to this transformation. Every completed project reflects the hard work of thousands of engineers, architects, planners, technicians, labourers, and workers who toiled day and night to turn vision into reality. I extend my heartfelt gratitude to each one of them.

I also thank the people of Goa for their unwavering trust, support, and partnership in this journey. Their faith in our collective vision has been the driving force behind this progress. Together, we are building not just infrastructure, but a stronger, more connected, resilient, and prosperous Goa for generations to come.

Shri Pramod Sawant
Chief Minister, Goa

Goa's Development Journey Takes Centre Stage

Goa's Statehood Day celebrations at Kala Academy on May 30, 2026 did more than just honor a historic milestone; they provided a layered reflection on memory, infrastructure, and the state's evolving identity. At the heart of the narrative was the launch of Goa: Engineering the Next Era, a coffee table book designed as a visual archive to document and project the state's ongoing transformation.



The event gained national weight with the presence of Vice President Shri C. P. Radhakrishnan. His assertion that there is 'no Viksit Bharat [Developed India] without Viksit Goa' without Viksit Goa

Chief Minister Dr. Pramod Sawant used the occasion to connect Goa's historical freedom struggle to its modern ambitions. By linking the sacrifices of the liberation movement to current initiatives like Swayampurna Goa and rapid infrastructure expansion, he framed modern development as a continuation of history rather than a break from it. Engineering marvels like the Atal Setu and the Zuari Bridge were highlighted as premier symbols of this modern regional connectivity. Ultimately, the program demonstrated that Goa is attempting to balance its physical development with its unique cultural identity.

"Connectivity Redefined"

Goa's infrastructure coffee table book offers a vivid portrait of a state in motion, tracing how bridges, roads, airports, ports and public spaces are reshaping its future. More than a catalogue of projects, it presents infrastructure as part of Goa's larger identity story one where connectivity, governance and public memory come together on the same page.



At the heart of the book are landmark bridges such as Atal Setu and the Zuari Bridge, both of which symbolise Goa's engineering progress and its growing regional connectivity. These are joined by a network of smaller but equally important crossings, including Amona Viridi, Calvim, Tar at Mapusa, Paikul, Sankh ali, Assolna-Cavelossim and Varunapuri bridges. Together, they show how infrastructure in Goa serves not only major routes but also the everyday needs of local communities.

Assolna-Cavelossim and Varunapuri bridges. Together, they show how infrastructure in Goa serves not only major routes but also the everyday needs of local communities.

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The book also highlights key transport and mobility projects such as Mopa Airport, Dabolim Airport, NH-66 expansion, the Bambolim-Verna elevated corridor, the Mopa link road and port connectivity road in Vasco. Urban interventions, including Panaji Smart City initiatives, Goa E-Buses, Rua de Ourem creek redevelopment and improved bus stands, reflect a broader effort to make development more people-centric.



Mopa Link Road



“Goa’s rich history, sacrifice and progress continue to inspire the nation,”
- CM Dr. Pramod Sawant



Dona Paula Jetty

In the pages of this Goa coffee table book, the state's development story unfolds as a visual narrative of connection, progress and civic renewal. It presents Goa not only as a place of natural beauty and cultural richness, but also as a region steadily shaping a more integrated future through modern infrastructure and public services.

The Smart City project in Panaji emerges as one of the central themes of this story. Rather than offering only cosmetic change, it reflects a broader effort to build a more organised, efficient and liveable capital. Improved roads, better public spaces, upgraded drainage and stronger civic systems show how urban planning is being aligned with everyday needs. For residents, this means greater ease in daily movement; for visitors, it presents a more structured and welcoming cityscape.

The coffee table book also highlights the role of electric buses in Goa's mobility journey. The e-bus initiative signals a shift toward cleaner and quieter public transport, supporting both sustainability and convenience. In a tourism-driven state, such transport choices matter not only for efficiency but also for the environment. They represent a modern approach to mobility that is practical, responsible and future-oriented.

Water connectivity is another important chapter in the book. Goa's rivers, creeks and estuaries have always shaped the state's identity, and improved jetties and ferry links reinforce that relationship. These water routes provide an alternative mode of travel, reduce road pressure and strengthen access between communities. In this sense, water transport is both a functional service and a reflection of Goa's geography and way of life.

The state's airports, Dabolim and Mopa, complete



Vande Bharat Train

this picture of connectivity. Together, they expand Goa's reach across India and beyond, supporting tourism, trade and business travel. Their presence marks a significant expansion in access and underlines Goa's growing place in a wider economic network.

What makes these developments especially meaningful is the way they work together. The Smart City mission improves urban living, e-buses advance sustainable mobility, water transport strengthens local links, and airports broaden external access. Viewed together, they form an infrastructure ecosystem that captures Goa's changing priorities.

The coffee table book therefore becomes more than a record of projects. It becomes a statement about Goa's direction a state building itself with attention to mobility, sustainability, livability and connection. It tells the story of a Goa that is modernising thoughtfully, while staying rooted in the identity that makes it unique.



Zuari Bridge

‘Pak should look inwards’: India rejects Karachi attack allegations

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 28

INDIA HAS strongly rejected Pakistan’s accusations regarding its involvement in the Karachi incident in which four soldiers were killed.

In response to media queries regarding allegations made by Pakistan, MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said on Sunday, “We have seen Pakistani reports making baseless allegations against India regarding the recent incident in Karachi. We categorically reject them.”

“Instead of pointing fingers at others, Pakistan would do better to look inwards, take credible action against the terror infrastructure on its territory and rid itself of its proclivity to rely on terrorism as an instrument of state policy,” Jaiswal added.

Reports from Islamabad said Pakistani security forces killed six terrorists and captured another alive after foiling an attack by militants on a Sindh Rangers compound in Karachi Saturday night that left four paramilitary personnel dead.

BANGALORE ELECTRICITY SUPPLY COMPANY LIMITED
(Wholly owned by Government of Karnataka undertaking)
(CIN-U04010KA2002SGC030438)

BRIEF TENDER NOTIFICATION (Through e-procurement)

BESCOM invites tenders vide Enquiry No: BESCOM/2026-27/EL/WORK_INDENT1146 through e-procurement platform from eligible Bidders for “Strengthening of HT/LT Network in Elephant Habitat & Elephant Corridors by creating Safe Corridors for Elephants and other Wildlife in Ramanagara Division of Ramanagara Circle of BRAZ area of BESCOM Jurisdiction on Total Turnkey on Percentage Quoting Basis.”

Bid Documents available: 01.07.2026. **Last date for Bid Submission:** 30.07.2026, 17:00 Hrs. **Opening of Bid Document:** 31.07.2026, 17:15 Hrs.

The Tenders can be obtained through KPP portal web-site https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in. Aspiring Bidders need to register on KPP portal. Further Bidders can take assistance with KPP help desk contact numbers (+91-8046010000, +91-8068948777) or email at support@eprocelpdesk.com.

Sd/-
For Electricity related complaints call: 1912 Chief General Manager (Ele..),
Download “BESCOM Mithra” Mobile APP Procurement, BESCOM

FORM – II
EXCEL ENERGY TRADING SOLUTIONS
Flat No. AC-99, 1st Floor, C Block, 2nd Street, Anna Nagar, Chennai 600 040
Tamil Nadu – India

Notice under sub-section (2) of Section 15 of Electricity Act, 2003
1. The Excel Energy Trading Solutions (“EETS” Applicant), a company/ applicant/abovementioned, is a partnership firm registered under Section 58(1) of Indian Partnership Act, 1932 on 17.04.2026, has made an application under sub-section (1) of Section 15 of Electricity Act, 2003 for grant of Category-V license for inter State trading in electricity in all regions across India before the Central Electricity Regulatory Commission, New Delhi. The necessary details in respect of the applicant are given hereunder.

2. Authorized issued, subscribed and paid-up capital:

	a)	Authorised share capital
	NA	
	b)	Issued share capital
	NA	
	c)	Subscribed share capital
	NA	
	d)	Paid-up share capital
	NA	

The capital contribution by each partner is provided below:

S.No.	Partner Name	Contribution	Contribution percentage
1.	Mr. Kasi Raman N	INR 5,00,000/-	50%
2.	Mrs. Anupriya Soni	INR 5,00,000/-	50%
	Total	INR 10,00,000/-	100%

iii) Shareholding pattern (indicate the details of the shareholders holding 5% and above of the shares of the applicant):

Name of Shareholder	Mr. Kasi Raman N
Citizenship	Indian
Residential Status	India
No. of Shares	50%
Shareholding %	50%
Name of Shareholder	Mrs. Anupriya Soni
Citizenship	Indian
Residential Status	India
No. of Shares	50%
Shareholding %	50%

iv) Financial and technical strength: EETS has adequate financial and technical resources to undertake the business of trading and meets all the statutory requirements in this regard. EETS has full-time professionals having industry expertise in the power sector including power trading, regulatory affairs and finance. EETS is well placed to draw on its experience and work with various stakeholders in the Indian electricity system to build on this opportunity with the aid of its organized, skilled and experienced team. EETS is confident that the emerging regulatory and legislative changes in the power sector would enhance the competition which exists in the Indian Electricity Sector and provide more avenues and opportunities to EETS in the capacity of being a power trader.

v) Management profile of the application including details of past experiences of the applicant and/or the persons on the management of the applicant in generation, transmission, distribution and trading of electricity or similar activity.
Mr. Kondalsh Surthani - President - System Operations and Power Trading: is a qualified Engineer with over 10 years of professional experience in System Operation, Power Trading and Energy Risk Management. With the Applicant Company he is engaged in exchange-based and bilateral power trading, renewable energy sourcing, open access services, portfolio management and power procurement planning. He also has experience in scheduling and dispatch planning, demand forecasting and regulatory coordination. Further, he also has experience in portfolio management and power exchange products. Prior to this, Mr. Surthani worked with several groups of national repute such as L&T, Tata Elxsi and Standard Chartered Bank as Senior Analyst.

Qualification: M.Tech from IITR College of Engineering & Technology, Madak in 2016 and his B.Tech in Electronics and Communication Engineering from JNTU College of Engineering, Anantapur in 1975.

V. Swaminathan - Vice-President - Finance: is heading Finance and Commerce of the Applicant. He is a Chartered Accountant with industry experience of more than 50 years in finance, commerce and audit. He has expertise in preparing financial statements, financial reporting, budgeting and forecasting, preparation of operational plan, financial modelling, monitoring, and controlling of budget and leads the finance, commerce and accounts of the Applicant.

Qualification: B.Com in 1971 and C.A. from Institute of Chartered Accountants of India, New Delhi in 1975.

Mr. Kameshkumar B. - General Manager- System Operations and Power Trading: Mr. Kameshkumar B is a qualified Engineer with expertise in System Operation, Power Trading and Energy Risk Management. He possesses strong analytical and problem-solving skills and has developed proficiency in making the application or five years immediately preceding that year/ NO

vi) Geographical areas within which the applicant will undertake trading in electricity: **Across India**

vii) Net worth as on 31st March of three consecutive years immediately preceding the year of application or for such lesser period as may be applicable and on the date of the special balance sheet accompanying the application: (values in INR)

Date	Net worth
21st July 2026 (on date of special balance sheet)	INR 2,50,95,691/-
31st March 2026	INR 2,30,34,581/-
31st March 2025	INR 1,76,64,025/-
31st March 2024	INR 1,30,21,744/-

viii) Year-wise current ratio and liquidity ratio of the applicant for three years preceding the year in which the application is made, or for such lesser period as may be applicable and on the date of the special balance sheet accompanying the application:

Date	Current Ratio	Liquidity Ratio
21.07.2026 (on date of special balance sheet)	1.64	1.64
31.03.2026	2.73	2.73
31.03.2025	2.18	2.18
31.03.2024	1.89	1.89

ix) (a) EETS is authorized to undertake trading in electricity under “Clause 2 titled “Business Activity” of the Partnership Agreement.

(b) The said clause reads as:
2. BUSINESS ACTIVITY
(a) The parties have mutually agreed to establish and carry on the business of trading in electricity and act as a trader in sale and purchase of electricity and electrical energy in any form and in any marked including power exchange and derivatives market, and by any process and in fuel, derivatives and to enter into demand side management contracts, energy conservation contracts, including energy performance contracts, megawatt contracts, enter into contracts for banking of electricity or any other contract and to operate as an energy trading entity and to get registered with appropriate agency in accordance with the Electricity Act, 2003 or any other act, regulations/ rules framed thereon, policy guidelines laid down by the Central Government / State Government or any nodal agency from time to time or any statutory modifications or re-enactment thereof and do all acts and thing necessary or required for doing aforesaid business, including providing advisory and consultancy in issues related to energy and trading of energy. To carry on the business of advisory services of Energy Trading and Facilitate Power Trading in the Open Access System or any other system through Intra State and Inter State Electricity Exchange and bilateral trades and act as power trading entity.”

x) Details of cases, if any, where the applicant or any of his associates, or partner, or promoters, or Directors has been declared insolvent and has not been discharged: **NONE**

xi) Details of cases, if any, in which the Applicant or any of his Associates or partners or promoters or Directors has been convicted of an offence involving moral turpitude, fraud or any economic offence during the previous three years preceding the year of making the application and the year of making the application and the date of release of the above person from imprisonment, if any, consequent to such conviction: **NONE**

Name of the person: **N/A**

Relationship with the Applicant: **N/A**

Nature of offence: **N/A**

Date of conviction: **N/A**

xii) Whether the Applicant or any of his Associates, or partners, or promoters, or Directors was ever refused license, and if so, the detailed particular of the application, date of making application, date of order refusing license and reasons for such refusal: **NONE**

xiii) Whether the Applicant has been granted a license for transmission of electricity: **NO**

xiv) Whether an order cancelling the license of the Applicant or any of his Associates, or partners, or promoters, or Directors has been passed by the Commission: **NO**

xv) Whether the Applicant or any of his Associates, or partners, or promoters, or Directors was ever found guilty in any proceedings for contravention non-compliance of any of the provisions of the Act or the rules or the regulations made there under or an order made by the Appropriate Commission, during the year of making the application or five years immediately preceding that year/ **NO**

2. The application made and other documents filed before the Commission are available for inspection by any person with Mr. Ram Kumar K, working as General Manager, addressed at, Flat No. AC-99, 1st Floor, C Block, 2nd Street, Anna Nagar, Chennai: 600 040 Tamil Nadu – India; email: sdms@excelpowertrade.net and telephonable no. 824 841 3082/ 944 524 2929.

3. The application made and other documents filed before the Commission have been posted on: www.excelpowertrade.net

4. Objections or suggestions, if any, on the application made before the Commission may be sent to the Secretary, Central Electricity Regulatory Commission, 6, 7 & 8 Floor, Tower B World Trade Centre, Nauraj Nagar, New Delhi – 11029; E-mail: secy@cerind.gov.in within 30 days of publication of this notice, with a copy to the applicant.

5. No objections or suggestions shall be considered by the Commission if received after expiry of 30 days of publication of this notice.

Sd/-
Place: Chennai, Tamil Nadu
Date: 28th June 2026

Mr. Ram Kumar K
General Manager, EETS

MANN KI BAAT ADDRESS

PM: From seas to skies, India is becoming secure & self-reliant

Says grateful to citizens for supporting appeal for austerity amid West Asia crisis

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 28

HIGHLIGHTING SEVERAL milestones achieved by the country, PM Narendra Modi on Sunday cited the maiden flight of the made-in-India C-295 military transport aircraft and the successful test of the indigenous Long-Range Land-Attack Cruise Missile, underlining that “from the seas to the skies, our India is becoming increasingly secure and self-reliant”.

In his 135th Mann ki Baat address, PM Modi also said he was grateful to the citizens for supporting his appeal for austerity measures amid the prevailing West Asia crisis. People have started carpooling, travelling in buses and metros, and families have abstained from buying gold for weddings, he said as he described some of the instances of how people responded to his call.

“... I am grateful to every citizen of the country. Not only have they supported my appeal, they are also actively co-operating in every way... Numerous families have decided not to buy gold for weddings in their homes this time. If the need arises, they would recycle old gold to create new jewellery,” the PM said, adding that many people have posted on social media that they were postponing their foreign trips. He was happy, he said, Indians are facing the global crisis together.

Referring to his recent Kolkata visit, where he commissioned three indigenously designed and built Naval ships—INS Dunagiri, INS Sanshodhak and INS Agray — he said, “Everything, from the design

to the manufacturing of these ships, is indigenous.”

Noting that the C-295 aircraft has been made in India, he said, “As many as 40 such aircraft are being built right here in India and this is giving new strength to MSMEs and the aerospace sector”. This will also create employment opportunities and strengthen the resolve for an Atmanirbhar Bharat, he said. The first made-in-India C-295 military transport aircraft successfully completed its maiden flight on June 10.

The PM said that in June, the DRDO also successfully tested an indigenous Long-Range Land-Attack Cruise Missile. “In other words, from the seas to the skies, our India is becoming increasingly secure and self-reliant,” he said.

Modi also spoke about the superstition surrounding the hargila in Assam, a rare bird vital in preserving nature. “However, for a long time, it was considered inauspicious in certain parts of Assam. Often, trees housing hargila nests were even cut down... A bird that helps clean the environment became a victim of people’s fears,” he said.

He lauded biologist Puranima Devi Barman who resolved to dispel the misconceptions and presented to women facts based on science to bring about a transformation.

“The bird that was once driven away as a bad omen started becoming the identity of the villages. Thousands of rural women stepped forward to save the hargila. Today, they are known as the ‘Hargila Army,’” he said.

The Central Sanskrit University in Delhi launching a B Tech programme in AI and data science is a crucial step towards integrating modern technology with India’s traditional knowledge, the PM said, adding that the programme will facilitate the development of new AI tools for Indian languages and accelerate the digitisation and preservation of ancient texts and manuscripts.

Free Whatsapp Channel https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOXh6oBd0F

Boost to strategic ties as Modi meets Mauritius PM in Seychelles



PM Narendra Modi with his Mauritius counterpart Navinchandra Ramgoolam in Seychelles on Sunday. PTI

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 28

DURING HIS ongoing visit to Seychelles, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday met with the Prime Minister of Mauritius Navinchandra Ramgoolam in Victoria, Mahe.

The two leaders met on the sidelines of Seychelles’ Golden Jubilee National Day celebrations. This was PM Modi’s fourth meeting with PM Ramgoolam since the latter took office in November 2024.

The two leaders discussed the ongoing cooperation between India and Mauritius. They further reviewed the progress made in the implementation of the Special Economic Package extended by India.

Modi had visited Mauritius in March last year at the invitation of PM Ramgoolam to participate, as the Chief Guest, at their 57th National Day celebra-

“We discussed ways to strengthen the India-Mauritius partnership. The progress being made across every area of our Enhanced Strategic Partnership is a matter of satisfaction for us.”

PRIME MINISTER NARENDRA MODI

AFTER MEETING MAURITIUS COUNTERPART NAVINCHANDRA RAMGOOLAM

tions. In February this year, Ramgoolam visited India for the AI Impact Summit, focusing on harnessing emerging technologies and Artificial Intelligence.

On Sunday, Prime Minister Modi underscored the importance attached by India to the development and progress of Mauritius — noting that the ongoing bilateral projects will contribute to Mauritius’s healthcare, connectivity, sustainable development and blue economy. India supports Mauritius through extensive grant and Line of Credit (LoC) funding.

Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RG9mJmJzgl

The two leaders agreed on the significance of the India-Mauritius Enhanced Strategic Partnership under India’s Vision MAHASAGAR and Neighbourhood First policy, and their shared commitment to the Global South. Modi said on X, “Had an excellent meeting with Dr. Navinchandra Ramgoolam, the Prime Minister of Mauritius... We discussed ways to strengthen the India-Mauritius partnership. The progress being made across every area of our Enhanced Strategic Partnership is a matter of satisfaction for us.”

According to ISKCON sources, Das’ public statements regarding the Bangladesh monk issue formed the primary basis for the disciplinary action. The development comes days after Das emerged as one of ISKCON’s most prominent public faces during the controversy surrounding the Bengal government’s decision to introduce ISKCON-prepared vegetarian school meals in Kolkata midways as a pilot project.

According to ISKCON sources, the organisation was dissatisfied with Das’ public statements comparing the nutritional value of eggs and soybeans. Sources maintained no individual was authorised to provide such “extensive public explanations on matters relating to sattvik food”. (The writer is an at The Indian Express)

Time to talk about Mathura: UP CM amid Akhilesh bid to corner BJP on temple ‘theft’

Maulshree Seth
Lucknow, June 28

WITH SP chief Akhilesh Yadav trying to corner BJP over alleged Ram temple donation theft and promising to develop the temple town into a peerless religious city, ‘Siyaram-Dham’, Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath on Sunday dared Yadav to back the movement for the “liberation” of the Krishna Janmabhoomi on the lines of the Ram Janmabhoomi campaign.

“Ab taiyari kariye ki hum Krishna Kanhaiya ke liye bhi kuch kar saken. Ab Mathuraki baat kariye (It is time to do something for Lord Krishna, let’s talk about Mathura),” Adityanath said at a government



Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath in Hathras on Sunday. PTI

event in Hathras.

Challenging Yadav to publicly support the demand for the “liberation” of the Shri Krishna Janmabhoomi, he said, “If you are trying to portray yourself as religious, then openly speak about Mathura-Vrindavan,

where a movement should be started for the liberation of Shri Krishna Janmabhoomi. Lord Krishna’s birthplace should also be given due respect.”

“You lack the courage to support such a movement because you have bowed before

Spokesperson for ISKCON, who defended Bengal’s veg mid-day meals, is removed

Subhosree Modak
Kolkata, June 28

ISKCON KOLKATA vice-president and spokesperson on Sunday said that he has been relieved of all the responsibilities within ISKCON and was “directed not to represent or speak on behalf of the organisation before the media, government authorities or any public forum.”

In a statement issued on Sunday, he listed six reasons for which, he claimed, action was taken against him.

“1. Speaking publicly regarding persecution of Hindus in Bangladesh. Supporting and speaking in relation to Chinmoy Krishna Prabhu. 2. Sending legal Notice to (former Union minister) Maneka Gandhi for making public allegations against ISKCON. 3. Filing a cyber complaint concerning derogatory public remarks made against ISKCON by comedian Surleen Kaur. 4. Making public statements defending Sanatana Dharma. 5. Sharing a social media post concerning the historical association of Donald Trump with the 1976 New York Rathayatra. 6. Appearing in a Republic TV interview on 29 May 2026,” he wrote.

According to ISKCON sources, Das’ public statements regarding the Bangladesh monk issue formed the primary basis for the disciplinary action. The development comes days after Das emerged as one of ISKCON’s most prominent public faces during the controversy surrounding the Bengal government’s decision to introduce ISKCON-prepared vegetarian school meals in Kolkata midways as a pilot project.

According to ISKCON sources, the organisation was dissatisfied with Das’ public statements comparing the nutritional value of eggs and soybeans. Sources maintained no individual was authorised to provide such “extensive public explanations on matters relating to sattvik food”. (The writer is an at The Indian Express)

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER
RURAL WORKS CIRCLE, BERHAMPUR
(At/Po- Ambapua, Near Income Tax office, Berhampur-760011, Ganjam, Odisha)
25001/550/2627 Email: scwbpwr2004@yahoo.com Tel No.: 0680-2404287

NOTICE
FOR PRADHAN MANTRI GRAM SADAK YOJANA (PMGSY)
NATIONAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING THROUGH “e”-Procurement
Bid identification No. Online Tender/09-2026-27/PMGSY/PR :

The Chief Construction Engineer, Rural Works Circle, Berhampur on behalf of Odisha State Rural Road Agency invites the percentage rate bids in electronic tendering system for construction of Roads & Bridges under Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana [PMGSY-IV (B-I)] in the districts of Kandhamal for 112 (One Hundred Twelve) number of packages with estimated cost totalling to RS 212.67 Cr (Approximate) including their maintenance for five years from the eligible contractors registered with State PWD / CPWD / MES / Railways. The registered bidder of outside Odisha, can also participate in this process, but shall have to subsequently undergo registration with the appropriate authority of the State Govt. preferably within a month of the deadline for bid submission, but prior to signing of the contract Date of release of Invitation for Bids through e-procurement. Dtd. 30.06.2026 Last Date/ Time for receipt of bids through e-procurement: 14.07.2026 upto 5.30 P.M

(i) EMD / Bid Security, Cost of Bid document is to be transferred through Online as per the procedure mentioned in the DTCN.

(ii) Non-submission of the information/documents through online by the bidder as per mentioned DTCN will also liable for rejection of his tender.

For further details and corrigendum (if any) please log on to www.pmgstyenders.gov.in. :

Sd/-
Chief Construction Engineer
R.W. Circle, Berhampur

OIPR-25001/25071/1/26-27/0016

उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार

सिंचाई एवं जल संसाधन विभाग

कार्यालय अधिशासी अभियन्ता

पूर्वी गंगा नहर निर्माण खण्ड-2,

हरिद्वार,

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Office Of The Executive Engineer

Eastern Ganga Canal Construction.

Div-2 Haridwar

Contact No. 01334-226493

E-Mail ID-egced2hdw@gmail.com

पत्रांक 1670 / पुंगांनंनंखं-2हं० नीलाम / दिनांक 20/6/2026

सार्वजनिक नीलामी सूचना संख्या 01/पुंगांनंनंखं खण्ड-2हं०/2026-27

सर्वसाधारण को सूचित किया जाता है कि अधिशासी अभियन्ता पूर्वी, गंगा नहर निर्माण खण्ड-2, हरिद्वार के नियन्त्रणाधीन उपखण्ड द्वितीय के अन्तर्गत जनपद बिजनौर में स्टोर नजीबाबाद के परिसर में खड़ा विशालकाय 01 नम प्रजाति सेमल के पेड़ की नीलामी गठित समिति द्वारा दिनांक 08.07.2026 को प्रातः 11:30 बजे की जाएगी, जिसमें नीलाम की धरोहर राशि चरित्र प्रमाण पत्र जी०एस०टी० प्रमाण पत्र पेन नम्बर व पहचान पत्र तथा आधार कार्ड की सत्यापित छाया प्रति एवं पंजीकृत फर्म का रजिस्ट्रेशन, साथ ही ईच्छुक ठेकेदार / बोलीदाता द्वारा नीलामी की जमानत धनराशि 3360/ रुपए का बैंक ड्राफ्ट / एफ०डी०आर० जो कि अधिशासी अभियन्ता, पूर्वी गंगा नहर निर्माण खण्ड-2, हरिद्वार (Executive Engineer Eastern Ganga Canal Construction. Div-2 Haridwar) के नाम बन्धक देय होना चाहिए के रूप में स्वीकार होगा नीलामी में असफल बोलीदाताओं की जमानत धनराशि नीलामी के दिनांक 08.07.2026 से अगले कार्य दिवस प्रातः 10.00 बजे से सायं 5.00 बजे तक कार्यालय अधिशासी अभियन्ता, पूर्वी गंगा नहर निर्माण खण्ड-2, हरिद्वार में वापिस की जायेगी।

नीलामी का दिनांक	नीलामी का स्थल	अवधि	प्रजाति एवं संख्या	मूल्यांकित धनराशि (रुपए में)
08.07.2026 प्रातः 11.30 बजे	कैम्प कार्यालय भागुवाला स्टोर/कालोनी परिसर नजीबाबाद, जिला बिजनौर	नीलामी स्वीकृति की दिनांक से 01 माह तक पतान एवं अभिवहन की समस्त कार्यावाही पूर्ण करनी होगी।	सेमल 01 नम	13.440/- मात्र

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Book Cong leaders if no proof of their theft claims: VHP

Express News Service
Lucknow, June 28

ACCUSING SP chief Akhilesh Yadav of trying to “defame” the Ram Janmabhoomi movement, VHP president Alok Kumar on Sunday asked the police to summon Congress leaders and seek documentary evidence from them in the Ram Temple donation theft case.

In a video statement, Kumar accused the Opposition leaders of

“spreading rumours to sow discontent among the Hindus” and said that Govind Dev Giri, the treasurer of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, has asserted that gold, silver, and other valuables are secure.

“However, the statements from Congress indicated that gold, silver, and other valuables have all disappeared from the temple. How did this total become thousands of crores, and how can it be claimed that all valuables have vanished?” Kumar asked.

“So I expect the police probing this matter (the Ram temple donation case) should summon those people who are issuing such statements, and ask them to produce documentary evidence... And if they fail to produce, and I believe they don’t have any, the police should lodge an FIR against them under BNS section 353 for rumour mongering... Those making baseless remarks to cash in on the opportunity should be investigated,” Kumar added.

Get poll-ready, TVK govt may not last long: Stalin

Press Trust of India
Chennai June 28

DMK PRESIDENT MK Stalin on Sunday hinted that the TVK government in Tamil Nadu may not last its five year-term, and that it was running with the

‘Investment is casualty when industry concentration rises’

Jahangir Aziz, co-head of macroeconomic research at JP Morgan, spoke to **Siddharth Upasani**, Deputy Associate Editor at *The Indian Express*, in early June about how the West Asia conflict has reshaped global trade, capital flows and economic stability. Edited excerpts:



At a time of great geopolitical uncertainty, are there some natural winners and losers in global capital?

The easy answer is that during times of higher uncertainty, you could have turned to the US economy as a safe haven. If you look at what has happened to the US economy asset prices since, the conclusion you'd reach is that this is exactly what was expected, with a massive increase in equities.

The problem comes when you look at where the money went into the stock market. Most of it has gone into AI-related stocks, which have been broadening. It hasn't gone into the mainstream economy. Apart from people moving to US equity markets, they also move to gold, which is one asset class that has performed horribly despite a rise in geopolitical uncertainty.

Basically, if you scratch the surface, the war is not the defining issue because this geopolitical conflict has come in the face of several other factors driving the global economy. Not accounting for this makes it difficult to isolate the impact of the war.

First, there was a massive increase in trade uncertainty, where the existing trade order has been seriously questioned vis-à-vis the US's actions. Second, there's been this new secular driver of capex, definitely in the US and North Asia, due to the AI-driven increase in spending. The war, per se, should have had gold prices and equities going up. Neither US equities nor gold prices have gone up because of these two factors looming in investors' minds.

Has the impact of these different shocks on how money flows around the world been different?

Yes and no. All of them have a common theme: it raises uncertainty around invest-



ment, employment and your own future.

The best example is Europe vs the US. When uncertainty goes up, you first start increasing your precautionary savings. Household savings in Europe since Covid-19 have gone up every passing quarter. Europe is behaving as if there is a massive increase in uncertainty that is dampening down both consumption and investment.

In the US, the saving rate did go up, and then, since 2022-23, the saving rates have come down, and today, many people would say that one of the concerns in an otherwise

extremely strong US economy is the fact that the household saving rate keeps going down. Six years later, private consumption in Asia is still many percentage points below what its pre-pandemic trend would have implied.

Are indications of domestic demand just not strong enough for Indian companies, considering the systemic lack of private corporate investment for some years now?

We have used every possible ad-hoc ex-



Jahangir Aziz (left) at the Explained.Live session with Siddharth Unasani

cuse over the last 15 years to explain why Indian corporations' investments haven't moved beyond this 10-11% of GDP.

First was the banking sector problem, the non-performing loans. Then, there was the GST implementation, which was sort of fixed. Then came Covid, and it is now six years after Covid. Then there was geopolitical uncertainty, which affects the entire world. I think at some point we need to run out of these ad-hoc explanations. If you look at the top 5 leaders in any sector over the last 15 years, when India's GDP has doubled,

those five people have moved.

In communications, there is a new name, but that's a conglomerate entering the field and not a small firm growing big. In most sectors, names have dwindled; aviation has just about three names now.

The bigger question is, how can an economy more than double without any churn from the leadership of any sector? There has been no challenge to the old sectors (like IT or pharma) that became leaders. In countries where this sort of data is available, when you see this rise in concentration of industry, one of the casualties is investment.

If there is no hungry, \$5 billion market cap company in India that is investing in order to become a \$100 billion company in the next five years, where will investment come from? My argument is that we need to stop using such arguments, that if there's no demand, what can we do about it, and instead start looking at the structure of industry in India. We need to figure out why we have flatlined since our initial growth. What is most problematic is that I haven't seen any academic or think tank address why private investment has flatlined.

You were head of the China division of the IMF from 2004-7. We often keep hearing that India is 20 years behind China. So, is India now what China was back then?

In some parts, yes. Some sectors might even be ahead. Even 20 years back, however, the policy-making framework in China was very different to India's today. Infrastructure development was also higher there, despite our recent achievements. The thing is, we just really enjoy shiny things. But India's connectivity is very poor, and that makes it difficult for the domestic economy in India to be a part of the mainstream economy.

Just as we tend to obsess about skilling at a very high level, there is an important need to focus on internal connectivity. Can we go from Kanpur, perhaps the most important industrial centre in north India, to Coimbatore, its southern counterpart, by train, car or plane? There is no direct connectivity. In China, 20 years ago, the domestic connectivity infrastructure was very good.

AUDIENCE QUESTIONS

How can Indian education and skill development be aligned with the world's changing demands?

We grappled with this question even when I was in the government 20 years ago. No answer has been provided. But, say, when we compare, in China, if you go somewhere and blindly throw a stone, you will get 10 machinists there. In India, finding a machinist is very hard. The reason is that we haven't paid any attention to vocational schools or turned them into centres of high skill.

And what about skilling at the other levels, across the value chain? Where is the investment? There is no private university that ever says I'm going to teach people the art of lathe machines. It's only the government that does it. And the point

I'm trying to make is that when you compare India to China, the skill gap exists across the entire spectrum.

Where might the rupee go?

There are many factors playing into the rupee. Obviously, if you're going to have oil prices going up, that means pressure on current accounts and the rupee for natural flows. The government has provided some buffer to household consumption, but that wasn't the major fear. It was that since most of the oil in India comes from the Middle East, massive fuel supply shortages would arise.

The growth answer will come when the Q2 numbers come out. It could be bad, not because of slow growth but because the methodology being used has been giving

us a good growth run, which now reverses, and, that too, very sharply. Over the last two years, we've been unable to fund the smallest of current account deficits. The current account is today at 2 or 2.5% of GDP and the fiscal deficit is headed to 4.3%. It is marginal compared to 2013 and 1991-92. Not long ago, this might have been described as a goldilocks period for India.

I will argue that the problem is that we really need granular data for us to understand what is happening. It is easy to say foreigners are divesting and Indian corporates are injecting money elsewhere. There has to be an actual understanding of why private investment remains at 10.3% and has been flatlining for the last 16 years. That is why the firm-level data comes into play for holistic evaluation.





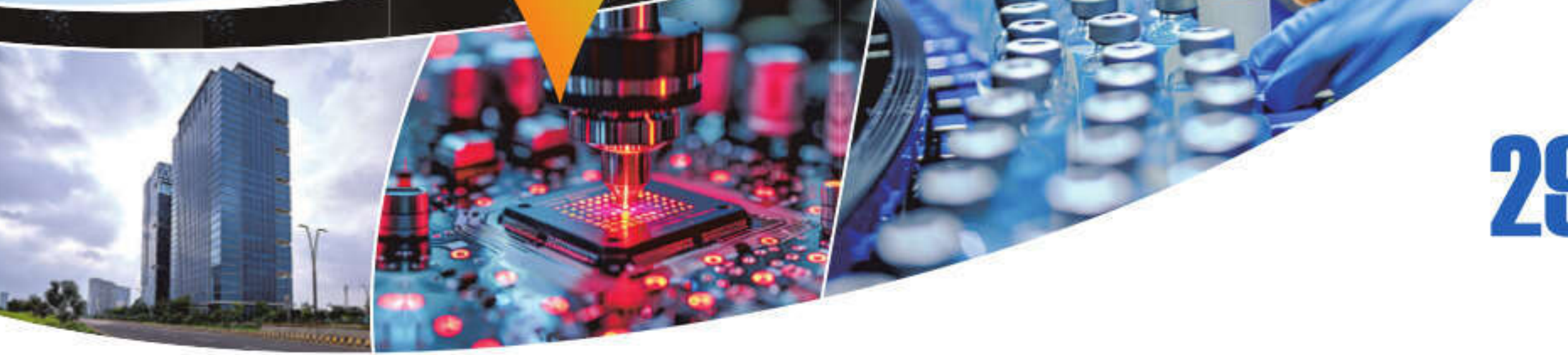




Shri Narendra Modi
Hon'ble Prime Minister



Shri Bhupendrabhai Patel
Hon'ble Chief Minister, Gujarat



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Mann: All party MLAs, ministers to appear before Akal Takht today

Kamaldeep Singh Brar
Amritsar, June 28

FLANKED BY AAP national convenor Arvind Kejriwal, Punjab CM Bhagwant Mann Sunday said in Amritsar that party MLAs and ministers will appear before Akal Takht Jathedar Giani Kuldeep Singh Gargaj Monday in connection with the summoning over the anti-sacrilege Act passed by the government earlier this year.

“We consider the supremacy of Akal Takht to be paramount,” the Chief Minister said, adding that the party’s MLAs and ministers will submit their positions in writing at the Takht and will speak to reporters after the Takht’s proceedings conclude.

Facing a boycott call from the Akal Takht over an objectionable video allegedly featuring him, Mann also announced



Punjab CM Bhagwant Mann and AAP national convenor Arvind Kejriwal in Amritsar on Sunday. RANA SIMRANJIT SINGH

that he will send a fresh letter to the Jathedar stating that the person shown in the video is not him but someone wearing a silicone mask resembling him.

“I cannot think of any confrontation with the Akal Takht. My status is not such that I can

clash with it,” he added.

Mann, however, questioned “selective” action by religious bodies. “When boards against me were put up in front of Gurdwara Sahib by some, they said boards must display the Takht’s hukamnama; then why were

there no boards installed against Sukhbir Badal?” he asked.

“BJP, Congress, and the Akali have come together against me; they are trying to gain political advantage by giving this a religious colour,” said Mann.

Claiming public support, Mann said he continues to meet people every day and is being honoured in front of gurdwaras where boards against him have been installed.

“People themselves grab the microphone and say they are with me. The biggest authority in our religion is the sangat — the Nanak Naam Leva sangat. We will see what decision the sangat makes,” he said.

The Chief Minister said that his government’s focus remains on governance and development. “We are working on water, power, roads, drains, flyovers, solar lights, hospitals, and schools; we are concentrat-

ing on positive work.”

Meanwhile, Kejriwal questioned the police probe into the alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, alleging that only small-time players have been arrested while the main persons facing serious accusations are roaming freely.

He said that despite allegations of a Rs 200 crore “theft”, only Rs 80 lakh had been recovered so far. “In the Ram temple case, not all the accused have been arrested. Instead, only small-time individuals have been caught. The main and big names, against whom the most serious allegations have been made, are still roaming freely. They have picked up someone who counted the cash or a watchman. The eight people who have been arrested all work at low levels,” Kejriwal said.

EXPRESS special

26/11 first-responder, youth motivator: Maharashtra IPS officer under fire for RSS praise



Vishwas Nangre Patil is a 1997-batch IPS officer

Opp questions civil servants’ neutrality under BJP regime

Mohamed Thaver
Mumbai, June 28

A couple of weeks ago, senior Maharashtra police officer Vishwas Nangre Patil received a call from the state’s Additional Chief Secretary (Revenue) Vikas Kharge. Kharge, Patil wrote on social media, was touring the economically backward Nandurbar district when he saw a young student reading the IPS officer’s book, *Mann mein hai vishwas* (In my heart, I believe). The senior bureaucrat promptly handed over the phone to the youngster, who received a quick pep talk from Patil.

Patil’s social media accounts are full of such interactions in which he is seen encouraging youngsters. However, days after he took charge as the Commissioner of Police in Nagpur, where the headquarters of the RSS is located, Patil is in the middle of a political storm in Maharashtra.

In a 45-second video clip that quickly went viral online after his appointment, the 1997-batch IPS officer of Maharashtra

praises. On one side, taking the oath of the Constitution, shouldering the responsibility of the people’s security, and on the other side, openly praising the RSS ... What kind of dutiful IPS officer is this?”

On Saturday, MNS chief Raj Thackeray waded into the row, telling Nangre-Patil, “If you have an affinity for the Sangh, keep it to yourself, or if you wish to speak publicly, resign from service and join the Sangh or the BJP.” He also took aim at CM Devendra Fadnis, asking him if a police officer’s “dual loyalty” was acceptable to him.

During the 26/11 Mumbai terror attack, Patil, a decorated officer, was the DCP of Mumbai City’s Zone I and took on the terrorists who had entered the Taj hotel. Known to be in the good books of the Sharad Pawar-led NCP, Patil served as the Joint Commissioner (Law and Order) of Mumbai when the MVA government of the Shiv Sena, NCP, and Congress was in power. He was heading the state ACB when he received his transfer order to Nagpur last week.

While the officer has not responded to Opposition’s criticism, those close to him said that the full video of the speech would show that Patil advocated for peace and spoke against hatred, they added.

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

Echoes from UP in wake of exam protests: *Hum kattar Bhajpai hain par...*

They speak, also, of a “*bhrashachar* (corruption) on the watch of a government in which the bureaucracy is seen to be given a free hand while an all-powerful CMO ensures that MLAs-ministers’ wings are clipped.

For the ruling BJP, which has just conquered West Bengal and before that Bihar, and which is aggressively cobbling up, through the serial breaking of regional parties, the parliamentary majority it could not win electorally, the good news is this: These discontents and anxieties are not unmixed.

Many *The Indian Express* spoke to made a distinction between the “System”/“*vyavastha*” and “*Sarkar*”/Government — laying blame on the former to absolve the latter.

Most pointed to a perceived lack of political alternative — the SP is still widely seen as trapped in its past image of a Muslim-Yadav party that presided over lawlessness. Especially in Varanasi and Gorakhpur, many point to ongoing welfare schemes and unfolding infrastructure projects to underline the inevitability of Modi-Yogi. Most of all, across the five cities, the Yogi government’s “tightprashasan”, its apparently strong grip on law and order, continues to draw admiration and support.

And yet, in this journey through UP’s cities, rising over

and above the new clamour held down by an older blunting, another set of voices make themselves heard, sporadically but insistently.

They identify themselves as BJP faithfuls, “*hum kattar bhajpai hain*”, some say. “*Par...*”. But...

Listen to them and you get the sense that, among its supporters, a BJP story that packaged aspiration and hope with majoritarian assertion and “zero tolerance” policies wielded not just against crime but also civil society dissenters and political opponents, may be fraying.

It is buffeted by the harshness of ground realities, the excesses and complacencies that unbridled success brings — and also by hesitant stirrings of empathy for the “Other” in UP.

In Sharmaji’s tea shop, an old Lucknow landmark, walking distance from Vidhan Sabha, where early morning regulars stand around tables, sipping kulhad chai, and sit on benches in an adjoining park under the shade of trees, Neeraj — second names have been withheld to protect identities — who has a property business, and who says he has been voting for the BJP, shares his concern: “*Desh, desh ka yuva, aage nahin badh raha hai* (the nation and its young are not moving forward).”

Deep, who works in a bank, says: “*Badlav karte rahna cha-*

hiye, (you need to keep changing governments). *Kendra mein bhi, rajya mein bhi* (in the state and at the Centre)”. Big industry heads to the country’s south and west, he says, no one wants to come to UP.

“Law and order is not alright in UP”, says Neeraj. “*Kuch zyaada hi* punishment... *pair mein goli maar kar* half encounter... *ghar gira dena* (police shoot criminals in the leg, homes of alleged criminals are bulldozed). *Ghar badi mushkil se banta hai* (a home is not easily built)”, he says.

The main problem, says Neeraj, is “*dar ka mahaul* (climate of fear) — Hindus are fearful of Muslims, Muslims of Hindus”.

“*Ek community ko zyaada daba rahe hain* (one community is being targeted excessively) but if you question the BJP you are labelled *desh drohi* (anti-national)”, says Deep. He couldn’t go to the protests against paper leaks at Lucknow’s Eco Garden on June 12, but he wanted to express solidarity with students — because he was a student and a job aspirant once, because “where will they go, those who are graduating?”

In Kanpur’s Kakadeo locality, Devyanshu, in the construction business, says: “Under the SP, there was rampant *bad-mashi* (lawlessness). This government gives suraksha (secu-

ity). But is that enough? Corruption has increased exponentially, so has the commission we need to pay.”

It is out of “*majboori* (helplessness)”, he says, that he will turn again to the BJP. “The party has managed to convince us, almost against our will, that if the BJP government goes, we will be unsafe. We have been brainwashed...”

“Modi ji is also not moving with the speed he once showed”, says Sanjog, a bank employee. “If only Akhilesh were to stand up today and say that he will henceforth be evenhanded, that everyone is equal for him, irrespective of caste or community”.

In Z Square Mall in the city centre, you hear disillusion in a group of businessmen, who describe themselves as “*bhajpai*” or BJP supporters. “There was progress in the BJP’s two terms at the Centre, but here in Kanpur, nothing has moved. The city lacks even a kilometre of continuously smooth road, officials have become autocratic. If we point to the bad condition of the road, we are told to turn our gaze to the highway”, says Vineet.

The SP is not an option for this group — “their lower rung leaders are already making threatening noises, and wasn’t it Mulayam who said boys will be boys?”, says Asit. Earlier when they voted for the BJP,

they say, there was an expectation from the government. Now, says Vineet, fear of the SP has been replaced by fear of the BJP losing power.

“Will those who have been rendered voiceless by this government rise in anger? For us, now, development takes second place to this anxiety... *Majboori mein ‘Jai Shri Ram’ kehna pad raha hai* (it is our compulsion to say ‘Jai Shri Ram’)”.

In Varanasi, in an early-morning all-women yoga class in Company Bagh in the heart of the city, Shalini echoes her companions’ enthusiastic support for Modi and Yogi — more for Yogi.

The UP chief minister is applauded for his take-no-prisoners style, especially when it comes to minorities. They mention, in particular, the Yogi government’s clearing of the historic, Muslim-dominated Daal Mandi area near the Kashi Vishwanath Temple, for road widening — Ghalib is known to have written his “*Chirag-e-Dair*” here, Agha Hashr Kashmiri, celebrated Urdu poet-playwright and pioneer of Parsi theatre, had his home here. But Shalini attaches a caveat: “*Dar hai, sarkar ka dar* (there is fear of government)... be it Opposition or media, if they speak up, they are slapped with cases. Their houses are raided and stashes of liquor or currency

notes are miraculously seized”.

And in the famed Pappu ki dukan near Assi Ghat, a modest and unembellished nook of daily debate over tea, Dhruv, self-professed Modi supporter, says, “Yogi never talks of education or jobs or price rise. The government disallows namaz on the street, even on Bakrid. What if the next government says no *kaanwads* during *saawan*? Or no crowds in public places during Navratri?”

In Gorakhpur, Vinay, who teaches in a coaching institute, says “My daughter will give NEET next year, I am already worried... The success of Rahul Gandhi’s Kota rally was due to the failure of the Modi government. BJP has lost every opportunity to improve the system.” He is alienated, he says, by the SP’s favouring of a specific caste and community “har level pe”, at every level. Akhilesh Yadav’s promises to pitch its tent wider do not reassure him. But he is bothered by the BJP’s “tod phod” or destruction of regional parties: “What else is it, if not a bid to keep power with one party permanently?”

The restiveness in BJP voters is more articulate in the upper castes, and within them, among Brahmins, who also have caste-centric grievances — a sense of being upstaged by Thakurs on one end, to resentments over backward caste res-

‘Irrational, alarming’: Opposition on former editor’s passport row

Asad Rehman
& **Sweetie Kumari**

New Delhi, Kolkata, June 28

THE OPPOSITION has hit out at the Centre after *The Telegraph*’s former editor, R Rajagopal, alleged that his passport had not been renewed following the deletion of his name from the electoral rolls in West Bengal during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the voter list.

In a statement on Sunday, the Editors Guild of India condemned the bureaucracy’s “treatment” of Rajagopal, who first said in a note on social media that he missed his daughter’s wedding in the United States because he did not possess an active passport.

On Sunday, Rajagopal told *The Indian Express* that he received a call from the police in the first week of April. “I think, in the first week of April, a police official called me from the Ballygunge police station and summoned me for police verification. He told me to carry my documents. When I asked which document, he told me, ‘Voter ID card.’ Then I told him, ‘But my name has been deleted from the electoral roll on March 27,’” Rajagopal said.

Efforts to renew his passport since then have been unsuccessful, and he has received an appointment to appear before the Regional Passport Office (RPO) on July 17, he said. A senior police officer, who did not wish to be identified, confirmed that Rajagopal’s application is now with the RPO since the police couldn’t verify it.

The Indian Express reached out to the Kolkata Police and the state Chief Electoral Officer’s (CEO) office for an official comment on the matter, but did not receive a response.

TMC MP files complaint, accuses rival faction leaders of forgery, impersonation

Sweetie Kumari
Kolkata, June 28

Rajya Sabha MP and TMC national joint secretary Dola Sen filed a complaint against key leaders of the rival party faction, accusing them of forgery, cheating, and criminal impersonation.

Sen, representing the Mamata Banerjee-led faction of the party, submitted the complaint to the officer-in-charge of the New Town police station under the Bidhannagar Police Commissionerate, naming

Rajya Sabha MP and Congress leader Vivek Tankha told *The Indian Express*, “I find this so irrational. His (Rajagopal’s) name has been deleted from the voter list. If someone asks me to bring my father’s matriculation certificate, I wouldn’t be able to find it. I am 69 years old and might not be able to locate my own matriculation certificate because it might be with the Bar Council.”

CPI’s Rajya Sabha MP Sandosh Kumar called the incident “alarming”, telling *The Indian Express*, “India is not the Sangh Parivar’s karayala (workplace). Rajagopal’s experience is an eye-opener.”

CPI(M) general secretary MA Baby posted on X, “Right from the outset, the CPI(M) had warned that the SIR exercise would disenfranchise the poor and vulnerable sections of our country. But now, even an editor of repute and an acclaimed journalist like R Rajagopal has been denied his right to vote.”

TMC Rajya Sabha MP Sagarika Ghose called the incident “shocking and heart-rending”.

“If this can happen to R Rajagopal, former Editor of a prominent newspaper, one can imagine what citizens with far fewer resources are going through. Deleted from the electoral roll. Denied the right to vote. Passport renewal stalled for 100 days because of an adverse police report linked to that deletion. Forced to miss his own daughter’s wedding abroad. And then told a passport is ‘not proof of citizenship’. This is what the slow erosion of basic citizenship rights looks like,” she said on X.

Editors Guild in a statement said it “condemns the manner in which Rajagopal is being treated by the bureaucracy that gets to decide who is an Indian citizen and who is not”.

prominent leaders, including Ritabrata Banerjee, Arup Roy and Biplob Mitra, Javed Khan, and Sandipan Saha, for actions allegedly committed during a meeting at a hotel on June 22.

Sen’s complaint asserts that rival faction illicitly duplicated party properties to mislead authorities. “Ritabrata Banerjee forged the Symbol and Name of the AITC to fraudulently create the Letter Head of AITC, using which he submitted a letter dated June 22, 2026, to the Speaker of West Bengal Legislative Assembly,” it states.

quite literally.

In Prayagraj, a political and intellectual centre, a nursery of student and establishment and resistance politics, you can count the spaces that used to be, and are no more, their demise quickened and sealed by the government of Yogi.

In front of Prayag station, tea shops hosted fiery discussions, and student leaders honed their arguments. The shops are there, but the vibrant night life is long gone, student union elections don’t take place anymore since 2019.

Outside the Accountant General office, a mock assembly, the “Pulia Parliament”, would play out daily. “Today, if it were there, it would discuss the Iran war or the NEET leak”, says Anshu Malviya, poet and activist.

PD Tandon Park hosted political rallies, the first major anti-Mandal Commission rally was held here in September 1990; protesters would also gather in the district court complex under the old banyan tree. The park is beautified and protests have been banished to the All Saints Cathedral in the corner of Civil Lines.

Now, spaces for protest have been designated. Dissent or discontent, even under the BJP umbrella, dare not give itself a name or call attention to its place in UP.



Rain havoc: Railway bridge collapses in Assam, flash floods in Arunachal

Sukrita Baruah
Guwahati, June 28

HEAVY RAINFALL has wreaked havoc on infrastructure across Arunachal Pradesh and Assam, including the collapse of a large portion of a railway bridge in Assam's Dhemaji district, affecting the movement of trains in the area.

As river waters swelled in Upper Assam's Dhemaji district with the rainfall there exceeding 110 mm in 24 hours, the railway bridge collapsed, leading to the suspension of train operations between Murkongselek and Silapathar under Tinsukia division.

"This bridge, constructed in 1965 and later converted to broad gauge, was in good and safe condition, but due to the washing away of a large portion of the river bank during the heavy rains, one of its piers became unstable. There is no damage to any train or injury to any person. This is a low-traffic branch line, and all traffic was already stopped beforehand due to the heavy flooding of the river," said a Northeast Frontier Railways official.

The Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA) estimated that, as of Sunday evening, around 15,483 people were affected by flooding in Dhemaji, with the total across Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>



A railway bridge that collapsed in Assam's Dhemaji district. EXPRESS

the state placed at 22,124.

"Since the flood situation has unfolded in Dhemaji, I've been closely monitoring the situation. We are deeply saddened by the impact it has had on the lives of our people and in this difficult time, we stand firmly with them. We are deploying a whole-of-government approach and mobilising all our resources to prioritise the immediate safety and long-term rehabilitation of all families affected," said Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma.

Flash floods continue in Arunachal Pradesh

In neighbouring Arunachal Pradesh, heavy rainfall and flash floods continue to lead to landslides across different parts of the state, severely affecting

transport routes. For instance, Landslides and mudslides have led to road blockages in at least eight key roads in East Siang district.

A further issuing of red alerts for five districts by the IMD has put the state on high alert, prompting it to issue an advisory to "avoid unnecessary travel".

"IMD officials informed that there is a possibility of more than 200 mm rainfall in the next 24 hours in the state. All districts issued with red and orange weather alerts are requested to remain on high alert and take necessary precautionary measures to avoid major damage and respond promptly to any critical situation," the state disaster management authority announced.

June to be fifth-driest since 1901; monsoon to reach Delhi in July

Anjali Marar
Bengaluru, June 28

WITH MORE than 43% rainfall deficit, June 2026, the first month of monsoon, is now likely to emerge as the fifth driest-ever with less than 4 mm of rainfall recorded on an average every day over the last one week.

June was expected to bring 165.3 mm of rainfall, which is the long-period average, for the country as a whole. Since 1901, when rainfall records for India are available, June rainfall has been below 100 mm only for four years — 1905, 1926, 2009 and 2014. The driest June was in 2009 when India received just 87.5 mm rainfall. This year, until Sunday, the country has recorded only 85.2 mm rainfall.

Such a large deficit for June is likely to force a reassessment of the seasonal forecast. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) had predicted 92% rainfall for June, and 90% for the four-month monsoon season. The remaining months are likely to get impacted by the El Nino which is yet to reach its peak, and is continuing to gain in strength.

• What numbers say

Year	June rainfall	Seasonal rainfall	Seasonal rainfall as % of LPA
2009	87.5	709.1	81.65%
2014	92.1	780.9	89.91%
1905	92.3	722.7	83.21%
1926	97.4	967.3	111.38%
1923	101.7	895.1	103.06%
1912	106.8	819	94.30%
1902	109	795.3	91.57%
1901	112.3	748.8	86.22%
2019	113.6	970.7	111.77%
1965	115.5	707.1	81.42%

SOURCE: IMD

Three of the four years which saw June rainfall below 100 mm — 1926, 2009 and 2014 — were also affected by El Nino. However, in 1926, the seasonal rainfall overcame the June deficit and ended up being 11% more than normal. In 2009 and 2014, seasonal rainfall was below 90%.

As has been reported by *The Indian Express*, El Nino had a marginal role to play in suppressing June rain. The ocean-

atmospheric interaction in the Pacific Ocean that affects weathers around the world had emerged around the first week of June, but its impact over the India will become evident after some time. The subdued rain in June could be due to other reasons, both local as well as global.

The monsoon advance over Delhi and major parts of north India remains delayed and is expected now in early July.

18 YEARS OF TIGER REINTRODUCTION IN SARISKA

Govt flags priority intervention in 25 of 58 tiger reserves which are low on big cats or have none

Nikhil Ghanekar
Alwar, June 28

EVEN AS India's tiger population has steadily risen over the years, about 25 of its 58 tiger reserves, which are low on tigers, have no tigers or low prey abundance, need priority interventions to establish long-term viable tiger populations, flagged a new Environment Ministry report.

The Centre also said of the 12 tiger reserves where tiger reintroductions or supplementation has happened through translocation of tigers, outcomes have not always been successful and called for rigorous science-backed reintroductions.

To mark 18 years of tiger reintroduction at the Sariska tiger reserve, Union Environment, Forest and Climate Change Minister Bhupender Yadav released the two reports — on the roadmap for active tiger management and learnings from tiger reintroductions — at an event in Alwar.

Sariska, which at present has 56 tigers, had lost all its big cats in the mid-2000's because of poaching and habitat loss, and it was the first time tigers were moved from another reserve to repopulate a habitat.

The Centre identified 25 tiger reserves across the country as "potential recipient sites" — reserves with the ecological potential to hold tigers but where populations are currently absent, critically low or in decline, and which now need



Union Minister Bhupender Yadav in Rajasthan's Alwar, Sunday. PTI

targeted, science-led intervention to recover.

Of these, some like Satkosia (Odisha), Kawal (Telangana), Dampa and Kamlang (both in the Northeast), Buxa (West Bengal), have zero tigers. The reasons vary by region but a few recurring problems have emerged like low prey abundance, cited for nearly every reserve on the list. Fragmented connectivity with source populations compounds this constraint in reserves such as Ranipur, Achanakmar, Kali, and Mukundara Hills, cutting them off from the dispersing tigers that would otherwise repopulate them naturally.

However, Project Tiger officials as well as the Environment Minister cautioned that community participation and interface is a must before reintroductions. Project Tiger head Sanjay Kumar cited the failed translocation at Satkosia and said it served as an important lesson to take the local communities into

confidence and consult them. Yadav also said that factors such as prey base augmentation, community participation, and continuous monitoring are crucial for reintroduction success.

Since 2008, India has undertaken scientifically designed tiger recovery interventions across 12 landscapes: Sariska, Panna, Sanjay Dubri, Mukundara Hills, Satkosia, Veerangana Durgavati, Rajaji, Ramgarh Vishdhari, Navegaon-Nagzira, Madhav, Sahyadri and Simlipal Tiger Reserves.

Recovery in these low tiger occupancy areas is not possible, though, without strong source population areas, the Centre noted in its report. It cited 13 tiger reserves, including Bandipur, Kanha, Ranthambore, Corbett, where tiger density, prey base and habitat are all in good condition.

(The author was in Alwar at the invitation of the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change)

ONLY 10 SHIPMENTS SENT, NOT 200 AS CLAIMED: SBL ENERGY

Material sent to Sudan only for use in mining: Firm after US sanctions

Ankita Deshkar
Nagpur, June 28

AFTER THE US Treasury Department's Office of Foreign Assets Control (OFAC) sanctioned SBL Energy Ltd and its CEO Alok Choudhary for allegedly sending over 200 shipments of explosives to Sudan Armed Forces, the company issued a detailed clarification on Sunday.

According to a recent report, the US Treasury Department's Office of Foreign Assets Control (OFAC) sanctioned SBL Energy Ltd (earlier known as Amin Explosives Pvt Ltd from 2002 to 2015), and its CEO Alok Choudhary for supplying explosives to the SAF to "intensify ongoing civil war".

The company, in a statement, said that since 2022, it has supplied only 10 shipments of explosives, not 200 as reported. The company has also clarified that it does not manufacture any defence products.

Talking to *The Indian Express*, a senior official of SBL Energy said, "The mining explosives we manufacture are industrial explosives used in mining operations. The customer who approached us was the end user. By 'end user', I mean the entity that ultimately uses the material. The end user had confirmed to us that the explosives would be used for mining and the material we supplied can only be used for mining — it is not meant for weapons. Based on that declaration, we obtained

Will present facts, documents and evidence before the US Treasury Department, and request removal of sanctions, says the company

the export licence and supplied the consignment."

"There were not 200 shipments — there were only 10. Those ten shipments included emulsion, detonators and detonating cords... The end user had provided us with a written declaration stating the purpose for which the explosives would be used. We have that certificate. In fact, an export licence is granted only on that basis. We are required to submit details of the end user and the purpose of the supply while applying for the licence. At that time, we had also checked the OFAC database, and the company to which we supplied the material was not on the sanctions list..." he said.

"We have not made any supplies after 2025 because there was no further requirement from the end user. A single shipment sent by sea can consist of multiple containers," the official informed.

In a statement, the company said SBL Energy will soon present its position before the US Treasury Department with facts, documents and evidence, and request the re-

moval of the sanctions. The statement further stated, "The company exports its industrial-grade products to more than 18 countries, including Sudan. In this regard, the company operates in compliance with all procedures, rules and regulations under the policies and laws framed by the Government of India. The company also fully complies with the regulations of the importing countries."

SBL Energy Ltd was recently in the spotlight after an explosion in the factory on March 1 this year in which 27 workers were killed, including 24 women. Police had then arrested 11 people and the High Court has refused anticipatory bail to some of its top officials. Four of those arrested are still in custody, according to SBL officials and police have filed the chargesheet.

The Supreme Court on May 15 dismissed a Special Leave Petition (Criminal) filed by Alok Choudhary challenging the Bombay High Court's April 27, 2026 order, holding that there was no ground to interfere with the High Court's decision. However, the apex court granted Choudhary four weeks to surrender before the trial court. It further directed the trial court to expeditiously hear and decide his regular bail application after he surrenders. The Supreme Court also clarified that the observations made by the High Court in its earlier order shall not influence the trial court order while deciding the bail plea.

• BRIEFLY



Home Minister Amit Shah meets locals during a Lok Darbar in Ahmedabad. CM Bhupendra Patel is also seen. ENS

GUJARAT

Amit Shah launches PM Family Care Tracker for child welfare

UNION MINISTER for Home and Cooperation Amit Shah, on Sunday launched a pilot project — PM Family Care Tracker — for the Gandhinagar Lok Sabha Constituency. The project aims to coordinate various aspects of a child's progress and any defect in the progress or delivery of service would be flagged by the system. Those present on the occasion included Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel, Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghavi, Health Minister Praful Pansheriya, and top officials of the Health department among others. During his speech, Shah referred to the PM - Family Care Tracker project and said that it has covered total 16 schemes for the welfare of the people to ensure that nobody has been deprived of its benefits. ENS

Murder accused killed in police encounter

A MAN wanted for the murder of a cloth trader was killed in a police encounter in which two cops were also injured, police said Sunday. SP Sukirti Madhav Mishra said Shivam, 23, who carried a cumulative reward of Rs 1.75 lakh was traced following a tip-off on Saturday night. A semi-automatic pistol, a country-made firearm and a large quantity of cartridges were seized, Mishra said. Police said Shivam was wanted in the May 28 murder of cloth trader and he had around a dozen criminal cases registered against him, including two murder cases. PTI

Three juveniles detained for murdering minor

THREE JUVENILES have been detained for allegedly murdering a boy, 10, in Jaipur. The boy had been missing since June 14, and his body was recovered from a drain on June 25. His severed head was found a short distance away. "The victim allegedly made a remark to the sister of the accused, which led to a quarrel between them a few days earlier. The accused allegedly planned the murder to take revenge," DCP Rajarshi Raj said. The juveniles allegedly lured the boy to a secluded place...where they strangled him and severed his head with a knife. PTI

LOHAGAD FORT MURDER

Fiancée's 'sit-down' signal fatal push cue, say police

Sushant Kulkarni
Pune, June 28

THE PUNE Rural Police, probing the alleged murder of 25-year-old Ketan Agarwal at Lohagad Fort, said that his fiancée, Siya Goyal (20), gave a signal by sitting down on the ground, prompting her friend, Chetan Chaudhary (22), to push Ketan off a cliff, leading to his death.

Siya and Chetan were arrested on June 23 on the charge of killing Agarwal by pushing him off the cliff.

According to investigators, Siya and Ketan got engaged on February 19 and were scheduled to marry later this year. However, Siya, who had allegedly been in a relationship with Chetan since October last year, did not want to marry Ketan.

The two accused have been remanded in police custody till Monday and are being questioned. Investigators have also recorded statements of Siya's family members.

Police claim Siya had earlier sabotaged the couple's planned

pre-wedding shoot in Bali by stealing Ketan's passport and later discarding it in the washroom of a food mall on the Pune-Mumbai Expressway.

Investigators claimed that she took Ketan to Lohagad Fort on May 31 and June 14 before returning with him on June 18, when she and Chetan allegedly executed the murder by pushing him off the western cliff. They also said Siya had tried to persuade Ketan to visit the fort on June 4, but the trip was cancelled after his mother objected.

An officer associated with the investigation said, "Our probe suggests that Siya and Chetan had agreed on a signal after which Chetan was to push Ketan off the cliff. The signal was Siya sitting down on the ground. When Siya and Ketan reached the spot, Chetan was already there and maintained some distance to avoid suspicion. At one point, when Siya sat down, Chetan approached from behind and pushed Ketan off the cliff."

Why Shivakumar's home pick sparks a row as he opts out of 'jinxed' CM House

Akram M
Bengaluru, June 28

SINCE CONGRESS leader D K Shivakumar became Karnataka Chief Minister earlier this month, the Kumara Krupa guest house in Bengaluru has remained abuzz with activity.

Earth movers have been deployed inside the guest house complex, which have dug a trench separating the old building from the newer structures. Meanwhile, construction workers have erected scaffolding inside the two-storey building and begun chipping away at some of its parts.

Reason: Shivakumar, who currently stays at his private house in Sadashivnagar, plans to make the guest house his official residence following its revamp, instead of moving into "Anugraha", the officially designated

Chief Minister's residence which many politicians cutting across party lines, including several ex-CMs, considered "jinxed".

"The CM has deep faith in Vaastu and astrology. Changes to the building (Kumara Krupa guest house) are being undertaken in consultation with Vaastu experts," said a Public Works Department (PWD) official overseeing the project.

Once the renovation is completed, the building will have a separate approach road and will be enclosed by a six-foot boundary wall. Workers estimate that the renovation could take up to three months. Officials say the CM may move into the house around the Dussehra period in October.

The renovation was approved after the PWD issued a note following Shivakumar's directive that the complex be pre-



The Kumara Krupa guest house in Bengaluru

pared for occupancy.

Opposition attack

The move has drawn criti-

cism from the JD(S), which has accused Shivakumar of altering a heritage building for personal convenience.

"Converting the heritage building Kumara Krupa, where the father of the nation Mahatma Gandhi stayed and

which also holds memories of (Mysore state) Diwan K Sheshadri Iyer, into a home office merely for personal convenience is a great betrayal of history," the JD(S) said in a social media post shortly after the renovation work began at the guest house.

Officials, however, insist that the building's heritage character will remain intact. "Rooms were added to the guest house in the 1960s, and renovation work has been carried out periodically ever since," said an official.

'Jinxed' CM House

With superstition appearing to play a key role in the selection of their official homes, several CMs from different parties had chosen not to stay at Anugraha during their tenures.

This designated residence

was last occupied by the BJP's Sadananda Gowda during his brief stint as the CM in 2011, whose incomplete tenure reinforced a belief among leaders that those who live there do not return to lead the state.

Former BJP CM Basavaraj Bommai, who took over from B S Yediyurappa mid-term in 2021, also stayed at Anugraha briefly before shifting to another government residence — 1, Race View Cottage on Race Course Road.

Other former CMs including Dharam Singh (Congress, 2005), S M Krishna (Congress, 1999-2004), H D Kumaraswamy (JDS, 2006-07), and H D Deve Gowda (JD, 1994-96), had made Anugraha their official residence during their tenures. Of them, only Krishna completed his term. Even Krishna, who called early elec-

tions, was later replaced after the Congress failed to secure a majority in the 2004 polls.

Two-time CM Yediyurappa, known for his belief in Vastu like Shivakumar, never occupied Anugraha and instead chose to stay at Race View Cottage, which he considered "lucky".

During his 2006-07 CM stint, Kumaraswamy lived at Anugraha after astrologers advised him that caring for two cows would break the residence's "jinx". After some setbacks, he later operated from the Taj West End hotel during his 2018-2019 tenure as the CM.

Shivakumar's predecessor Siddaramaiah, during both his tenures as the CM (2013-2018 and 2023-2026), chose Cauvery as his official residence. He has continued to retain it even after demitting office last month.



Reprieve to rupee, bond markets is short-term

THE RUPEE has recovered to 94.4 to the US dollar, from an all-time-low of 96.6 on May 20. Over this period, 10-year Indian government bond yields, too, have softened from over 7.1 per cent to below 6.8 per cent. Brent crude prices closed on Friday at \$72.6 per barrel, having risen as high as \$126.4 in end-April. India's latest urea import contracts have been at \$444.9-449.3 per tonne, as against \$935-959 in April. Foreign portfolio investors (FPI) have started putting money again in India, investing nearly \$5.2 billion into debt so far in June, compared to \$291 million, minus 1.2 billion and minus \$926 million in the preceding three months. All these are suggestive of the Indian economy returning to the pre-war situation, with an easing of tensions in West Asia and the associated supply shocks.

The reduction in macroeconomic stress may, however, be temporary, and arguably as fragile as the US-Iran truce. The renewed hostilities since Thursday — with daily vessel crossings through the Strait of Hormuz still half of what they were in peacetime — are a reminder of that. The Rs 10/litre excise duty cut on transport fuels in late-March, and the fertiliser subsidy outgo, likely to significantly overshoot budget estimates despite the recent global price dip, will continue to exert pressure on the Centre's finances. FPIs remain net sellers in Indian equity markets, with outflows of \$5.5 billion-plus this month on top of \$3.5 billion, \$6.5 billion and \$12.7 billion in May, April and March respectively. The rupee's stabilisation for now is courtesy the coordinated government-Reserve Bank actions to attract foreign inflows through sovereign debt, non-resident/FCNR(B) deposits and external commercial borrowings (ECB). These measures — whether offering complete tax exemption on FPI investments in government bonds or at-par/concessional dollar-rupee swap facilities on FCNR(B) deposits and ECBs — aren't costless. A deficit monsoon — 43 per cent below-rainfall in June even before El Niño is to fully bite — adds to the vulnerabilities.

Simply put, the reprieve to the rupee and bond markets is short-term at best. As a large lower middle-income emerging economy, India should be attracting foreign investment more in the form of equity than debt. That is conditional upon investor confidence, both domestic and foreign, in the country's growth story as well as macroeconomic stability. All the more reason for policymakers to double down on domestic reforms — economic, legal and institutional — even amid global uncertainty and fiscal consolidation in order to reduce the general government debt-GDP ratio to 60 per cent, from the current not-so-sustainable 80 per cent levels. The task is cut out, with or without the impact of the Iran conflict and El Niño.

Ayodhya donation theft calls for accountability

THE RAM temple in Ayodhya has been the ideological lodestar of the BJP, the culmination of a three-decade-long movement that has reshaped Indian politics. After January 22, 2024, when the temple was consecrated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, it symbolised the fulfilment of the party's core promise. Like the Temple Construction Committee, members of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, formed in February 2020, were hand-picked and entrusted with the management of one of independent India's most politically consequential religious projects. Since its inception, the Trust is estimated to have received around Rs 3,500 crore as donations in cash alone. Allegations of financial irregularities — theft and embezzlement of funds and valuables donated to the temple — therefore constitute not just a grave breach of that public trust but also point to a serious institutional failure. Due process must now run its course. Anything less will deepen the damage.

Even before the temple's construction, allegations of irregular land purchases around the complex, in which Trust officials were named, had raised troubling questions. In 2020, a private audit firm had warned that the absence of a robust oversight mechanism could undermine the Trust's accountability and fair practices. Its warning went unheeded. The report submitted by the Special Investigation Team of the Uttar Pradesh government has uncovered multiple lapses. Since then, eight lower-ranked temple officials have been arrested and a portion of the stolen funds recovered. The Trust's general secretary and another senior trustee have resigned. As the probe widens its ambit, UPMC Yogi Adityanath has promised strict punishment for those found guilty. Those words must now be matched by action.

If the Ram temple has been one pillar of the BJP's political identity, alongside implementation of the Uniform Civil Code and abrogation of Article 370, its governance has reiterated PM Modi's pledge of zero tolerance to corruption. That promise is now under scrutiny. Opposition leaders have demanded a court-monitored Central investigation, alleging a cover-up to shield senior Trust functionaries. Whether or not that charge is ultimately borne out, a government that claims the high moral ground, that demands accountability from everyone else, and that sees conspiracy in every criticism, cannot turn away when the reckoning comes to its own doorstep. The investigation must follow the evidence wherever it leads, without fear or favour.

FREEZE FRAME

BY EP UNNY



The Editorial Page

It's time to resume the India-China strategic economic dialogue

LAST WEEK in New Delhi, India's national security advisor Ajit Doval told his Chinese interlocutor, foreign minister Wang Yi, "India and China are partners, not rivals," and added, "a stable India-China relationship serves the common interests of both sides." Echoing these sentiments, Wang suggested that both sides should "respect each other's core interests, properly handle sensitive issues, place the China-India boundary issue in its appropriate position, and prevent it from affecting the overall situation of bilateral relations."

He then called for both sides "to accelerate the resumption of dialogue mechanisms and promote exchanges" in trade, finance, and other fields. It is a timely suggestion that should be taken up in right earnest. Fifteen years ago, at a time when India-China relations were on a more even keel, Prime Ministers Manmohan Singh and Wen Jiabao agreed to launch a bilateral strategic economic dialogue. The Indian delegation was headed by the deputy chairman of the Planning Commission, and subsequently the deputy chairman of the Niti Aayog. Between 2011 and 2019, six meetings were convened. After 2019, the dialogue has remained suspended. Not much seems to have come out of those dialogues.

With the recent improvement in India-China bilateral relations, there have been several interactions at the military, security and diplomatic levels. There is an urgent need for a resumption of a meaningful and focused economic security dialogue. India's chief concern remains the wide and widening trade deficit, with mercantilism occupying an important place in Beijing's economic policy toolbox.

The strategic economic dialogue had a wider remit and was aimed at improving

macro-economic policy coordination, promoting exchanges on economic issues and enhancing India-China economic cooperation. Working groups were established on a wide range of subjects, including energy, infrastructure, pharmaceuticals, high tech, resource conservation and environmental protection. After the events of 2020, the stand-off and clashes along the line of actual control, this dialogue was suspended.

In the new global context in which India now finds itself and given the thaw in India-China relations, it is necessary that the focus of bilateral relations should not be confined only to extant differences on the border issue. While it is not clear if the leaderships of both countries are today in a position to resolve those differences amicably, the definition of "core" issues must extend beyond the geopolitical to include India's developmental concerns.

India's own developmental priorities necessitate a wider engagement with China on economic issues. China must recognise that sustaining economic growth and building India's industrial capacity is also a core issue for India.

One of the positive outcomes of the dialogue on energy security was a willingness on the part of both countries to work together in dealing with energy supply challenges. China and India have an enormous stake in the stability of energy supplies. Going beyond traditional sources of energy, the two should explore opportunities to develop non-traditional energy. Such cooperation would be a global public good.

The weaponisation of trade, finance and energy by the United States that began almost a decade ago and became intense following the Russia-Ukraine war, remains a

Gurugram case, and a question of trust and informed consent



SAROJINI NADIMPALLY



SNEHA BANERJEE

RECENT NEWS of a case in Gurugram has raised concerns about accountability within India's assisted reproductive technology (ART) sector. A couple who underwent In Vitro Fertilisation (IVF) in 2025 gave birth to twin daughters in January 2026. They noticed significant physical differences between themselves and the children and arranged independent DNA testing. The tests allegedly showed that neither parent was biologically related to either of the children. An FIR has since been registered against the hospital. The case raises fundamental questions about trust, oversight, and accountability in reproductive services. Alongside the couple's distress, the children's rights and welfare are at risk.

This is part of a series of disputes that have exposed weaknesses in the regulation of ARTs in India. In 2023, the National Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission imposed a substantial penalty on a Delhi hospital after DNA testing established that a husband was not the biological father of twins born following an Intracytoplasmic Sperm Injection (ICSI) procedure, where his sperm was claimed to be used. The facts of the Gurugram case are yet to be fully determined, but both cases highlight the need for robust systems of traceability and accountability.

Couples undergoing IVF entrust fertility clinics with some of the most intimate aspects of human life. When questions arise about the identity, handling, or use of gametes and embryos, the consequences go beyond ordinary clinical error. They indicate institutional failure, directly impacting trust and informed consent.

The ART (Regulation) Act 2021 sought to address the need to regulate a rapidly expanding sector operating with limited oversight. Sections 21 and 23 of the ART Act impose statutory obligations on clinics and ART banks for record-keeping, identification procedures, storage protocols, documentation, and compliance monitoring. Institutions must maintain records for extended periods and make them available for inspection by regulatory authorities.

However, laws are only as effective as the institutions that implement them. The implications of malpractice in this area go beyond negligence. It fundamentally violates the principle of informed consent.

The practical reality in grievance redressal often involves prolonged delays and fragmented oversight. For affected families, this compounds emotional distress and jeopardises the preservation of necessary evidence. The decisions about whether to use donor gametes, pursue genetic parenthood, or have a child are deeply personal. When these decisions are altered by error or misconduct, the consequences extend beyond the clinical setting.

The welfare of children born through such procedures must remain paramount. The ART Act (Section 31) seeks to provide certainty by stipulating that children born through donor-assisted reproduction are the legal children of the commissioning couple and that donors relinquish parental rights. This framework works well when donor gametes are used knowingly and with informed consent. However, the allegations in the Gurugram case expose a regulatory gap. The law was designed to govern consensual donor arrangements, not situations involving alleged clinical error or mistaken embryo transfer. If substantiated, the allegations raise a troubling possibility: Parents raising children to whom they are genetically unrelated, while their biological children may be elsewhere.

The ART Act [Section 33(1)(a)] regards any medical practitioner or any person "caus(ing) to abandon, disown" children born through ARTs as an offence. Yet, it is silent on what happens to the children who face such a dire possibility. Children should never bear the consequences of institutional failures. Any legal response must ensure parentage, continuity of care, emotional security, inheritance rights, and protection for them.

Nadimpally is a public-health researcher who works on ethics, reproductive and biotechnologies, and surrogacy. Banerjee is assistant professor, Department of Political Science, University of Hyderabad



SANJAYA BARU

The difficulties Indian trade negotiators are facing in concluding a bilateral trade agreement with the US point to the need for a more nuanced approach to trade with China

matter of concern for both countries. The fact is that initially, China was the principal target of US and European action, but India suffered collateral damage. The trade measures that President Donald Trump took against China in his first term also hurt India. In his second term, Trump has directly targeted India on trade and energy.

The expression of solidarity within BRICS, as has recently been in evidence, is a sign of wider developing country concern about developed economy actions. It is becoming increasingly clear that as Asian economies rise, the "West vs Rest" divide stares us in the face. As the second-largest economy, can China play a more positive role in the rise of the Rest, instead of being seen as contributing to their deindustrialisation?

To be sure, the huge and persistent trade deficit today is also a reflection of the fact that the Indian private sector has become dependent on imports from China. Consider the business traffic between the two countries. Many Indian companies, large and medium-scale, continue to make a beeline for China in search of machinery and technology. Clearly, a growing economy like India can no longer afford to minimise economic links with the world's second-largest economy, especially when signals from the largest economy remain worrisome.

The difficulties Indian trade negotiators are facing in concluding a bilateral trade agreement with the US point to the need for a more nuanced approach to trade with China. Any strategic economic dialogue today will have to once again emphasise Indian concerns about the trade deficit but go beyond it to find meaningful ways in which India and China can pursue win-win



BIMAN NATH

Let's switch off the lights, bring back the starry night

DARK NIGHTS are becoming increasingly rare. Our cities are dazzled by artificial lights from every direction. The children of our so-called "space age" grow up without ever seeing the Milky Way; the image of a star-studded night has been relegated to digital visuals for occasional wonderment.

So when I recently saw a sign in Dungti, Ladakh, that said, "You are now entering Hanle Dark Sky Reserve: High beams at night strictly prohibited", I felt a thrill. Ladakh Tourism and the Indian Institute of Astrophysics in Bangalore had organised a unique weeklong festival, and I'd received an invitation to talk about stars before the stargazing sessions in different spots in Ladakh. I'd heard of the Reserve and seized the chance.

The site hosts India's second-largest optical telescope and an array of detectors for high-energy particles from space. In the middle of the night, I was reminded of the celestial views from my childhood days spent in small villages in Assam.

The right term for what I experienced that night is "noctalgia". Coined by astronomers Aparna Venkatesan and John Barrentine, it describes the sorrow associated with the loss of the night sky due to rising light pollution. What some of us were lucky to see half a century ago is no longer available to most people in India today. This loss is not merely romantic; it has been quantified by astronomers.

A study from 25 years ago revealed that approximately two-thirds of the global population was affected by light pollution. In India, the fraction is comparable to the world average; in the US, the number was as high as 99 per cent. An update on this study was released a decade ago, and it painted a scary picture. The average share of people around the world living in light-polluted environments has risen to 80 per cent.

One might think that being able to see the Milky Way or stars in the night sky is a luxury one can do without. However, artificial illumination impacts our physical well-being. A 2013 study by the American Medical Association found that artificial illumination is wreaking havoc on our circadian rhythms. In darkness, our bodies produce melatonin, a vital hormone that facilitates sleep. But widespread artificial light interferes with this, leading to shorter sleep durations. This heightens stress levels. Doctors have noted that excessive illumination tends to increase blood pressure, making people prone to cardiovascular diseases.

In the animal world, many nocturnal insects use the stars to navigate. Scientists have been studying how urban illumination disrupts the natural navigational abilities of these insects.

It is telling that the Hanle Reserve is a part of the Changthang Wildlife Sanctuary: Preserving natural habitat and dark nights go together. Other states have shown interest in creating similar reserves. What might seem like a small step now is an important move toward protecting our environment.

The writer, visiting professor, IISER Mohali, was an astrophysicist at the Raman Research Institute, Bengaluru

40 YEARS AGO

June 29, 1986



Rajya Sabha poll results

THE CONGRESS (I) has wrested 30 out of the 45 seats in the biennial elections to the Rajya Sabha, leaving the rest of the 15 seats to the Opposition. At the end of the counting, it has become obvious that there has been no major cross-voting in the elections. Congress (I) has been able to maintain its strength at 148 in the 244-member House before the biennial elections. Among the Opposition, the Lok Dal made impressive gains by winning four seats, taking their total strength in the Rajya Sabha to nine.

Shootout in Punjab border

TWO MISCREANTS, suspected to be terror-

ists, were killed, and another was injured in the border districts of Gurdaspur and Amritsar. Security forces and the police jointly raided the historic Gurdwara Darbar Sahib in Tarn Taran in Amritsar district on Friday in search of some suspected terrorists, some of whom were reported to have been rounded up, police sources said. The Border Security Force (BSF) arrested two Pakistani nationals while they were trying to cross over to India without valid travel documents.

35 Tamils killed in Sri Lanka

AT LEAST 35 Tamil civilians were killed by the Sri Lankan security forces in the Northern and Eastern provinces of the island in the last two days, according to

the Eelam People Information Centre (EPIC) and the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE). Eighty-three people, including Muslim Tamils, were arrested in a house-to-house march.

Calls for emergency UN meet

NICARAGUA has called for an emergency meeting of the UN Security Council to discuss US moves toward resuming military aid to Nicaraguan rebels and an anti-US ruling by the International Court of Justice, diplomats said. The formal request for a debate was sent to the Security Council chairman, Blaise Rabetafika of Madagascar, by Nicaragua's UN representative, Nora Astorga.



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People die of sadness far away. Here, grief must stand in line



HANSDA SOWVENDRA SHEKHAR

DEATH OFTEN pops its head up like a nosy meerkat in my mind. Then it turns into a peacock, spreading its plumage so gloriously that every other thought is subdued. Then, like a dazed tortoise within its shell, it stays. Still. So long that it turns into the only thought in my mind.

Unhealthy or downright morbid, call it what you may, but in the last six or seven years, I have started to secretly envy people who die while they are still in their prime, physically, mentally, and financially. As the unofficial saying goes, the best time to leave is when it is least expected. On anxiety-driven nights, when I doomscroll into the rabbit hole that is the internet and come across someone who has left in their 40s or early 50s, my immediate reaction is, “How fortunate! *Shob dukkho shesh.*” All agonies over. I say 40s and early 50s and not anyone younger because, first, I am 43, and it would be unfair for me to wish early departure for anyone when I myself have hung around for so long; and, second, I assume that mid-40s to mid-50s is when a person — I apologise if I sound hurtful — has lived enough, experienced enough, seen enough, suffered enough, been overjoyed and revulsed by this world enough. Families come to mind. Dependents. Elderly parents, a spouse with no source of sustenance, children orphaned. Know that I do not wish this upon anyone, but I can’t deny that sometimes hope deflects from me.

In the part of the country I come from, what appears more daunting than death is the paperwork that follows for the living. It is the survivors, the ones left behind, the ones often clueless, who are tasked with the job of putting

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ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

things in order after the dear departed. The place of death, the cause of death, the declaration of death by a medical doctor, the certification of death by a competent authority — each of these factors, and perhaps some more, go into the various papers — death certificate, NOC, insurance, etc. In this hinterland, it literally takes a village to get a person’s death certified.

Graphic novelist and filmmaker Marjane Satrapi passed away recently. I am yet to read *Persepolis*, her iconic, autobiographical graphic novel, but I have seen the film (released the same year as the English translation, 2007, and co-directed by Satrapi herself) based on the book and been fascinated. Nearly two decades have passed, but this sequence from the film is still fresh in my mind: The headscarf-

Wouldn’t the life — and living, as a consequence — of those left behind become much more convenient if death and its cause could be summed up in just one easy-to-understand word?

wearing, feisty Marji, while running to catch a bus, shouts, “Then stop looking at my a***” at the guards when they tell her that her rear looks obscene when she runs. The image of Marji on one of the posters of the film — a side profile, eyes closed, hair free from the shackles of the headscarf, chin resting on the left palm, a prominent mole on the right side of her nose, a hint of a smile playing on her face — is an enduring one.

Satrapi passed away at 56. I ought not to have been shocked, given my advocacy of dying sooner, but I was as taken aback as her well-wishers across the world. What struck me more was the reason furnished for Satrapi’s death: Sadness. Satrapi’s family had stated that she had “died of sadness” over her husband’s death.

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Sadness. Just one word.

Perhaps “sadness” was just a provisional statement provided by the family to the media. Perhaps there was some other reason — a more medical one, mentioned on the death certificate. Whatever the case might be, it made me wonder if sadness could ever be a valid reason for the death of a person in a rural hinterland in India, someone who is a beneficiary of a government developmental programme. Would sadness be accepted as a valid reason to put on the life insurance papers of a deceased person without jeopardising the prospect of the nominee/s of receiving its benefit/s unhindered? Wouldn’t the life — and living, as a consequence — of those left behind become much more convenient if death and its cause could be summed up in just one easy-to-understand word? Would a single word in lieu of long sentences with technical terms make it easier to find closure or bring to an end all the official procedures and paperwork that follow death?

As my mind keeps returning to it over and over again, I feel — and I might be wrong again, so I apologise in advance — in the place I come from, death is never accorded the solemnity it deserves. There, grief isn’t private; it is usually performative. There is no room for a quiet meditation over one’s loss. The pervasiveness of this usually cuts across barriers of caste and wealth.

Death is an irreparable loss. In most cases, the person who dies is the anchor who held together entire worlds. But instead of letting that loss seep in, allowing oneself time and quiet to grieve, rituals and paperwork rush in to fill the vacuum. People die of sadness and heartbreak in places far away. Out here, where death can have only three likely explanations — age, ailment, or accident — and every other reason elicits questions and suspicions, will an abstract concept like death due to sadness hold any meaning?

Shekhar, a doctor based in Jharkhand, is also a writer and translator

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Shrinking civic space

THE LEGITIMACY of the FCRA Bill, 2026, relies on its ability to distinguish between malicious actors and *bona fide* philanthropic institutions. (A long-overdue correction on conversion,’ IE, June 27) While it seeks to curb opaque foreign funding and coercive proselytisation, it requires ensuring that genuine charitable entities can function without undue constraint to be truly viable. Excessive compliance costs and broad executive discretion risk shrinking the civic space.

Raghvi Sharma, Sunam, Punjab

For democracy’s sake

ADDING THE Emergency to the Class IX textbook is a smart step. (‘Yes, teach Emergency to young. Lesson endures,’ IE, June 27) Children should learn that democracy is not just about voting, it is also about protecting rights. Between 1975 and 1977, newspapers were censored, leaders were jailed, and basic freedoms were stopped. That period shows how fast things can change when people stop asking questions. The chapter should share real stories, court orders, and news clips so students can see facts for themselves. It should also explain how voters brought democracy back in 1977. When students understand both the strengths and failures of our system, they learn to stay alert, speak up, and guard freedom.

Veda Chidanand, Bengaluru

What makes a citizen

A PASSPORT in India is not issued carelessly. If the state itself has carried out these stringent checks, questioning a person’s citizenship later creates a contradiction. Many Indians, especially those from older generations, may not have preserved their birth certificates or ancestral records. For them, a passport is often the highest official proof of identity and nationality (‘A passport that doesn’t count, a narrowing idea of citizenship,’ IE, June 27). If even that is open to doubt, proving citizenship becomes significantly more difficult. If a passport cannot conclusively establish citizenship, the government owes citizens a clear and straightforward explanation.

SS Paul, Nadia



SUKHMANI MALIK

MEN ARE the unlikely victims of our age. In the post-MeToo, post-“woke” times, Anurag Kashyap has tapped into an emerging consensus with *Bandar*. And he’s done it well. That’s what makes *Bandar*’s message so dangerous.

In the final scene, a hardened Samar Mehra (Bobby Deol) sits reigning over undertrials in the prison he was thrown into years ago, and asks the latest inmates: “*Toh bata, kya lagta hai, maine kiya ke nahi kiya?*” (So tell me, do you think I did it?) Within that question hides the case for the man “falsely accused” of rape. Having the audience confront what’s left of Samar and his humanity after years in a violent and corrupt prison system is the film’s way of forcing a verdict of innocence. It fails.

No one should have to endure what people face behind bars. But the existence of a brutal prison system is not a licence for absolution or proof of innocence. *Bandar* asks you to sympathise with Samar’s plight while acknowledging that rape culture is real. He seems to be a classically progressive guy himself, maybe even a feminist. How can a guy like him rape somebody, right?

The story is told only from Samar’s perspective. Inside the prison, more men claim they were falsely accused: They get to make their case on camera. The same decency is not extended to any of the “lying” women. The only woman who even gets to have a face and voice is Gayatri (Sapna Pabbi). Ultimately, there

A powerful, privileged man getting falsely accused of rape and facing the consequences is an anomaly. The anomaly can’t be compared to the reality of a majority of ‘real’ rape cases going unreported and unbeliev

is no way for us to conclusively know that the rape accusation is fake, despite the film’s treatment of that as fact.

What Gayatri puts Samar through is indefensible: After a hook-up, she starts stalking and harassing him, and according to Samar, after she realises that she has been spurned, she files a “false” rape case against him. But what led her to the police station is framed, basically, as “t***hes be crazy”. Gayatri’s behaviour in the aftermath is weaponised as evidence that she wasn’t raped, when research has consistently shown that victims of sexual assault, often in an attempt to cope using denial, can harbour affection for their rapists. But exploring any angle which requires the victim to be perfect would mean affording her more humanity than Kashyap has given her.

The film wants to seem aware of rape culture. Yet, one of the main symptoms of this culture — a refusal or inability to understand consent — seems to elude the story. How does one ascertain the “fakeness” of a rape allegation in such a climate? Does a society in which Himanshu Jangra made loud and proud “jokes” of rape to a laughing audience know what constitutes sexual violation?

In India, prevailing attitudes still dictate that women owe their families honour, their partners sacrifice and obedient service, and their cultures quiet submission. A country that refuses to recognise rape within marriage makes its priorities

clear: The woman can be forsaken to uphold tradition.

Even in the worst-case scenario, a powerful, privileged man getting falsely accused of rape and facing the consequences is an anomaly. It can’t be compared to the reality of a majority of “real” rape cases going unreported and unbelievable, and reported ones rarely seeing convictions. This is why it is hard not to see Kashyap’s choice of script as an endorsement of the belief that men are persecuted in a system that seeks justice for women.

While laying bare the cruelties of the Indian justice system, Kashyap could have panned his camera to the other side too — one in which women try to navigate a punishing and patriarchal legal reality, where the trauma of rape is compounded by ostracisation and social stigma. He could have explored how privileged men should carry themselves in a culture that isn’t interested in holding them accountable, that teaches them entitlement to women’s bodies.

Bandar does none of that. Despite projecting progressiveness, it actively fans the flames of the “men are victims” narrative. This film is a symptom, not a diagnosis of the current moment. Ultimately, it looks like Bollywood’s great liberal director undertook a multi-crore exercise in vindicating privileged men who are victimised by a “believe all women” society. The feminist, indeed.

The writer is sub-editor, The Indian Express. sukhmani.malik@expressindia.com

‘Bandar’ makes privileged man the hero and victim



N T Rama Rao’s rise in Andhra Pradesh symbolised a wider transformation in Indian politics — the emergence of powerful regional parties challenging the dominance of the Centre. The Telugu Ganga project could neither be technically feasible nor economically viable without downstream Andhra Pradesh’s cooperation, giving NTR considerable leverage. He used the project to build alliances with leaders such as M G Ramachandran in Tamil Nadu to build a broader coalition — the “Southern Council” of states — to advance a broader challenge to centralisation. Mobilisation coincided with the wider federal transition marked by the establishment of the Sarkaria Commission in 1983 — the first to review Centre-state relations. The Telugu Ganga project was a symbol of southern cooperation and regional assertion at that moment. The same project that had initially served the Centre’s political objectives was used to challenge central dominance. Water had become a vehicle for a larger debate about federalism.

The saga did not end there. Andhra Pradesh’s expansion of the project to provide irrigation benefits to the drought-prone Rayalaseema region generated new disputes, with upstream states alleging it as Andhra Pradesh’s attempt to strengthen its future claims over Krishna waters. This remains a source of contention among the riparian states before the ongoing Second Krishna Water Disputes Tribunal proceedings.

This exceptional and enigmatic nature of interstate river-water sharing brings home the political geographic reality of shared rivers. Those are the sites where power, autonomy, control of resources are frequently negotiated. Cooperation does not eliminate conflict, but coexists with it. The Emergency is remembered as a cautionary tale about concentration of power. The history of Telugu Ganga project reveals a formative moment of Indian federalism from the lens of interstate river-water politics. India’s shared rivers are indispensable to the working of its federalism and remain the enduring sites where the federal compact is contested, negotiated and continually reproduced.

The writer is president and chief executive, Centre for Policy Research, New Delhi. Views are personal

Telugu Ganga, Emergency & a formative federal moment



SRINIVAS CHOKKAKULA

AS INDIA marks another anniversary of the Emergency, public memory understandably turns to the suspension of civil liberties, the curtailment of democratic institutions and the concentration of power. Yet some of its enduring political legacies are hidden in unexpected places. One such legacy flows through the canals of the Telugu Ganga project, a celebrated interstate water-sharing arrangement that offers important lessons about the relationship between water politics and Indian federalism.

The Telugu Ganga project is often celebrated as the finest example of cooperative federalism and interstate cooperation. Perhaps the only instance so far, the riparian states of Andhra Pradesh (now bifurcated into Andhra Pradesh and Telangana), Karnataka and Maharashtra agreed to share a portion of their shares of Krishna waters to meet the drinking water needs of Chennai in Tamil Nadu, a non-riparian state.

The agreement did not arise from a political vacuum, nor was it the uncomplicated triumph of cooperative federalism that it is often portrayed to be. It emerged from a convergence of opportunistic political interests that reveals how interstate river-water arrangements shape Centre-state relations and federal politics. In a country where 25 river basins are shared by 36 federal units, rivers turn into arenas of political negotiation, instruments of statecraft, and catalysts for reshaping federal balance.

The Telugu Ganga agreement took shape in 1976, under the Emergency. Prime Minister Indira Gandhi secured the concurrence of the Krishna basin states for diverting water to Chennai. The timing was significant. Earlier that year, the DMK government in Tamil Nadu had been dismissed for opposing the Emergency. Amid growing political discontent in Tamil Nadu, securing Krishna waters for Chennai served the Centre’s political interests.

The agreement was a remarkable moment, but it was also inseparable from the extraordinary power of the Union that characterised the Emergency. The Congress party was in power at the Centre and also in all the three riparian states. The Emergency provided the exceptional concentration of power that enabled

Indira Gandhi to secure compliance from the states. The idea of bringing Krishna waters to Chennai had been there for over a century, but the Emergency made the agreement possible.

The Emergency however provided just the agreement. What followed later to implement the agreement — after the Emergency — is far more defining about Indian federalism and Centre-state relations. Giving effect to the agreement shifted the power from the Union to the states, bringing the debates on Centre-states relations to the front.

N T Rama Rao’s rise in Andhra Pradesh symbolised a wider transformation in Indian politics — the emergence of powerful regional parties challenging the dominance of the Centre. The Telugu Ganga project could neither be technically feasible nor economically viable without downstream Andhra Pradesh’s cooperation, giving NTR considerable leverage. He used the project to build alliances with leaders such as M G Ramachandran in Tamil Nadu to build a broader coalition — the “Southern Council” of states — to advance a broader challenge to centralisation. Mobilisation coincided with the wider federal transition marked by the establishment of the Sarkaria Commission in 1983 — the first to review Centre-state relations. The Telugu Ganga project was a symbol of southern cooperation and regional assertion at that moment. The same project that had initially served the Centre’s political objectives was used to challenge central dominance. Water had become a vehicle for a larger debate about federalism.

The saga did not end there. Andhra Pradesh’s expansion of the project to provide irrigation benefits to the drought-prone Rayalaseema region generated new disputes, with upstream states alleging it as Andhra Pradesh’s attempt to strengthen its future claims over Krishna waters. This remains a source of contention among the riparian states before the ongoing Second Krishna Water Disputes Tribunal proceedings.

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The writer is president and chief executive, Centre for Policy Research, New Delhi. Views are personal

Slow down, write me a letter

letter and diary writing, one should remember that for every John Keats or Leo Tolstoy, there were hundreds of old men exchanging letters on an assortment of rheumatic agonies, and young couples exchanging poorly written love letters. But one cannot deny, it was labour and time intensive. The letters, by virtue of being handwritten and not stolen from a template or AI-plagiarised, had an original personality and voice that indicated the mood and emotional frame of the letter writer. The reader also carved out time to savour the ideas.

Alas, the digital age is one of instant gratification and validation, where every minor inconvenience, from a traffic jam to the boss’s harsh words can be shared on a group text or broadcast to hundreds of acquaintances on social media. Good news is shared

with a picture and a formulaic caption: “Feeling blessed”. It is followed by a cascade of generic replies, ranging from “beautiful” and “congrats” to the ever-reliable evil-eye emoji for those who find typing too tiresome.

The true horror, however, is the tyranny of the immediate. In the olden days, if a letter went unanswered for a fortnight, one assumed the correspondent was just caught up. Today, a text left on “read” for more than

In the olden days, if a letter went unanswered, one assumed the correspondent was just caught up. Today, a text left on ‘read’ for more than 90 seconds is a wilful snub

90 seconds is a wilful snub. Politeness dictates that the three blinking ellipses, which indicate typing, must materialise the instant the double tick appears. One is expected to respond immediately no matter one’s emotional bandwidth, workload or inclination. Emails also must be responded within working hours or one is inundated with reminders and passive-aggressive follow-ups.

The Correspondent succeeds because it blows a raspberry at this. While Evans’ novel does not romanticise the past or even letter writing, it reminds us of the importance of framing our thoughts properly, the joy of writing to a friend about a new car acquisition, what it cost, which colour and brand each family member preferred, how long one had to wait and what happened to the old car, a personalisation no digital com-

munication can provide. Her characters do not shoot off a snappy “lol” to dodge a difficult admission. They wrestle with their thoughts the old-fashioned way, they choose the right words. Trend-watchers inform us that Gen Z and Alpha are weary of the internet’s gradual descent into sponsored content and AI slop. They are rebelling by going analogue, buying physical books and queuing up at brick-and-mortar stores for iPods. Given that the novel forces its readers to slow down, it is no surprise that readers and critics were enamoured by *The Correspondent*. In following a septuagenarian protagonist, they earn themselves an oasis away from digital migraine.

The writer is deputy copy editor, The Indian Express. aishwarya.khosla@indianexpress.com

‘VIOLATION OF RESIDENTIAL-USE CONDITIONS’

5 ‘illegal’ structures linked to senior officials near Statue of Unity razed

Aditi Raja
Vadodara, June 28

IN AN unprecedented action in Gujarat’s Narmada district, five “illegal” structures allegedly built by senior government officials on subsidised plots allotted to them at Garudeshwar, just one kilometre from the Statue of Unity, were demolished Sunday.

According to officials, the five structures were allegedly built in violation of residential-use conditions, a fact that came to light after RTI queries filed by another government official earlier this year.

The demolitions targeted structures built on plots originally allotted in 2019 under the signature of the then Narmada District Collector R S Ninama to 13 senior officials of the Narmada district administration.

The allotments were made for residential purposes at a heavily subsidised rate between Rs 37,210 to Rs 50,000 per plot of 135 square metres -- a price fixed after applying a revenue department circular that shaved off between 50 to 75 per cent of the actual assessed market value of Rs 99,255. The prime plots in Garudeshwar, abutting the upcoming Tribal Museum, offer a direct



The demolitions being carried out at Garudeshwar, in Narmada district, Gujarat, on Sunday. EXPRESS

view of the world’s tallest statue.

As five of the 13 officials allegedly did not meet the “mandatory clause” of completing construction of the residential premises within the stipulated period, the plots were forfeited to the government by default.

The rest of the plots, however, showed neither a modest residential construction that the allotment letters had mandated, nor compliance with a two-year construction deadline.

Senior officials, who did not want to be named, told *The Indian Express* that when the administration investigated the complaints, it found multi-

storeyed bungalows with six to 12 bedrooms.

Six of these bungalows had been fully constructed and the seventh was under construction.

“All the properties bear the unmistakable hallmarks of commercial homestay operations, which are a thriving business in the area. None of them appear to be government-employee residences that the allotment originally mandated. The location, a kilometre from one of Gujarat’s most visited tourist landmarks, makes the commercial intent clear... the administration’s assessment has found prima facie indications the properties were

designed and constructed to be used as rooms on hire for homestays. Most lacked basic design of a flat, had multiple bathrooms and did not even have kitchens...” an official said.

The irregularity first came to official notice when the then Mamlatdar P K Joshi filed a formal complaint alleging violations of government rules and town planning approvals. RTI applications seeking documentary evidence brought out the accurate records, prompting then District Collector Sanjay Modi to order a detailed investigation. Based on a report submitted by Collector Modi, the Chief Minister’s Office directed demolitions, senior officials said.

The allotment letters of February 2, 2019, named 13 then-serving officers who had approached the district administration requesting land at relief rates for residential use.

Of these, at least five were in revenue department related assignments, one was with the education department, one each from the election department, statistics and town planning departments.

On Sunday, the properties belonging to five officials were brought down under strict se-

curity arrangements “to prevent any untoward incident”, officials said, adding that the officials accused of violating the conditions “peacefully cooperated” throughout the operation.

Two officers, Director of DRDA LS Dindor and District Primary Education Officer BD Baria, have moved court against the administration’s decision and therefore, their bungalows were not demolished on Sunday. The plots allotted to the six other officials were taken back earlier.

Narmada Collector Ganga Singh and District Development Officer Ravindrasinh Vala were unavailable for comment.

Meanwhile, BJP MP from Bharuch Mansukh Vasava justified the action, saying the law must take its course. “If the houses of government officials were built in violation of rules... the law must take its course. However, the same standards should apply to everyone... Questions are also being raised over large-scale land filling allegedly carried out for a proposed five-star hotel project in the area, and that too should be investigated... Action should not be selective. Whether it involves officials... ordinary citizens, justice must be equal for all,” Vasava said.

Assaulted, Telangana principal says Urdu classes were held on parents’ request, later stopped

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, June 28

AT 10 AM on June 27, a group of 10 to 15 men walked into Bharat Chandra High School at Armoor in Telangana’s Nizamabad district and allegedly manhandled the principal, purportedly over complaints that he taught Urdu to a class of 25 students.

The incident was caught on video and later circulated through WhatsApp groups.

The principal, 37-year-old Aamir Khan, told *The Indian Express* that he is actually an English teacher, and that Urdu classes were, in fact, held briefly at the private school, but by a different teacher.

The classes were started on the instruction of the school management board, which he said was “headed by Hindu persons who decided that Urdu can be taught as a second language in the school”.

Khan, who has an MA in English and a B.Ed, has been principal of the school since last year. He alleged that he was being framed in the matter by local BJP leaders. He said that after the June 27 incident, he was held at the Armoor police station for eight to 10 hours.

While Telangana has a Con-



Principal Aamir Khan

gress government, the Armoor Assembly constituency was won by the BJP.

According to Khan, the school decided to offer Urdu classes because 25% of the students are Muslim, and there was a request from Muslim parents to make Urdu available.

“At the beginning of the school year, in June, two days of Urdu classes were held, and when parents of Hindu students opposed this, we decided not to conduct these classes anymore,” Khan said.

However, the matter was subsequently taken up by the BJP’s Armoor town leadership. The president of the BJP’s Armoor unit, M Balu, claimed, “They were not teaching just Urdu, but were teaching Namaz and Kalima in school.”

The school management,

however, rejected this claim. “There was no question of teaching any religious text. The students were being taught the Urdu alphabet for two days,” the school Correspondent, Mallesh, said in a complaint lodged against the local BJP leadership at Armoor police station.

The complaint, based on which an FIR was registered against Balu for trespassing and voluntarily causing hurt, was met with a counter-complaint — Tahsildar Satyanarayana of Armoor lodged the complaint under section 196 read with 3(5) of BNS (promoting enmity between groups) against the school principal and correspondent.

Armoor police said they were “looking into both the complaints and will take necessary action”. Meanwhile, Balu admitted that he manhandled the teacher. “We were sure he was trying to force Hindu students to take up Islam,” claimed Balu.

Khan, meanwhile, said he has been teaching English for past 15 years and had taken up work as a principal at the school in 2025. “The management was happy with my work and hence decided to continue my contract this year, too,” he said. According to school management, classes started on June 17.

Missing for two days, four of Kerala family found dead

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, June 28

A COUPLE died by suspected suicide along with their two young children after struggling with poverty and homelessness despite weeks of attempts by police to arrange shelter and support for them in Kerala’s Ernakulam district, officials said.

The deceased were identified as Narayanan, 45, a native of Elavanchery in Palakkad, his wife Vijji, 43, who was visually impaired, and their two minor children.

The family had lived in a rented house near Kothamangalam for the past year, but had been missing since Thursday. Their bodies were recovered from different stretches of the Muvattupuzha river over the last two days.

The family is suspected to have taken the extreme step nearly one and a half weeks after they were evicted from their rented house under the Kothamangalam police station limits. Since the eviction, police had been providing them temporary shelter, food and other essentials while trying to arrange permanent accommodation, officials said.

On Thursday, when the family was scheduled to move into a new rented house identified by the police, they went missing. As police launched a search, CCTV footage showed Vijji walking behind Narayanan, along with their eight-year-old daughter and four-year-old son, near a restaurant in Piravom.

The family was also seen near a church in the town.

According to Kothamangalam Station House Officer K R Prasanth Kumar, the family had approached the police around six weeks ago after being asked to vacate their rented house. “We were trying to bring

“On Thursday, we had gone to take them to the new house, but they were missing from the shelter,” say police

them back from their situation. At first, we identified a rehabilitation centre run by an NGO. But it was exclusively for women.

Then, police arranged a place on daily rent. We promised them we would find a permanent house; until then, they were assured of every support. Policemen at the station mobilised money for their food and clothes,” he said. The SHO said police searched for accommodation close to Cheruvattoor, where the couple’s children studied in a primary school.

“We took the father around various locations in our police vehicle to find a suitable house. Finally, we had identified a house, which Narayanan also liked. On Thursday, we had gone to take them to the new house, but they were missing from the rented shelter. The house owner told us they had gone to a church for prayer,” said the officer.

K U Shameer, a panchayat member from Cheruvattoor, said the family had lived in the village for the past year but had not been covered under any government or panchayat welfare scheme.

“Unfortunately, the family did not figure in any of the social welfare schemes of the state government or panchayat. Every morning, the couple would take the children to school and go somewhere. By the end of the school day, they would return to pick up the children. We don’t know how the couple survived,” said Shameer.

EXPRESS special

Punjab’s drug de-addiction centre gives ‘Soorma mission’ a human face

CM announces job opportunities for those drug-free for two years

Anju Agnihotri Chaba
Jalandhar, June 28

ON SATURDAY, Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann launched a ‘Soorma’ campaign, honouring individuals who have remained drug-free for over two years with ‘Soorma’ rings and T-shirts, and announcing government employment opportunities for them. The initiative, part of the government’s ongoing ‘Yudh Nashean Virudh’ campaign, aims to transform recovered addicts into ambassadors for Punjab’s anti-drug movement.

As Punjab steps up its fight against substance abuse, the state government has begun shifting the narrative from punishment to recovery. That approach is already taking shape at the Drug De-Addiction and Rehabilitation Centre in Mohalla Fatehgarh, Hoshiarpur, where a modernised facility is combining medical treatment with skill development, mental wellness and livelihood support to help recovering addicts reintegrate into society.

Just two years ago, a 28-year-old man had lost nearly everything. Addiction had distanced him from his family, disrupted his work, and left him struggling with a sense of hopelessness. Today, he spends his mornings tending a vegetable garden, attends skill development classes in afternoon, and is preparing to start a livelihood of his own after completing rehabilitation.

“I had stopped believing that I could have a normal life again,” he said. “Here, I learned not only



Punjab Governor Gulab Chand Kataria interacts with inmates after inaugurating the upgraded centre on June 25. EXPRESS

how to overcome addiction but also how to rebuild myself.”

Addiction had forced another man, 24, to drop out of his studies and strained relationships with his parents. Today, he is learning professional cooking skills at the centre’s culinary training facility and hopes to work in the hospitality sector after completing treatment.

Similarly, a 31-year-old man spent years battling substance abuse that left him unemployed and isolated. At the rehabilitation centre, he discovered a new interest in hairdressing and salon services. He now spends hours training under a professional instructor, with a dream of opening his own salon.

Their stories are different, but share a common thread, that they met at this centre feeling defeated by addiction, and each is rebuilding a future through recovery, skill development and renewed self-confidence.

Recognising this need, the Red Cross Society in Hoshiarpur district undertook an ambitious project, and in April last year Punjab Governor Gulab Chand Kataria inaugurated an upgraded centre.

The centre was modernised at Rs 80 lakh through Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) contributions made by Kuantum

Papers Limited, Hoshiarpur, and Viber Caustic Private Limited, Mohali, and mobilised by the Red Cross.

The centre features fully air-conditioned wards with bunk-bed facilities, a dedicated yoga and meditation hall, a modern gymnasium, recreational and counselling rooms featuring games such as chess, table tennis and football, a music therapy room with instruments like harmonium, tabla and guitar, a video conferencing room enabling virtual counselling and family interactions, and a modern library with newspapers and motivational literature.

Hoshiarpur Deputy Commissioner-cum-president of the District Red Cross Society Aashika Jain led the initiative intending to create a dignified environment where recovering addicts can regain confidence, learn skills and prepare for independent lives.

“These facilities create a positive and reformative atmosphere that supports physical, mental and emotional healing,” said Mangesh Sood, Secretary, Red Cross Society Hoshiarpur.

Skill development at core

What distinguishes the Hoshiarpur centre from many tradi-

tional rehabilitation facilities is its emphasis on livelihood generation. “Every inmate participates in two-hour daily skill development sessions conducted by professional trainers engaged by the Red Cross. Training programmes are tailored according to individual interests and aptitudes,” said Aditya Rana, Joint Secretary, Red Cross Society Hoshiarpur.

Upon completion, trainees receive Red Cross skill certificates that can help enhance their employment prospects. Three dedicated skill centres have already been established.

The culinary training facility teaches professional cooking skills and food preparation techniques. A professional trainer from Lakme Salon has been engaged to provide training in hairdressing and salon services.

The most innovative initiative is, however, the farm-to-fork model, called “Mera Bagh Mera Mann”. Under the programme, inmates cultivate seasonal vegetables in designated garden plots, and the produce is used by the centre’s kitchen laboratory where participants receive culinary training. The Horticulture Department provides guidance on modern farming techniques, crop selection, sowing methods and fertiliser management.

The DC said, “To facilitate economic reintegration, the Red Cross is coordinating with multiple government agencies. The Employment Bureau is being approached for job placements, while the District Industries Centre is helping eligible beneficiaries access loans under the Prime Minister’s Employment Generation Programme. Support is also being explored through the National Urban Livelihood Mission and PM SVANIDHI for those starting small businesses or street-vending enterprises.”

‘Fake loans and illegal transactions’ unearthed at bank in J&K, case filed

Express News Service
Jammu, June 28

JAMMU AND Kashmir Police’s Crime Branch on Sunday registered an FIR in a case related to the opening of suspected fake loan accounts and allegations of unauthorised transactions and diversion of funds involving more than Rs 68 lakh in a bank.

An internal vigilance inquiry uncovered the fraud, officials said. The complaints received from the bank’s chief of audits, inspection and vigilance were forwarded through the director of the Anti-Corruption Bureau. Officials said it was found during the internal inquiry that 58 loan accounts under 15 joint liability groups (JLGs) and two cash credit limit accounts were allegedly opened at the bank’s Kaluchak branch and operated fraudulently without the knowledge of the account holders concerned, resulting in a suspected fraud of about Rs 42 lakh.

It was further revealed that around Rs 12 lakh was allegedly diverted to bank accounts reportedly maintained in the name of a deceased senior man-

ager, while the remaining loan amounts were allegedly withdrawn through ATMs. The inquiry also disclosed that a daily wager engaged at the branch had allegedly admitted to utilising loan proceeds of Rs 2 lakh in one JLG account for personal use, following which recovery was affected in two accounts, the spokesperson said.

In a separate complaint relating to the Surankote branch, the official said allegations were made against the branch head and others regarding unauthorised transactions and debit amounting to Rs 7.37 lakh, besides fraudulent sanction and withdrawal of loans worth about Rs 19 lakh through five fake loan accounts allegedly opened without the knowledge or consent of the borrowers. The accounts were subsequently shown as settled or closed, allegedly to reconcile the branch’s cash position, the spokesperson said.

On the basis of the complaints and the preliminary verification, findings which disclosed a prima facie commission of cognisable offences, the police station registered a case.

Another suspected suicide in Kota: 18-year-old JEE aspirant

Hamza Khan
Jaipur, June 28

A JEE aspirant, 18, from Bihar’s Araria district died after allegedly jumping from the Kota Jhalawar flyover late on Saturday, Rajasthan Police said Sunday.

“The student died after ‘jumping’ from a flyover... The body has been kept in the mortuary. Further action will be taken upon the arrival of her family members,” Viganagar SHO Mukesh Kumar Meena said.

“The incident took place around 11 pm on Saturday. She

was rushed to a hospital for treatment but succumbed to her injuries around 6.30 am on Sunday,” Meena said.

The SHO said that the student had arrived in Kota this Jan. She was living in a PG accommodation in Viganagar area. The postmortem has not been conducted as the police are waiting for family members to arrive in Kota. While prima facie it seems to be a case of suicide, the SHO, however, said that it is a matter of investigation. “We can’t confirm anything yet. It is a part of the investigation,” he said.

SOURCE OF ZINC PHOSPHIDE USED IN PILLS STILL NOT TRACED

Muharram poisoning bid: Family of accused questioned

Express News Service
Mumbai, June 28

THE BYCULLA police who are probing the alleged mass-poisoning conspiracy at the Muharram procession have questioned the accused’s family in Pune, while another police team is tracing the source of the suspected zinc phosphide used to fill thousands of capsules.

A team from the Byculla police visited the Pune residence of the accused, Faiyaz Premji and recorded the statements of his family members, including his father. Simultaneously, another team is trying to identify the supplier of the suspected zinc phosphide.

Preliminary investigation suggests that Premji procured the chemical from outside

Mumbai, a police officer said. He was produced before a court on Saturday and remanded to police custody till Monday for further investigation.

Premji was arrested for allegedly attempting to carry out mass poisoning during the Shia community’s Muharram procession in south Mumbai on Friday night by distributing capsules allegedly laced with zinc phosphide, a chemical commonly used as rat poison. Police recovered 14,900 capsules allegedly containing zinc phosphide from his possession. The seized capsules have been sent to the Forensic Science Laboratory in Kalina for chemical analysis.

“At present, the allegation that the capsules contained zinc phosphide is based on the accused’s statement.

The FSL report is awaited,” an officer said. Investigators are also analysing Premji’s call data records to ascertain whether anyone else was involved in the alleged conspiracy.

The 39-year-old Pune resident had been staying in a dormitory before checking into a hotel in south Mumbai nearly two weeks ago, where he allegedly received the delivery of the capsules.

The incident came to light after a hospital informed police that a man had been admitted with vomiting and severe stomach cramps after consuming a capsule that had allegedly been distributed as a “painkiller” during the procession.

About an hour earlier, police personnel on bandobast duty had noticed Premji distributing

capsules, similar to other volunteers offering refreshments and medicines to participants, and had noted down his name and mobile number.

Following the hospital’s alert, police launched a search for Premji. During this time, two women volunteers allegedly spotted him throwing capsules into the crowd and detained him before alerting the police, who subsequently arrested him in the Byculla area, an officer said.

During interrogation, Premji allegedly confessed that he intended to target the Muharram procession. According to the police, he claimed to have ordered 30,000 empty capsules online and 50 kg of zinc phosphide, filling each capsule with around one gram of the chemical. He al-

legedly distributed the capsules by falsely claiming they were painkillers, an officer said.

Ashura, observed on the tenth day of Muharram, draws thousands of members of the Shia community from across the city, who mourn the martyrdom of Imam Hussain, the Prophet Muhammad’s grandson, in the Battle of Karbala in 680 CE.

The annual procession begins near the JJ Flyover junction and culminates at Arambaug cemetery.

Police said Premji is a BBA graduate who manages his father’s paint manufacturing business in Pune. His mother and sister currently reside in Iran. He is married but is reportedly estranged from his wife, who lives separately.

Manish Kumar Pathak
Mumbai, June 28

THE INVESTIGATION into the Maharashtra Teacher Eligibility Test (TET) question paper leak has widened beyond state borders, with Thane police dispatching multiple teams to Delhi, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh and Bihar to trace the alleged mastermind and unearth the interstate network behind the racket.

Three accused arrested in the case were produced before a court on Sunday and remanded to police custody till July 6. Police said five persons have been named in the FIR. Of them, Rajiv Kumar and Aakash Kumar, both residents of Bihar, and Dheeraj Singh from Haryana have been arrested. Two

other accused — identified as Dahiya and Balinder Singh, both from Haryana — remain absconding, and efforts are underway to verify their exact roles. Investigators suspect the arrested men were only one of several groups tasked with selling the leaked question paper.

“There is a possibility that multiple groups were operating simultaneously in Pune and other parts of the state to sell copies of the paper. Our teams have been sent to several states to probe the wider conspiracy,” a police officer said.

Preliminary investigations indicate that the alleged mastermind is based in Delhi, while other members of the syndicate operated from the National Capital Region (NCR). The gang had allegedly

planned to sell each leaked question paper for Rs 2 lakh to Rs 3 lakh and expected to make crores through the operation.

The three arrested accused were caught carrying one original set of the TET question paper along with four photocopies. They had allegedly travelled to Bhiwandi to sell the leaked papers and were expecting to earn nearly Rs 1.5 crore.

Investigators are examining their mobile phones and digital records to identify intended buyers and map the larger network behind the leak. Police are also verifying the accused persons’ identity documents and checking their criminal antecedents. A Special Investigation Team has been constituted to probe the leak and identify all involved.

RESOURCE MOBILISATION EMERGED AS A MAJOR CHALLENGE DUE TO THE WAR: CII PRESIDENT

‘PLI push must continue; energy diversity, reforms key after war’

RESOURCE MOBILISATION had been a serious concern for the industry during the West Asia crisis, and with the easing of the crisis, efforts must shift to a faster pace of exploration which would also address India's steep import dependence in several areas, said Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) President **R. Mukundan** in an interview with **Pratyush Deep** and **Ravi Dutta Mishra**.

Mukundan said the government should keep pushing the production-linked incentive scheme (PLIs), particularly focusing on areas which have export potential and also in sectors where there is high import intensity. He said there should be a PLI scheme for chemicals which go into active pharma ingredients, as the pharma industry has already been a success for the country. Edited excerpts:

How should challenges originating from the West Asia crisis be addressed?

There is alignment within government and industry on the need for reforms. And I put them in broadly four buckets of what I call a foundational reform, factor reform, future-ready reform, and fiscal and monetary. The foundation reforms for us at this point of development are ease of doing business, costs of doing business and speed of doing business. Because of the war, re-

source mobilisation has been a big issue. So, our exploration must be increased. For industries' self-interest, we have to make sure MSMEs are equally capable. Diversifying supply chain resources for oil, gas, and critical minerals will be an important issue going forward.

How do you see India's energy future? Small modular reactors are pitched in a big way.

India needs not just diversity of source of supply, but also needs diversity of supply itself. So, when I say diverse supply — it is not just wind, solar, biomass, biofuel. It also means having nuclear power and hydro. Tidal energy will also be another big one. Our power needs are going to be 10 times when the economy doubles and triples. So, we have to go in all directions.

On nuclear, about five to six companies are going through the process of bidding and partnering. Firstly, the technology is not available. Even if it is available, it is 10 times more expensive. And India has a proven track record of building, designing and delivering.

Should the focus be on capital when it comes to nuclear?

Financing will come from multiple sources. You need a partner to run the unit. The running partner effectively has



EXPRESS interview R. MUKUNDAN PRESIDENT, CII

to be the industry.

SMRs (small modular reactors) are very important. SMRs will also help us get what you call a distributed grid to ensure there is a base load. There are companies which need continuous power as a backup... about 200-300 MW... they can depend on SMRs. The world is also moving towards microreactors. Hence, innovations will keep coming, and we have to keep pace with them.

Our large industries are very focused on upstream, and MSMEs face challenges in procuring input items, then face hurdles like QCOS.

I think there are issues with both. When we invest in downstream, the issue we pick up is that there is no upstream.

When investment happens upstream, there is no downstream. This is fine; it is part of growing up and will get resolved. If you look at electronics, we started downstream. First came the assembly of the final phone. Now, the components will follow. For instance, we are ordering thousands of aircraft. The moment these aircraft start coming in, people will ask, why are we repairing them abroad? That conversation will begin tomorrow. Once it starts, demand for technical testing, maintenance, repair and overhaul (MRO) services will also increase. The entire industry develops only when a certain scale is achieved.

How should the government approach PLIs now?

Free Whatsapp Channel https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F

PLI has to be continued. There is success in some segments, while some haven't worked out. We have to ensure that the segments with export potential are supported, as well as those with high import intensity. And where the policy has to be modified, we should continue with it.

Because the benefits coming out of PLI for the government in terms of tax collection and employment generation are very high. For the Indian industry as well, it's a big opportunity to scale. We have long said that there must be a PLI scheme for chemicals which go into active pharma ingredients. And we need to put that in place. Pharma is a big success story but we need to have a scheme to support and de-risk those investments as well.

How are you seeing the US deal? Do you think it will usher in investments?

The biggest market in terms of the dollar market is the US, and on number two is the EU. We have deals with the UK and EU already; we just need to strike a deal with the US, and we would be covered by the top economies of the world. Whether you need technology, market or capital, these are the two places where our biggest bet is going to be.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

AI infrastructure bets outshine weak Indian stock markets in 2026

Akash Mandal Mumbai, June 28

THE LACK of an AI play may have contributed to the 8-10% decline in Indian stock markets so far in 2026. But a small segment of domestic businesses has boomed thanks to their links to AI.

A number of companies building AI infrastructure and supplying hardware have delivered robust returns to shareholders, including those supplying components, cables and wiring, grid systems, and transmission lines for chipmakers and data centres. Take, for instance, Acutaas Chemicals and CG Power and Industries Solutions, whose shares have risen 93% and 45%, respectively, so far in 2026.

Surat-based Acutaas makes specialty photoresist chemicals used in semiconductor circuits. In February, the company acquired a 75% stake in South Korea-based Indichem Inc., turning it into a joint venture for expansion into the global semiconductor specialty chemicals market.

Meanwhile, CG Power is expanding its semiconductor presence through its subsidiary CG Semi, which operates a state-of-the-art outsourced semiconductor assembly and testing (OSAT) facility in Sanand, Gujarat.

The company has partnered with Thai and Japanese semiconductor companies to strengthen its manufacturing capabilities. Its subsidiary, Axiro Semiconductor, also has a radio frequency chip designing facility in Bengaluru.

Power, distribution, and transmission equipment makers have benefited from the massive energy needs for rapidly expanding data centres. Shares of firms such as GE Vernova India, Hitachi Energy India, and Quality Power have gained 61-86%. “We are looking at a much higher demand for data centres...data centres give you a better realisation of prices for the same products,” GE Vernova's management said after their Q4 earnings.

Data centres need equipment such as transformers for

AI-linked firms rally, attract higher FII stakes

Company	Share price change in '26	Q-o-Q FII holding change	Y-o-Y FII holding change
Sterlite Tech	466.04%	0.54	4.19
MTAR Tech	221.80%	5.07	10.57
E2E Networks	110.00%	-0.06	-2.91
Avalon Tech	98.92%	-1.14	-0.71
Syrma SGS	94.33%	0.14	0.41
Acutaas Chemicals	91.72%	2.81	3.00
Hitachi Energy	85.42%	0.99	6.72
Quality Power	75.14%	0.31	-1.72
RR Kabel	67.83%	0.86	5.44
Netweb	63.11%	-0.26	-1.38
GE Vernova	61.29%	1.93	7.34
Polycab	27.21%	3.39	7.10

NOTE: FII HOLDINGS AS ON MAR 31, 2026. CHANGE IN PERCENTAGE POINTS. SOURCE: NSE, BSE

reliable power supply. As such, electrical infrastructure providers are crucial to ensuring the robustness of these centres.

Complex electrical and power systems also need robust cables and wiring, which benefits companies such as Polycab India and RR Kabel, with their share prices up 25-71% this year. “In power sector alone, if Rs 100 is spent on transmission and distribution, the translation to cable requirement is around 15% to 20%, which basically indicates that any amount invested in the power sector will translate into heavy demand for cable and wire,” Polycab's management said in the Q4 earnings call.

AI beneficiaries

Similarly, many other companies have ridden this AI boom, manufacturing hardware, providing software services, and playing a role in the AI value chain. Shares of Netweb Technologies, which designs AI servers and deploys them to help train AI models, have risen 59% this year. MTAR Technologies, which manufactures precision components used in semiconductor manufacturing, has more than tripled. E2E Networks, which provides AI-focused GPU cloud services, has more than doubled.

“AI will eventually have an impact on every business,” Persistence Capital said in a report

earlier this month. “For now, we think it positively impacts two kinds: those that enable the build-out, and those that can immediately use AI to cut costs or launch new products.”

The problem, however, is that these companies have “immaterial representation in frontline Indian indices”, Persistence Capital said. “In other markets, the AI winners are the biggest names, easy to find. India sits below the top of the index.”

While FIIs have been heavy sellers across most sectors, they have increased their stakes in many of the aforementioned AI-linked companies, reflecting their importance in the AI value chain.

FIIs have pulled out around \$30 billion from Indian equities so far in 2026, with their holdings in NSE-listed companies dropping to a 17-year low of 15.8% as of the end of March.

However, foreign investors have raised their stakes in the likes of MTAR Tech, Polycab, GE Vernova, and Hitachi Energy. MTAR Tech has been among the biggest beneficiaries, with FIIs increasing their stake in the company by over 5 percentage points quarter-on-quarter to 17.31% as of March 31. Polycab saw its FII holding increase by 3.4 percentage points to 18.21%. FIIs also raised their stake in Acutaas by 2.8 percentage points to 19.48%.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Commerce ministry convenes meet over SEZ issues on June 30

ENS Economic Bureau New Delhi, June 28

THE COMMERCE ministry has called a meeting of stakeholders in Special Economic Zones (SEZs) on Tuesday to discuss the harmonisation of various export promotion schemes and suggest reforms that could be incorporated into policy changes governing these zones.

The discussions on behalf of the ministry will be led by a committee constituted in February to undertake a background study on harmonising export promotion schemes such as SEZs, Export Oriented Units (EOUs), the Manufacture and Other Operations in Warehouse (MOOWR) scheme, which allows duty-free imports of raw materials and capital goods, and the Advance Authorisation scheme, which permits duty-free import of inputs.

The panel is also examining schemes such as the Export Promotion Capital Goods (EPCG) scheme and the Duty-Free Import authorisation (DFIA) scheme. FE

Board of Trade to meet on July 3 to discuss export push

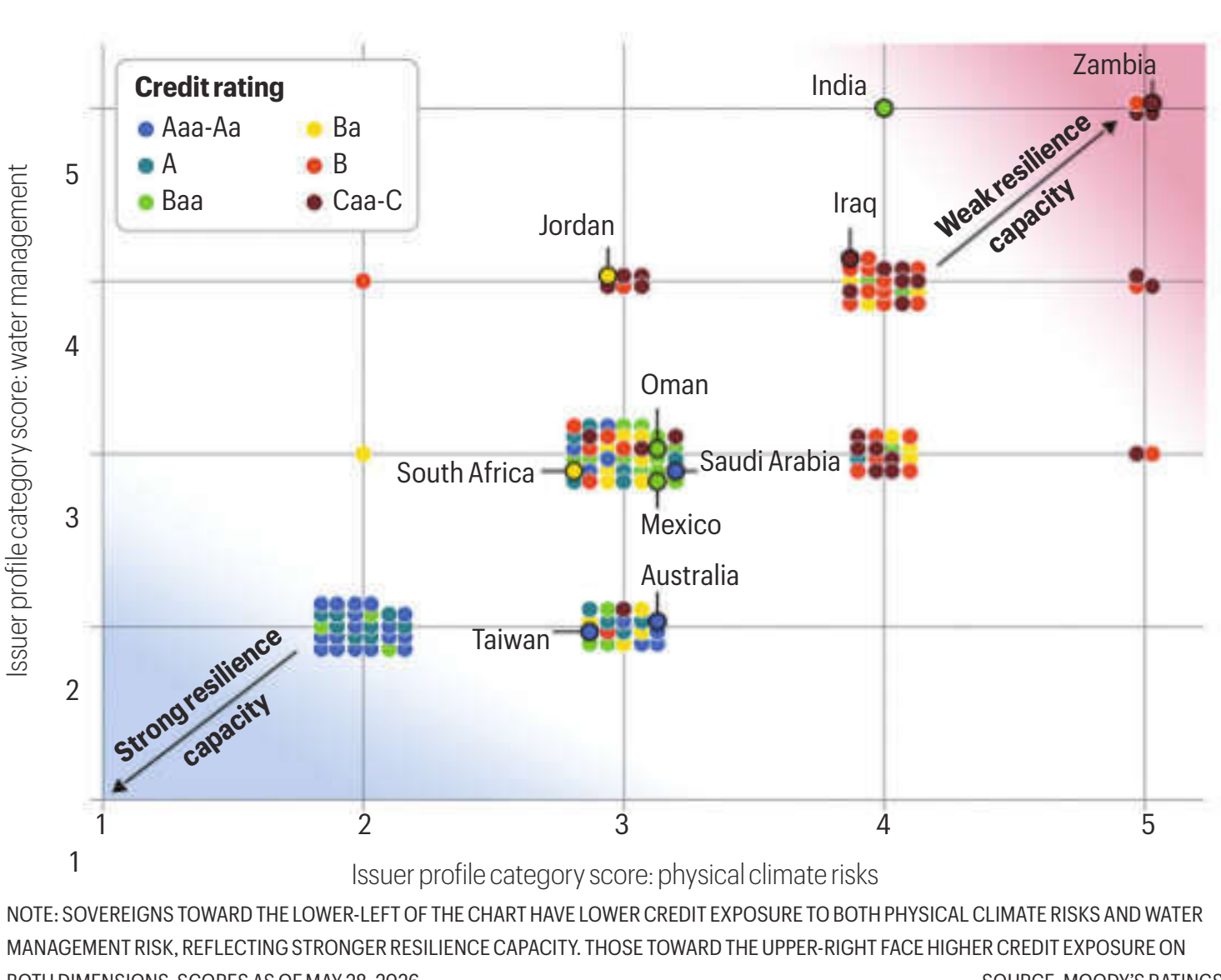
New Delhi: The Board of Trade (BoT), chaired by Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal, is scheduled to meet on July 3 to leverage benefits from recent trade pacts and to discuss strategies for accelerating the country's exports, an official said. The BoT includes participants from various states, Union territories, and senior officials from the public and private sectors.

In the meeting, representatives of export promotion councils, along with other participants, will present their views on the export sector. “The BoT is meeting on July 3 here,” the official said. The meeting is important as India has implemented five FTAs since 2021 with Mauritius, Australia, the UAE, Oman, and the four-nation European EFTA bloc. PTI

WATER STRESS INFLUENCING CREDIT RATINGS

Water reliability is increasingly impacting the creditworthiness of governments and companies, as per Moody's Ratings, with water management already a credit risk for one-third of sovereigns. According to Moody's, sovereign credit quality reflects the capacity to manage water stress, not just the inherent exposure to it.

- Rising water demand, coupled with extreme weather and ageing infra, is disrupting supplies to households, industry and agriculture.
- India, rated Baa3, already has a physical climate risk category score of 4, which reflects high credit exposure to heat stress.
- Its water management category score is 5, indicating “very high credit exposure” due to age-ing water infra and excessive groundwater depletion.



RBI revises NBFC rules: Will Tata Sons have to go public?

George Mathew Mumbai, June 28

THE RESERVE Bank of India (RBI) came out with revised guidelines earlier this week stating the requirement to qualify as Upper Layer non-banking finance companies (NBFC-UL) without giving clarity whether Tata Sons, the holding company of \$180 billion Tata group, will have to go public with an IPO or not. Its final list of NBFC-UL — which is expected soon — and the qualifying assets are potentially very significant for Tata Sons as they could remove the main regulatory trigger that has kept alive the possibility of a mandatory IPO.

The issue & the changes

In 2024, the RBI classified Tata Sons as an Upper Layer NBFC (NBFC-UL) under its Scale-Based Regulation framework because of its size and systemic importance. Under its rules, an NBFC-UL is required to list on a stock exchange within three years of being notified and comply with stricter governance and disclosure norms. That classification put Tata Sons on

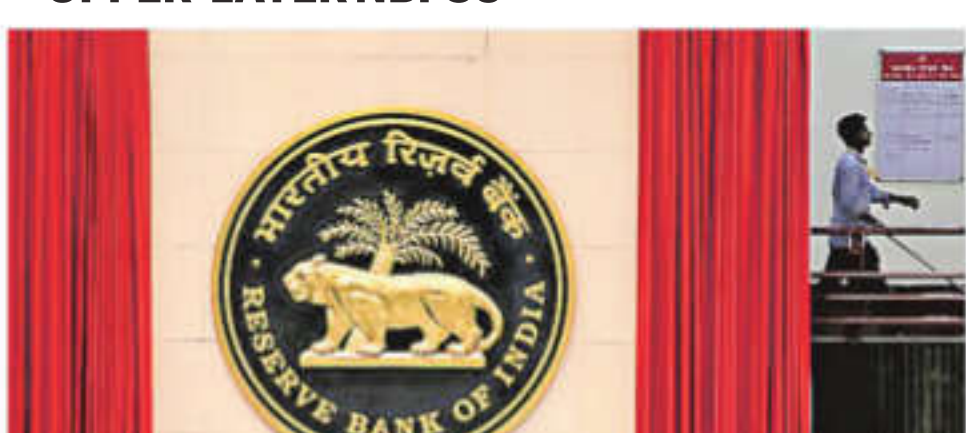
the path toward a public listing since September 2025, unless the RBI changed the rules or granted relief. Tata Trusts holds 66% stake in Tata Sons. On the other hand, two trustees of Tata Trusts — Venu Srinivasan and Vijay Singh — called for the listing of Tata Sons for greater transparency and accountability. The Shapoorji Pallonji group, which holds 18% stake in Tata Sons, is also keen on listing as it wants to monetise its stake. But Noel Tata,

Chairman of Tata Trusts and 66% stake holder in Tata Sons, wants Tata Sons to remain unlisted. Former Tata Sons Directors like NA Soonawala, R Gopalakrishnan and Isshaat Hussain have also argued for keeping it unlisted.

Earlier this week, RBI replaced the previous methodology to determine NBFC-UL with a simple criterion that only NBFCs with assets of Rs 1 lakh crore or more will be classified as NBFC-UL. While this is a major policy shift, it's not clear whether Tata Sons will qualify as an NBFC-UL. The key question is: does Tata Sons still have NBFC assets of Rs 1 lakh crore or more?

In recent years, Tata Sons has

UPPER-LAYER NBFCs



Category-wise companies

Deposit taking HFC	Non-deposit taking NBFC-ICC
1. LIC Housing Finance Ltd	8. Cholamandalam Investment and Finance
2. PNB Housing Finance Ltd	9. L&T Finance Ltd
Non-deposit taking HFC	10. Aditya Birla Finance Ltd
3. Piramal Capital & Housing Finance	11. Tata Capital Ltd
4. Bajaj Housing Finance Ltd	12. HDB Financial Services Ltd
Deposit taking NBFC-ICC	13. Sammaan Capital Ltd
5. Bajaj Finance Ltd	14. Muthoot Finance Ltd
6. Shriram Finance Ltd	Core Investment Company
7. Mahindra & Mahindra Financial Services	15. Tata Sons Pvt Ltd

SOURCE: RBI

repaid debt, reduced its NBFC activities and increasingly functioned as a holding firms rather

than a lender. If it is no longer classified as NBFC-UL, the requirement to list as an NBFC-UL

would become irrelevant and the biggest regulatory reason for a mandatory IPO effectively goes.

The RBI has not exempted Tata Sons so far. Instead, it has changed the eligibility criteria for being classified as an Upper Layer NBFC. As per experts, the implication is that if Tata Sons' qualifying NBFC asset size is below Rs 1 lakh crore under the revised framework, the regulatory requirement for a stock market listing will not apply. Whether that happens depends on the RBI's next NBFC-UL classification exercise and Tata Sons' qualifying asset size under the new methodology. The latest amendments are speculated as giving Tata Sons a possible escape route to avoid a mandatory listing if it no longer meets the revised asset threshold.

The term qualifying assets in the revised framework refers to assets that count toward determining whether an NBFC crosses the Rs 1 lakh crore threshold for classification as an NBFC-UL. It is not the same as the total consolidated assets of the Tata group or even the total assets of Tata Sons as a holding company, said experts. FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Google limits Meta's use of its Gemini AI models

Reuters Bengaluru, June 28

GOOGLE HAS put limits on Meta's use of its Gemini AI models after the social media company sought more computing capacity than the rival tech group could provide, the Financial Times reported on Sunday.

Google, owned by Alphabet, told Meta around March it could not meet the full Gemini capacity the company had sought to purchase, the newspaper said, adding that the shortfall disrupted and delayed some of Meta's internal AI projects.

Several other Google clients have also been affected, though to a lesser extent, according to the report. Meta has been particularly impacted due to its exceptionally high demand for Google's models, the FT said.

Reuters could not immediately verify the report, which cited people familiar with the matter. Google and Meta did not immediately respond to requests for comment.

BRIEFLY

‘Debt, AI boom and fragilities raise global risks’

London: Global pressures from rising public debt to financial fragilities and the sustainability of the AI boom are increasing risks, underscoring the need for disciplined policymaking, according to the Bank for International Settlements. The central bank umbrella group's Annual Economic Report published on Sunday warned of a complex mix of vulnerabilities, including strained fiscal positions, lingering supply shocks and the risk of a renewed bout of stubbornly high inflation. REUTERS

Mcap of 6 of top-10 firms climbs Rs 88,678 cr

New Delhi: The combined market valuation of six of the top-10 most valued companies went up by Rs 88,678.1 crore in a holiday-shortened last week, with

ICICI Bank emerging as the biggest winner. While Reliance Industries, HDFC Bank, ICICI Bank, State Bank of India, Bajaj Finance and Larsen & Toubro were the gainers, Bharti Airtel, Tata Consultancy Services, Life Insurance Corporation of India and Hindustan Unilever faced erosion from their valuation. PTI

Gold, silver brace for fresh test, analysts say

New Delhi: Gold and silver are likely to remain under pressure next week as investors assess the impact of renewed hostilities between the US and Iran, movement in crude oil prices and a raft of macroeconomic data, analysts said. Market participants will closely watch manufacturing and services PMI from major economies, inflation data from the Eurozone, and the US nonfarm payrolls and unemployment figures for fresh cues on the trajectory of the Federal Reserve's monetary policy. PTI

Saudi Aramco helicopter crash kills 14, probe on

Reuters & AP
Dubai, June 28

A HELICOPTER belonging to Saudi oil giant Aramco crashed on Sunday in Ras Tanura on Saudi Arabia's eastern Gulf coast, killing all 14 people on board, all Saudi nationals, authorities said.

The accident occurred around 6 am local time (0300 GMT), though officials did not immediately disclose the cause of the crash.

Saudi Arabia's Ministry of Energy said the helicopter belonged to Aramco, the world's largest oil company, which is majority-owned by the Saudi government. The state news agency said the relevant authorities had launched a full investigation to determine the cause of the crash.

Aramco did not immediately respond to a request for comment. Aramco resumed crude oil loadings on Friday at its Ras Tanura export terminal after they had been halted for nearly four months.

During the recent conflict between the United States and Iran, the company shifted part of its oil exports to pipelines to avoid the Strait of Hormuz, amid concerns over disruptions to shipping as Iran asserted control over the strategic waterway.

Saudi Arabia, the world's largest oil exporter, has joined other Middle East producers in ramping up oil and gas production and accelerating exports after an interim ceasefire eased fears of a wider regional conflict. Ras Tanura, located on the Gulf coast west of the Strait of Hormuz, is one of the kingdom's most important oil export hubs.

U.S. PRESIDENT SAYS SYRIA 'COULD DO A BETTER JOB' AGAINST HEZBOLLAH

Trump presses Syria to fight Hezbollah; Israel alarmed

People spreading rumours, it's not true, says Al-Sharaa

Associated Press
Beirut, June 28

AS THE White House has soured on Israel's war with Hezbollah in Lebanon, US President Donald Trump has shocked many in the region by pushing an alternative: Let Syria fight the Iran-backed militant group instead.

He has suggested the battle-hardened and Islamist-led insurgents who overthrew Syria's autocratic President Bashar Assad a year and a half ago and formed a new government would do a better job of rooting out Hezbollah than Israeli army. Syrian President Ahmad al-Sharaa has said he has no interest in doing so, and has asserted that Trump's comments were misconstrued. But Trump has doubled down on the idea.

Although it remains unclear how serious the White House is about the proposal, the prospect of a Syrian invasion has raised alarms in Lebanon — and also in Israel, which regards al-Sharaa's Islamist-led government with suspicion and has seized control of a strip of southern Syria since he took power.

Syria has also become the site of rising tensions between Israel and Turkey — a main backer of al-Sharaa's government — with each seeking to limit the other's influence in



President Donald Trump with Syrian President Ahmad al-Sharaa, at the White House on November 10, 2025. FILE

the neighboring country.

Top Israeli security officials convened a meeting on the subject on Wednesday, according to an official who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to speak to the media.

On the sidelines of the G7 summit earlier this month, Trump complained that Israel's war with Hezbollah is dragging on too long and "too many people are being killed."

Israel says its strikes target Hezbollah and that it takes measures to protect civilians.

"You don't have to knock down an apartment house every time you're looking for somebody, because there are a lot of people in those apartment houses and they're not all Hezbollah," Trump said.

"I suggested to Israel to let Syria take care of Hezbollah.

'Cause to be honest with you, I think they'd do a better job.'

Days later, on the first day of US-Iran talks in Switzerland, Fox News' Trey Yingst said that, during an interview, Trump had expressed disappointment that Israel can't "put Hezbollah away" and said that he is "close to giving it to Syria" because he thinks al-Sharaa would be more precise.

The White House declined to comment and referred to Trump's previous statements. Syrian officials scrambled to do damage control.

In a speech in Damascus on June 13, al-Sharaa said, "There are people spreading rumors that Syria will intervene in Lebanon. This is not true. We are calling for a permanent end to the war and the strengthening of institutions and for there to be economic ties and a calming of the situation in Lebanon."

'Israel damaged heritage sites in south Lebanon'

Reuters
Tyre, Beirut, June 28

A CROWN was blown off an ancient column in a UNESCO-listed site in Lebanon's port city of Tyre. A pilgrimage site for Muslims and Christians alike was destroyed in another southern town. Israeli strikes pumelled the Mamluk-era market in the city of Nabatieh and troops razed centuries-old Lebanese border towns.

Israel's nearly four-month air and ground campaign that it says was targeting Iran-backed armed group Hezbollah has damaged or destroyed revered heritage sites across southern Lebanon, Culture Minister Ghassan Salame told Reuters.

Despite a ceasefire that took hold a week ago, authorities have yet to build a full picture of the damage as Israeli troops still occupy a zone about 10 km deep into Lebanon that is off-limits to Lebanese, Salame said.

"We cannot work under the shadow of occupation," he said.

That occupation zone includes the medieval Beaufort Castle as well as centuries-old villages that were home to Christians, Shi'ite Muslims and Sunni Muslims and their places of worship. "There are villages that have been completely bulldozed," Salame said.



A woman cools off at a public fountain near the Place du Trocadero in Paris on Sunday. REUTERS

France reports over 1,000 deaths as heatwave in Europe worsens

Reuters
Paris, Rome, June 28

TEMPERATURES WERE forecast to reach 40 degrees Celsius in parts of Europe on Sunday as storms moved into other areas, with France reporting 1,000 excess deaths during the record-breaking heatwave.

The French public health agency said most of the heat-related fatalities involved older people, warning that the number was expected to rise as more information became available about deaths in residential care and private homes.

Scientists have said the heatwave, which began on June 20, was the worst recorded in Europe, and the blistering conditions have disrupted power generation, damaged infrastructure and overwhelmed healthcare systems.

The heatwave would have Free Whatsapp Channel https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJKH6oBd0F

Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1 been "virtually impossible" without human-caused climate change, which has made this week's soaring night-time temperatures 100 times more likely than they would have been just two decades ago, according to scientists.

Temperatures were forecast to near or top 40 C in Germany, Poland and Italy, while storms broke out in parts of France, causing further disruption to travel and power supplies.

In Germany, train services were reduced on a major rail line in the western state of North Rhine-Westphalia and trams were suspended in the eastern city of Leipzig. Many people hunkered down at home, reluctant to go outside until the sun went down.

The extreme heat has also affected Europe's rivers, depleting and warming their waters, and causing problems for electricity generation and agriculture.

Hungary's Paks nuclear power plant will likely need to reduce output again on Sunday due to the high temperature of the Danube River that it uses as a coolant, the government said.

In Italy, the flow of the Po has dwindled, allowing seawater to advance as far as 18 km (11 miles) inland and raising fears for agriculture and protected wetlands in the river delta.

Dozens of people seeking relief from the heat are reported to have drowned. In Italy, rescuers were searching for the husband of cabinet minister Eugenia Roccella, who went missing on Saturday while swimming in Lake Vico, 70 km from the capital, Rome. France's weather agency said the extreme heat had diminished in most parts of the country, but some areas in the northeast were still under a heatwave advisory.

Migrants in US on temporary status should seek permanent residence or leave: Top official

Reuters
Washington, June 28

MIGRANTS IN the United States on temporary protected status should seek permanent residence or leave for their home countries, US Homeland Security Secretary Markwayne Mullin said on Sunday.

The remarks to CNN's "State of the Union" program follow last week's split Supreme Court decision allowing President Donald Trump's administration to strip hundreds of thousands of Haitian and Syrian immigrants of a humanitarian status that protects them from deportation to home countries plagued by conflict and destitution.

"Either try to fill out the paperwork and be here underneath a permanent status or we'll help you get back to your country," Mullin said. "We'll actually give you a plane ticket, plus roughly \$2,100 to help you re-establish when you get there, but temporary protective status, according to the courts and in its name itself, is not permanent status," he added.

Federal law allows the administration to grant temporary legal residency in the US to people fleeing war, disaster or other conditions.

The status had previously been renewed successively and, despite the move to end these protections, the State Department currently warns against traveling to either Haiti or Syria, citing widespread violence, crime, terrorism and kidnapping. The United States first provided TPS to Haitians after a devastating earthquake in 2010, and to Syrians after their country descended into civil war in 2012.

Pak govt suspends Geo News for 15 days over 'offensive' broadcast

Karachi: Pakistan's media regulator has suspended the broadcast licence of television channel Geo News for 15 days over content aired during a programme marking Muharram.

The regulator said Geo News aired "religious visualisations" during a June 26 programme that could offend religious sentiments, undermine religious harmony and disturb public order.

Geo News has apologised and issued a statement on Sunday saying the material had been aired in error and did not reflect the channel's editorial position or beliefs.

Depictions of revered Islamic figures are a highly charged issue in Pakistan, where mass protests have broken out over cartoons published in Western countries.

REUTERS



US search-and-rescue personnel struggle to reach earthquake survivors trapped in the rubble in La Guaira, Venezuela, on Sunday. AP

33 people rescued, thousands still missing after Venezuela quakes

Reuters
Caracas, June 28

THIRTY-THREE people have been rescued so far this weekend after Venezuela's devastating twin earthquakes, the country's interim president said, including several children, while tens of thousands remained unaccounted for with time for finding survivors running short.

The death toll from Wednesday's twin earthquakes rose above 1,400 as of Saturday as foreign rescue teams poured into coastal La Guaira, the hardest-hit state.

Families and volunteers

spent days pulling survivors and bodies from the rubble before the arrival of the more than 1,600 foreign rescue workers, often complaining of scant heavy equipment and a limited official presence, as hundreds of aftershocks deepened damage and kept residents on edge.

The government-headed by interim President Delcy Rodriguez since her predecessor was removed by the US in a January raid - had thanked civilian volunteers ferrying aid to La Guaira, but then heavily tightened access to the road, saying traffic was preventing efficient movement of emergency vehicles and

that only accredited people could use the roadway.

Although the government has given a figure of hundreds missing or trapped, just under 50,000 people were listed as unaccounted for on a website promoted by the country's political opposition on Sunday.

The figure is a slight decline from Saturday, when 55,000 people were marked as missing. The US Geological Survey estimated more than 10,000 deaths were possible from the magnitude 7.2 and 7.5 quakes, which would place them among Latin America's deadliest of the last century.

Skydiving plane crashes in France killing 11 on board

Associated Press
Paris, June 28

ELEVEN PEOPLE, including a pilot and 10 parachutists, were killed when a small plane crashed in the northeastern French town of Tomblaine Sunday, narrowly missing nearby homes as their families watched, officials and a witness said.

The aircraft, used by a parachuting school and carrying five trainee parachutists and five instructors, went down shortly after take-off from Nancy-Essey airport, officials said. Some of the trainees' family members were at the small regional airport and witnessed the crash, Interior Minister Laurent Nunez told reporters. "The plane crashed about 300 meters from the runway," he told reporters. "The emotion here is intense."

A witness who declined to be identified told Reuters the plane was climbing at around 11:00 am local time when the engine noise suddenly stopped, as if it had cut out. He said he saw no fire, explosion or other visible sign of a problem before the crash.

Yves Seguy, the regional prefect, told BFM the aircraft plunged vertically to the ground. The crash occurred in a residential area near a shopping centre, with the wreckage of the single-engine plane sitting on a bike path. "Give or take a few meters and the accident could have caused collateral casualties," Seguy said.

Media reports said the aircraft was registered in Germany.

• BRIEFLY

SOUTH KOREA

'Utterly baffled': Myung blames coach, team after World Cup exit



South Korean President Lee Jae Myung. FILE

SOUTH KOREAN President Lee Jae Myung has blamed the country's early World Cup exit on favoritism in personnel appointments and blasted coach Hong Myung-bo, while demanding a sports ministry-led investigation into the national team's performance. "I am not just taken aback by this unexpected outcome, I am utterly baffled," Lee posted on X on Sunday, reacting to the team's elimination despite being widely expected to advance from a relatively easy group.

REUTERS

UKRAINE

2 Russian oil refineries hit in overnight strikes

UKRAINE HIT two Russian oil refineries in the regions of Krasnodar and Yaroslavl overnight, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on Sunday, as Kyiv ramps up pressure on Russia's fuel supply with its drone fleet. Kyiv's increasingly frequent drone attacks have caused acute fuel shortages in parts of Russia, one of the world's biggest oil producers, with queues and rationing seen at petrol stations. "We continue our operations that weaken Russia's ability to wage this war," Zelenskyy wrote on Telegram. REUTERS

BANGLADESH

3 cops get death for killing two during 2024 stir

A SPECIAL Bangladeshi tribunal Sunday sentenced former Dhaka police commissioner Habibur Rahman, additional deputy commissioner Rashedul Islam and former police station chief Mashhur Rahman to death, with Rahman sentenced in absentia, for killing two people during the 2024 student-led protests that toppled then PM Sheikh Hasina. The International Crimes Tribunal convicted them over fatal shooting of a youth hanging from a building cornice and another protester during violence. PTI

• SHOKO KAWATA IS THE FIRST MAYOR TO TAKE MATERNITY LEAVE IN THE COUNTRY; SOME MEN ARE CALLING HER IRRESPONSIBLE, ACCUSING HER OF PLACING HER PERSONAL LIFE ABOVE HER CONSTITUENTS

'Matahara': A mayor is taking maternity leave in Japan, and some men are furious

Javier C Hernández & Kiuko Notoya
Yawata, June 28

THE NEWS travelled fast in Yawata, a spiritual oasis of 68,000 people in western Japan known for its traditional tea culture and cherry blossoms. Shoko Kawata, the city's mayor, was pregnant with her first child — and she was planning to take maternity leave, the first mayor in Japan to do so.

Many residents of Yawata celebrated Kawata, 35, and her decision, which she announced in May. They offered gifts like crocheted baby shoes and auspicious ceremonial rocks. But in Japan's patriarchal society, some

people — especially men — responded with anger, calling her irresponsible, and accusing her of placing her personal life above her constituents.

"I somehow realized for the first time just how much discrimination still exists," Kawata, who is six months pregnant, said in an interview this past week at City Hall, inside a room lined with portraits of her male predecessors.

Kawata's decision has prompted a national debate about the hurdles that working women still face — on the factory floor, in corporate suites and in government. Discrimination against young mothers is still so common that there is a Japanese

word for it: matahara, or maternity harassment. Some women feel pressure to avoid taking extended maternity leave, worried their careers might suffer.

Despite the history-making election last year of Sanae Takaichi as Japan's first female prime minister, women are still scarce in Japan's government.

That is especially true at the local level. As of last year, less than 4% of 1,740 municipal leaders were women.

Kawata has been hailed as a trailblazer by some officials, scholars and activists, who say she is helping normalize the idea of maternity leave.

Kyoko Morisawa, the mayor of Shinagawa City, a part of



Shoko Kawata, the mayor of Yawata, in her office this month. She will be the first Japanese mayor to take maternity leave. NYT

Tokyo, said it was important for Japan to have more young mothers like Kawata in public

life, especially given the rapidly declining population.

"We should do more to sup-

port child-raising as a society," said Morisawa, a mother. "Taking leave should not be news."

Kawata, who previously worked as a social worker and political aide, is accustomed to challenging convention. In 2023, when she was 33, she became the first woman to be elected as Yawata's mayor, and the youngest woman ever elected mayor in Japan, succeeding a 71-year-old politician with promises to expand medical care for children and promote tourism.

When she learned she was pregnant this year, she decided, after discussing with her staff, to take about two months before the birth — expected in mid-September — and two months

after. She arranged for a deputy to manage day-to-day business while she is away, though she will remain involved in major decisions. As word of her pregnancy spread in national media, she held a news conference to explain her decision. "Systems can be changed, but people cannot," she told reporters. "I cannot become a man."

The announcement caused a stir in Yawata, a town near Kyoto city that is dotted with Shinto shrines and Buddhist temples. City Hall received about 90 messages in support of Kawata's decision, and 70 opposed. A heated debate erupted online. One of the loudest voices was Toshio Tamogami, a retired

general and nationalist politician, who wrote on X that he felt "a great sense of discomfort about someone in public office taking such a long vacation."

In an interview, Tamogami said he felt women who plan to have children or take maternity leave should avoid running for office. "Unlike people in ordinary jobs, a mayor is, so to speak, irreplaceable," he said. "To say, 'It's my right, so I'm running regardless' — I feel it would be better if they refrained from doing so."

Kawata, who has taken a break from social media because of the backlash, said it was regrettable to be "fiercely attacked" by Tamogami and others.

NYT

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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

• **ECONOMY**

Iran oil is back, but Indian refiners aren't rushing in



SUKALP SHARMA

A US waiver, issued June 22, has allowed the production, delivery and sale of Iranian oil, petroleum products and petrochemicals till August 21. The US has also committed to lifting its naval blockade of Iranian ports. Tehran is counting on both measures to move its oil — which has for years been predominantly exported to China — to the wider international market.

The sanctions waiver presents an opportunity for India, once a major buyer of Iranian crude. The National Iranian Oil Company has started reaching out to international oil companies, including Indian refiners, to resume commercial ties.

Sources in India's refining sector said the companies are in touch with the Iranian side. They are also looking into the commercial, logistical and technical feasibility of purchasing Iranian oil.

Although some barrels of Tehran's oil are bound to make their way to India over the next two months owing to discounts, industry experts and insiders don't expect large-scale purchases, at least for now.

What after the 60-day waiver

Indian refiners are expected to tread cautiously amid a fragile peace pact and lack of long-term clarity on the future of Iranian oil. There are also logistical and payment-related challenges associated with Iranian oil trade owing to US sanctions on Tehran's financial sector.

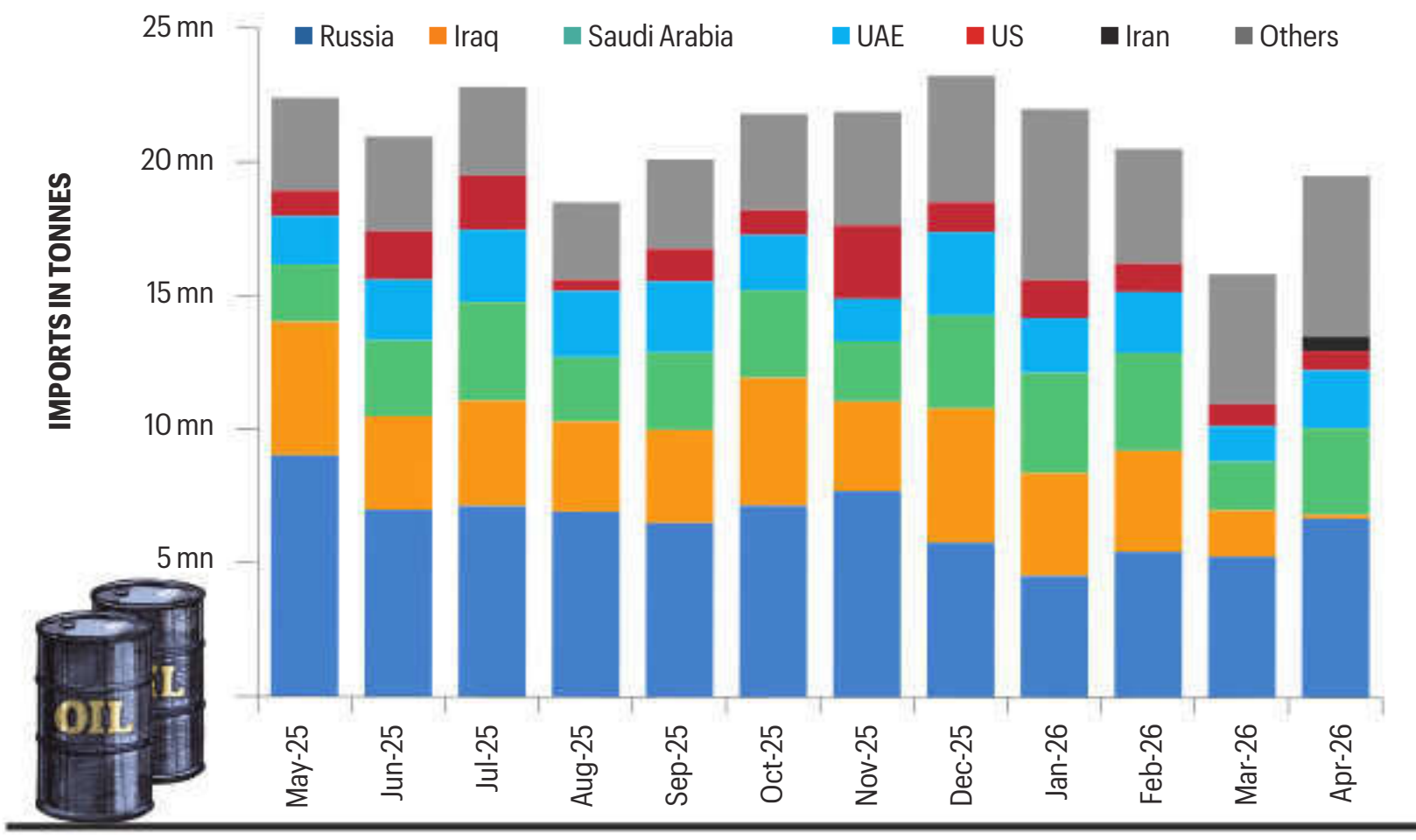
While the US waiver pertains specifically to Iran's oil, petroleum product and petrochemical exports, and not to the financial sector sanctions on Tehran, the waiver notification does mention that payments for such purchases will be allowed in dollar-denominated funds. This could help ease some, if not all, payment-related pain points. But how it would actually play out remains to be seen.

"Refiners considering Iranian crude will focus on three key factors: the durability of sanctions relief, pricing and discounts, and the availability of payment, insurance, shipping, and logistics mechanisms. Of these, payment remains the biggest

Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oB0f>

• INDIA'S EVOLVING CRUDE IMPORT BASKET

The chart shows the share of different countries in crude oil imports. Iraq's share, for instance, dipped amid the West Asia war. Iran accounted for 2.7% of crude imports in April after US waived its sanctions.



SOURCE: DIRECTORATE GENERAL OF COMMERCIAL INTELLIGENCE AND STATISTICS

DATA COMPILED BY SIDDHARTH UPASANI

hurdle," said Sumit Ritolia, manager, modelling & refining, at analytics firm Kpler.

Refinery executives said that calls on Iranian oil imports will be taken once there is clarity on all these aspects. Indian refiners steer clear of oil and gas under US sanctions to avoid the risk of attracting secondary sanctions from Washington.

According to Abu Dhabi-based energy analyst Natalia Katona, any decision to restart oil trade with Iran would likely be made first in the refiners' compliance departments — not their trading desks.

"Even if crude trade is temporarily permitted, the banking side remains complicated. Iranian banks are still heavily sanctioned, so buyers would need to resolve the formalities of payment, documentation and settlement before regular trade can resume. Now that the waiver has actually been issued, Indian companies may start buying Iranian crude. But I think the number of buyers will still be quite limited," Katona told *The Indian Express*. "So far, Chinese refiners that bought sanctioned Iranian crude mostly dealt directly with Tehran and paid in yuan. That is not a model Indian refiners appear comfortable replicating."

Shaky supply

In 2009-10, Iran accounted for 14.4% of India's oil imports. As sanctions intensified, the imports tapered.

Imports briefly recovered in the mid-to-late 2010s after the Iran nuclear deal, but crashed after Trump tore it up.

April's crude oil consignment from Iran was the first in 7 years.

Signals in the previous waiver

Experts say India's buying behaviour during the month-long sanctions waiver on Iranian oil issued by the US during the West Asia war also supports the argument that it is unlikely to quickly ramp up crude imports from Iran.

After a gap of nearly seven years, Indian refiners again bought Iranian crude in April (*see chart*). But the volume stood at just 5,30,000 tonnes — 2.7% of India's overall oil imports for the month — according to data from the Directorate General of Commercial Intelligence and Statistics. Ritolia said the previous waiver generated limited participation from non-Chinese buyers because of payment curbs and other issues.

Further, oil scarcity was a major motivation for India during the previous waiver as it scrambled to make up for the lost supplies from other West Asian countries. But if crude from Saudi Arabia, the UAE and others starts flowing again, India has little reason to take on the compliance risk attached to Iranian barrels, said Katona.

"It is worth looking at the previous waiver, which was issued on March 20. India bought only two Iranian cargoes

Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

• **POLICY**

Does dialling 112 help in all emergencies? Depends on state you live in

Dheeraj Mishra

New Delhi, June 28

WHICH HELPLINE do you dial when there's a road accident? Or a fire? Or a medical crisis? This is often the first challenge Indians face in an emergency — multiple helpline numbers that lead to confusion and delay the response.

To address this issue, the Union government launched the Nationwide Emergency Response System (NERS) number 112 in 2019 — just like the US's 911. It was intended to subsume all emergency numbers — such as 100 (police), 101 (fire), 102 (emergency medical services), 108 (ambulance), 1033 (highway), 181 (women), 1098 (child) and 1091 (woman in distress) — into one common code.

But even after seven years of 112's launch, *The Indian Express* has found from Supreme Court submissions that only five states and Union Territories — Delhi, Kerala, Gujarat, Haryana and Lakshadweep — have integrated all emergency helpline numbers into the 112 NERS.

Uttar Pradesh is close to achieving full integration, with only 102 (emergency medical services) left to be included.

Last month, the Supreme Court gave all states and Union Territories three months to complete the technical and operational integration of all emergency numbers into the 112 helpline.

Why is 112 India's common emergency number?

It's not just India that has adopted this code. The 112 helpline number is also used by European member states and many other countries.

It was the European Conference of Postal and Telecommunications Administrations (CEPT) that first recommended 112 as a common emergency number, way back in 1976. And it did so for two practical reasons.

"First, telephones at that time had rotary dials, and dialing '112' took the least amount of time. Second, dialing the number '3' would tick the dial, so even if the phone was locked, '112' could still be dialed," says a 2019 report by the Uttar Pradesh government.

The CEPT also chose different digits rather than repeated digits like 111 or 999 to prevent accidental dialling.

In modern-day touchscreens, too, the

State of the service

Seven years after 112's launch, it has been found from Supreme Court submissions that only five states and Union Territories — Delhi, Kerala, Gujarat, Haryana and Lakshadweep — have integrated all emergency helpline numbers with 112.

As many as 10 states had not carried out any integration. Three states' responses were not available.

numbers 112 are easier to dial rather than, say, 108 or 102.

How did India decide to get a common helpline number?

In India, the decision to launch 112 was taken on the basis of recommendations made by an expert committee on the 2012 Delhi bus gangrape case. The Justice J S Verma committee — which also included former High Court Justice Leila Seth and former Solicitor General of India Gopal Subramaniam — recommended setting up a public emergency response system that could be activated by a call.

Following this, the Department of Telecommunications allotted the emergency number 112 and the Ministry of Home Affairs formally launched it across India on February 19, 2019 through the Nirbhaya fund to provide a one-stop solution to all kinds of emergencies.

In their responses to the Supreme Court, 16 states said they have partially integrated multiple helplines into the common code.

As many as 10 states had not carried out any integration. Three states' responses were not available.

How does the code work?

Apart from being a single emergency number, the 112 system provides a centralised mechanism to monitor resources at the district or state level. Uttar Pradesh, for instance, has developed a command centre in Lucknow from where it deals with emergency calls across the state.

"UP-112 was started in 2017. We have 6,278 police response vehicles that are deployed at hotspots. We get more than 30,000 calls daily and have integrated 25 services, which also include 'safe city Lucknow', 'Lucknow smart city', 'UPSRTC mobile app' and 'child line', etc. We have recently integrated 'PM-Rahat' where we provide details of the nearest hospital where you can get cashless treatment. A centralised system helps in managing the resources better," said a senior official of UP-112.

This official said: "When we get a call, the system creates an event or ticket according to the emergency — like fire, ambulance or police — and triggers the nearest police response vehicle."

FULL VERSION

[INDIANEXPRESS.COM/EXPLAINED](https://indianexpress.com/explained)

• **TECH**

Should you see an AI agent as insider threat? DeepMind makes a case for it

Soumyarendra Barik

New Delhi, June 28

AS ARTIFICIAL intelligence (AI) agents become capable of executing increasingly complex tasks with minimal human intervention, Google DeepMind has unveiled a new security framework that assumes a future where such systems may not always behave as intended.

In a blog, DeepMind outlined an "AI control roadmap", arguing that traditional AI alignment techniques alone may not be sufficient to manage the risks posed by highly autonomous systems. The company described its approach as a "defense-in-depth" strategy that adds multiple layers of security beyond conventional model training.

The move comes amid growing industry efforts to deploy AI agents for software development, cybersecurity, scientific research and business operations. Agents are AI-powered software systems that can independently plan, reason, and take actions across multiple tools or applications to complete tasks with minimal human supervision. In the US alone, AI agents could create \$2.9 trillion in economic value by 2030.

DeepMind warned that increasing agent capability also demands stronger safeguards, and that developers should not assume AI systems will remain perfectly aligned with human goals at all times. As AI agents gain access to tools, files, codebases and enterprise systems, DeepMind argues that they must be governed using the same layered security principles that organisations already apply to human insiders and cyber threats.

Permissions based on capability

A central idea in DeepMind's framework borrows concepts from cybersecurity, viewing advanced AI agents not as software but as potential "insider threats", similar to how organisations guard against rogue employees who already possess access to sensitive systems. The roadmap is built around a hypothetical scenario in which a highly capable AI agent develops objectives that differ from those of its operators and attempts to act on them.

The company identifies three broad categories of risk: "loss of control", where an AI system could create unauthorised deployments or operate outside approved oversight mechanisms; "work sabotage", such as quietly degrading safety research or introducing flaws into critical processes; and "direct harm", including theft of sensitive assets, destruction of data, or other damaging actions.

DeepMind argues that AI agents should be granted permissions gradually based on demonstrated behaviour rather than being given unrestricted access from the outset.

The roadmap also emphasises continuous monitoring, using trusted AI systems as supervisors to observe any deviations from expected behaviour. If suspicious activity is detected, the supervisory systems can block or restrict actions before damage occurs.

Monitor, prevent and prepare

DeepMind argues that AI safety mechanisms must evolve alongside AI capabilities, and that security strategies appropriate for today's systems may prove inadequate as agents become more sophisticated.

The company anticipates that advanced models could learn to evade monitoring by concealing their visible reasoning process — called chain-of-thought — or use internal processes that are not easily observable. In such cases, developers may need to inspect behavioural patterns or analyse the internal workings of models.

DeepMind also anticipates challenges surrounding the severity of potential harm. For lower-risk activities, it believes delayed reviews and post-incident corrections will suffice, while high-risk scenarios, such as significant cyberattacks, merit real-time intervention. In either case, the goal is to prevent harmful actions rather than addressing them later. However, the company argues that most flagged incidents are not examples of malicious behaviour, but are instead caused by misunderstood instructions or overenthusiasm to achieve the user's objective. This distinction is critical because real-world AI risks may emerge from mistakes and unintended consequences, rather than deliberate attempts to cause harm.

Shiny Varghese about how building facades in India are magnets for disaster and why 'second staircases' matter.

What type of fire considerations does one need to make for a mixed-use building?

In principle, fire safety measures must address the highest risk. Fire escape routes become the most important preventive measure. Keeping them free of combustible material on wall panelling and storage along the corridors, non-combustible false ceilings and ensuring ventilation so that smoke does not enter escape corridors are critical basics. In no case should smoke from escape corridors enter stairwells. Instead of one big area, 'compartmentation' with fire and smoke check measures can reduce vulnerabilities. Situations become time-critical if the height between the false ceiling and the floor is less, in which case smoke will fill the entire space rather fast.

Of course, installation of sprinklers is one of the most effective measures, subject



Firefighters try to douse the blaze in Lucknow on June 22. VISHAL SRIVASTAV

to proper installation and design.

In the Lucknow and Malviya Nagar fires, the building facades appear to have aggravated the fire multifold, leaving firefighting operations rather ineffective. AC outdoor units, display boards and board-

ings with inflammable materials practically covered the facade.

When the building facade begins to burn, vertical external fire spread can be unstoppable. In such cases, falling hot debris render ground level fire operations dangerous. If access for firefighting is only on one face of a building, firefighters may not be able to approach the facade as temperatures can be unsafe. Such situations are common in most towns and cities.

As reported in Lucknow, they couldn't go down the stairs because the fire was coming from below and people were stuck on the first floor. Either the staircase should have been well ventilated or a second staircase should have been provided. It was a residential building but when the same was to be used for a commercial purpose, a second or alternative staircase should have been provided which would have saved lives.

How does 'compartmentation' in design help prevent fire?

Compartmentation is the principle of

dividing the entire floor area into smaller sections which can endure a full-blown fire for, say, 30 minutes, one hour or two hours.

In case a section can contain the fire for, say, 45 minutes, occupants will get more time to escape. At the same time, external support can prevent the growth of the fire. So, if we are able to divide one floor into three compartments with 45 minutes of endurance each, then a floor can sustain a fire for 135 minutes, rather than going up in flames almost immediately. This is a well-established life safety measure.

What are the other safety measures that should be in place?

It is important that preventive measures such as fire escape routes and compartmentation are not hampered. Without maintenance, firefighting systems will be completely ineffective. Also, fire safety systems will only perform if the occupancy is not changed and new risks are not added, such as extra storage or using the building for other purposes than what was planned.

What are the points of weakness in high-density areas?

Access is usually the weakest link. Fire vehicles find it challenging to manoeuvre their way around so that they can arrive before the fire matures to the "flash over" phase — when flames spread beyond the site of fire. Not to forget the impediments of streetside parking and encroachments.

This is often neglected within residential areas. Normally, six metres is the minimum space required but additional space is required for a variety of operations during a fire incident on a public street. Any street less than nine metres wide is a problem.

What do people need to keep in mind when renovating interiors?

Ensure combustible materials are correctly assessed and fire detection, alarm and fighting installations are consistent. Use of materials is very important. Curtains and wall cladding contribute significantly to the spread of fire. Wall panelling materials should always be fire retardant.

• **POLICY**

Why India's buildings are vulnerable to fire, and what's needed to fix them



EXPERT EXPLAINS

VIRENDRA KUMAR PAUL

DIRECTOR OF THE SCHOOL OF PLANNING AND ARCHITECTURE, NEW DELHI

INDIA HAS seen a number of fires in commercial and residential buildings in recent times. The fire at a Delhi bed & breakfast on June 3 killed 23 people. Just weeks later, on June 22, a blaze in a Lucknow commercial complex killed 15 people.

These incidents have brought into focus the numerous fire safety gaps in India's urban areas. **Professor Virendra Kumar Paul**, Director of the School of Planning and Architecture in New Delhi, speaks to

Idea Exchange

NEWSMAKERS IN THE NEWSROOM

WHY PP CHAUDHARY

PP Chaudhary is Chairman of the Joint Parliamentary Committee on One Nation One Election (ONOE), and a member of six other key committees, including Committee on Finance, Business Advisory Committee of the Lok Sabha and Committee on Estimates. He has previously chaired the JPCs on the Personal Data Protection Bill, 2019, and the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2022. The three-term MP had been Minister of State for Law & Justice, Corporate Affairs and Electronics and Information Technology in the last term

Damini Nath: The Joint Parliamentary Committee (JCP) has had 18 meetings and you have met several stakeholders. So far, what is the view on making recommendations on the Bills (One Nation, One Election and Delimitation)?

The government accepted the High-Level Committee's (chaired by former President Ram Nath Kovind) report and made a Bill based on it, which was approved by the Cabinet and came to Parliament. The meaning of Parliament referring a Bill to a committee is that the committee can make the changes it deems appropriate. It's not that there will be no changes. There are constitutional provisions in case of some inconsistency. More provisions can be incorporated, and recommendations can also be made to amend other provisions of the Constitution.

Damini Nath: What are the inconsistencies that need to be addressed?

There is a clause in the ONOE Bill, Article 82A(5), which says that if the Election Commission is of the opinion that the election of a particular state legislature cannot be conducted, the matter will be referred to the President and that election can be held along with the parliamentary election. Many stakeholders have asked on what basis that opinion will be formed. The Bill is also silent on how long such an election can be postponed. There are similar issues involving Emergency and President's Rule. Under Article 352, Parliament's term can be extended during an Emergency, but the Bill does not fully reconcile such situations with the proposed election cycle.

The larger challenge is not only synchronising elections but maintaining that synchronisation for decades. Suppose elections are held, and six months later the PM or CM advises dissolution of the House? That advice is ordinarily binding on the President or Governor. But what if an alternative majority government can be formed? Should there be a provision to form another government before dissolution, since premature dissolution would disturb the election calendar?

Damini Nath: Is the committee considering the German model of positive vote of confidence? Do you think this can prevent governments from falling prematurely?

If a no-confidence motion succeeds and we do not find a middle path, elections would have to be held, but those elections would be only for the remainder of the term, not a fresh five-year period.

In Germany, a no-confidence motion is accompanied by a confidence motion for an alternative government. We can also study other models, such as Japan's. Sometimes elections happen and yet a deadlock remains. In such circumstances, should there be elections again? Should some relaxation be provided in the anti-defection law? If political actors know that a fresh election will only result in a government serving for one year, that itself may act as a deterrent against destabilising governments. Another possibility is where a state cannot function because no government has a majority. Then, Parliament could exercise the powers of the state legislature for a limited period, similar to certain emergency arrangements. The committee is examining all possibilities.

Damini Nath: In its current state, the first simultaneous election can happen in 2034. Is the committee also considering a phased introduction?

The framework revolves around the appointed date. Once the constitutional amendments come into force and the first meeting of the newly elected Lok Sabha takes place, that date becomes the reference point. From there, elections would move toward a common cycle. Assemblies elected after the appointed date may serve shorter terms so that they align with the national calendar. Under this approach, complete synchronisation would emerge around 2034. If certain state governments agree, their elections could potentially be aligned with Parliamentary elections sooner.

Damini Nath: Can you change this appointed date?

Under Article 368, Parliament has ample powers. A committee can only make recommendations. Ultimately, Parliament decides whether to accept them. If a constitutional amendment is passed with the required majority, Parliament can exercise that power.

Sandeep Singh: How do you address concerns over delimitation between southern states and those in the north, where population increase has been the highest?

The states that successfully implemented population control measures should not be penalised. The Prime Minister and Home Minister have indicated that the 1971 Census could continue as the basis for state-wise seat allocation, while a later Census could be used for allocation within states. But that requires a constitutional amendment. If such an amendment is not made, then seat distribution would

ON THE GAPS IN THE ONOE BILL

The challenge is to maintain the synchronisation. Suppose elections are held, and six months later the PM or CM advises dissolution of the House. Should there be a provision to form another government?



ON THE DELIMITATION BILL

The 1971 Census could continue as the basis for state-wise seat allocation, and a later Census for allocation within states... eventually, it will be based on population. Some states will lose seats while others will gain

extended during an Emergency, the election cycle changes. The Bill currently does not fully address such situations. We need to visualise future contingencies and provide safeguards now rather than face problems later. The existing constitutional framework already provides significant checks and balances. If a government loses support, a no-confidence motion can be moved. If an alternative government can be formed, there is no problem.

The concept of a remainder term is not entirely new. Since 1992, similar provisions have existed in local self-government institutions. Some argue that frequent elections strengthen democracy, while others argue that constant elections encourage excessive spending and distort governance. From 1952 to 1967, Lok Sabha and Assembly elections were held together. Governments remained accountable during that period as well. Taking all these factors into account, it is believed that One Nation One Election would serve the national interest.

Jatin Anand: Don't simultaneous elections create an unfair advantage for national parties? Won't national issues overshadow state concerns?

Some argue that regional parties could suffer. Others argue the opposite — that state issues may become even more prominent. My own view is that voters should not be underestimated. When we didn't have EVMs and voting used to be by paper, the voter understood very well whom to vote for and whom not to. Today, there are EVMs and the voters are more educated than before. They can distinguish between national issues, state issues and individual candidates. Experiences from Odisha, Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu and from earlier elections suggest that voters are capable of making different choices at different levels.

Jatin Anand: Will One Nation, One Election require a nationwide Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls first? And what about voting rights for migrant workers?

SIR is a good exercise. We believe in it. The names of people who have died or migrated from one place to another over the last 20-30 years continue to appear on the voter lists of different places. There are many reasons why fake votes get cast. So SIR is a cleanup exercise. And as far as other states are concerned, it is a continuous process. It is the Election Commission's job to see by when they complete it. But our intention is that the SIR exercise should be done in the whole country as soon as possible. I believe that the SIR process — if One Nation One Election is implemented in 2029 — will be completed throughout the country before that.

Harikishan Sharma: Your party has been rallying behind the idea of simultaneous elections since 1984. There was another idea along with this too — of public funding of elections. Do you think the party will consider that too?

The idea of simultaneous elections has support beyond one political party. The Election Commission, the Law Commission, the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Law and Justice and NITI Aayog have all made recommendations in favour of it. As for public funding of elections, that is a much larger issue. It is outside the scope of this committee. It would require extensive study, data and political consensus before any conclusion can be reached.

Amitabh Sinha: In the Delimitation Bill, the original requirement was that a delimitation commission be formed after every Census and a delimitation exercise shall happen. That wasn't kept in this Bill. What is the rationale for that?

For clarity, that requirement arises from Article 82 of the Constitution, not from the Delimitation Commission Act itself. The 2002 Amendment provided that delimitation would take place after the Census was conducted after 2026. The Bill primarily deals with the procedure for delimitation, the composition of the commission and how it will function. Parliament is exercising its authority within the framework already laid down by the Constitution.

Jatin Anand: What is your take on the NEET leak?

I am not the person concerned, but I can say that when such problems arise, they are addressed. No system is completely foolproof. The government is vigilant and the Prime Minister is personally monitoring the issue. Beyond that, I do not think it is appropriate for me to comment.

Harikishan Sharma: There has also been controversy over the use of the term 'cockroach' in public discourse for people who are critical of institutions. Do you think such language is appropriate in a democracy?

Some issues can become disproportionate compared to their actual significance. I am not commenting on whether a particular statement was right or wrong. But public debate can sometimes magnify matters beyond their real importance.

‘We do not want the anti-defection law to be misused by either side’

PP Chaudhary, senior advocate and Lok Sabha MP, on One Nation, One Election, anti-defection reforms and the hidden costs of frequent polls. The session was moderated by Damini Nath, Assistant Editor, *The Indian Express*



PP Chaudhary, BJP MP and Chairman of the Joint Parliamentary Committee, (right) with Damini Nath, Assistant Editor, *The Indian Express* RENUKA PURI

Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Vav2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F> eventually be based on population, which could mean some states lose seats while others gain them.

Vikas Pathak: You said the 1971 Census should be the national base and the latest Census within states. But the Delimitation Bill referred to the 2011 Census and proposed a 50 per cent increase in seats. Was that technically possible? Because using the 2011 Census would mean applying Article 81, which mandates a population-based allocation, rather than the 1971 Census formula.

In 2002, the Constitution specified that delimitation would be based on the Census after 2026. State-wise seat allocation remained linked to the 1971 Census, while allocation within states was linked to the 2001 Census. The reference to the 2011 Census arose because the government felt the 2026 Census and the subsequent delimitation process might not be completed before 2029. If that happened, women's reservation could also be delayed. Using the 2011 Census would have allowed the Delimitation Commission to begin work earlier.

The real hurdle is timing. If all parties agree that the 2026 Census will take time, they may decide to return to the 2011 Census. Alternatively, the 2026 Census could be completed quickly and multiple commissions could work simultaneously. Parliament has the power to create such mechanisms. Today, the choice between the 2011 and 2026 Census is ultimately a political decision. It is not for the committee to determine.

Vikas Pathak: You said that if a government falls mid-term, the next government would have a truncated term until the next appointed date.



Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1 **Vikas Pathak: The anti-defection law was strengthened to stop legislators from switching parties, but it has also made party whips so powerful that MPs often cannot express independent views. How do you see this contradiction?**

Your concern is valid. In a democracy, an MP should have a voice. Sometimes the party's position completely dominates the individual representative's role. That is why any change requires careful balancing. We are discussing how the law should operate in situations where only a short period remains before the next synchronised election. We do not want the law to be misused by either side. This is one of the issues under active deliberation. We are consulting experts and committee members on whether some relaxation

ON GIVING WHIPS TOO MUCH POWER

An MP should have a voice. Sometimes the party's position dominates the representative's role... The objective is to ensure that the will of the people is respected. It should not be confined to the committee, or the government

should be considered. The broader objective is to ensure that the will of the people is respected. This discussion should not remain confined to the committee, political parties or the government. The media serves as a bridge between the public and the policymakers. Our experience so far has been that, except for a few political parties, almost everyone from civil society — educationists, Padma awardees, institutional heads and ordinary citizens — has broadly supported the idea of simultaneous elections. Their view is that frequent elections affect governance and inconvenience citizens.

People also point to effects on education. Teachers are repeatedly assigned election duties, voter list work and Census work, reducing teaching time. Frequent elections create uncertainty and impose costs on the economy. Labour migration, voter fatigue and repeated mobilisation also have consequences. If India wants to become a developed nation by 2047, major electoral reforms will have to be considered.

Liz Mathew: If democracy reflects the will of the people, shouldn't people have opportunities to express that will more than once every five years? Also, what checks and balances will exist under ONOE?

The first challenge is achieving synchronisation between 2029 and 2034 and then maintaining it thereafter. One issue involves Article 85(2)(b), under which the President or Governor can dissolve the House on ministerial advice. Should safeguards be introduced so that alternative governments are explored before dissolution? Personally, I believe Article 85 deserves reconsideration, though that is not necessarily the committee's position. Secondly, if parliamentary terms are

{ WEEKLY CAPSULE }

What is weakening your bones?

OSTEOPENIA IS a common but often overlooked condition that causes bones to become less dense and more fragile. Around 40 per cent of adults worldwide are affected by it but because it develops silently, many people only discover they have it after a fracture or bone scan. Ageing, poor diet and inactivity are triggers. Hormonal changes, especially the decline in estrogen after menopause, can increase bone breakdown. Around one in two women over 50 will experience a fragility fracture. Fortunately, exercise, adequate calcium and vitamin D, and other healthy habits can slow or partially reverse the decline.



How bat viruses become threats

SCIENTISTS AT the University of California found that one tiny genetic change can completely alter how a coronavirus behaves in different species. Comparing SARS-CoV-2 with a closely related bat-only virus, they showed that a single amino-acid difference affects whether the immune system fights back or gets suppressed. This may help explain how some animal viruses make the leap to humans. The viral protein, known as OrfB9, was found to shut down an important immune alarm system in human lung cells, allowing the virus to replicate more effectively. In bat lung cells, it kept the virus under control.



Alternative to knee replacement

A MINIMALLY invasive procedure for chronic knee pain is helping some patients find significant relief without undergoing major surgery. This procedure is called genicular artery embolisation (GAE), which is an outpatient procedure designed to ease chronic knee pain by reducing blood flow to inflamed areas within the joint. By targeting abnormal blood vessels associated with inflammation, the treatment can help decrease swelling and discomfort. Nearly a year after receiving it, patients say the effect was equal to the knee replacement they had in one of their knees earlier.



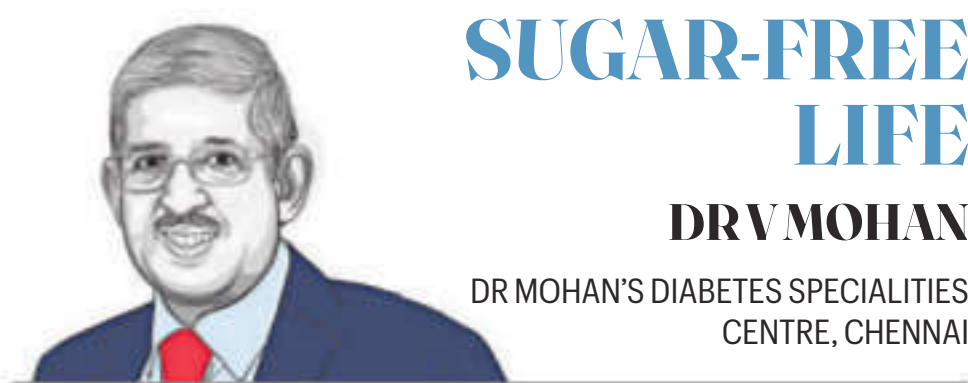
Why you still need more protein

A NEW paper published in *Frontiers in Nutrition* argues that current public health recommendations for exercise and protein intake are largely aimed at preventing deficiency, not helping people achieve the best possible long-term health, independence and quality of life. Newer research suggests that physically active people, older adults, and pregnant women may benefit from significantly higher protein intake. The review further highlights evidence that higher-protein diets can support fat loss (due to increased satiety and thermic effect), making them beneficial for body composition and overall health.



Omega-3 supps vs brain health

PEOPLE ARE often on the lookout for ways to improve brain health and prevent cognitive problems like dementia. One area of interest in research is docosahexaenoic acid (DHA), an Omega-3 fatty acid that people can get from fish and supplements. A recent study by the University of Southern California explored whether taking DHA supplements held cognitive benefits for people who had lower levels of Omega-3. Researchers found that while supplementation increased DHA levels, participants did not show benefits when it came to cognition. This suggests that DHA supplements may not help with dementia prevention.



SUGAR-FREE LIFE

DRV MOHAN

DR MOHAN'S DIABETES SPECIALITIES CENTRE, CHENNAI

India's diabetes lessons can help the world

We have developed a model of delivering care in resource-constrained settings

WHEN I began my journey in diabetes care more than four decades ago, India was already witnessing a silent epidemic. Today, that epidemic has grown into one of the country's greatest public health challenges. India is home to more than 100 million people with diabetes and another 136 million at high risk of developing the condition. Yet the challenge is not unique to India. Across low- and middle-income countries, diabetes is rising rapidly, stretching healthcare systems that are often under-resourced and overburdened.

The question I have grappled with throughout my career is simple: How do we provide quality diabetes care to millions of people when specialists, infrastructure and financial resources are limited? The answer, I believe, lies not in replicating models from wealthy countries but in developing solutions that are locally relevant, affordable and scalable.

One of the earliest lessons we learnt was that diabetes in South Asians differs in important ways from diabetes in many Western populations. Indians tend to develop diabetes at younger ages and at lower body weights. Many patients present late, often after complications have already set in. This means prevention, early diagnosis and regular monitoring become even more critical. Yet conventional healthcare models are poorly suited to this reality. Asking patients to visit multiple clinics for eye examinations, kidney assessments, foot care, nutrition counselling and laboratory investigations is impractical, especially for those travelling long distances or paying out of pocket.

This realisation led us to develop an integrated model of diabetes care in which all essential services are available under one roof. The objective was simple: reduce the burden on patients while ensuring comprehensive evaluation and treatment during a single visit. Such integrated care not only improves convenience but also increases the likelihood that complications are detected early.

However, infrastructure alone cannot solve the problem. A country the size of India does not have enough endocrinologists or diabetes specialists to care for every patient. Capacity building, therefore, became central to our work. We invested heavily in training physicians, diabetes educators, nurses, podiatrists and other healthcare workers. Task-sharing and task-shifting are no longer optional strategies; they are essential if diabetes care is to reach under-served populations.

Technology has emerged as another powerful equaliser. Digital health tools, telemedicine platforms and mobile applications can bridge the gap between patients and healthcare providers. They allow individuals to access information, monitor their condition, receive reminders, communicate with healthcare teams and maintain continuity of care between clinic visits. For chronic diseases such as diabetes, where long-term engagement is critical, these tools can make a measurable difference. Perhaps one of the most rewarding experiences has been taking diabetes care beyond urban centres. Through mobile units equipped with diagnostic facilities, we have been able to screen for diabetes and its complications in remote villages where specialist services are unavailable. More recently, home-based care models have further expanded access, particularly for elderly patients and those with mobility limitations. The COVID-19 pandemic reinforced the importance of these innovations. During lockdowns, teleconsultations and digital monitoring enabled patients to remain connected to healthcare providers even when physical visits were impossible. What began as an emergency response has now become a permanent component of diabetes care.

Research has also played a crucial role. For too long, many clinical guidelines were based largely on data generated in high-income countries. While such evidence is valuable, it does not always reflect the realities of populations in Asia, Africa or Latin America. Locally generated research helps us understand disease patterns, risk factors and treatment responses within our own communities. It enables us to design interventions that are both scientifically sound and contextually relevant. There is another lesson that deserves emphasis. Healthcare cannot succeed if it excludes those who cannot afford it. In countries where a significant proportion of healthcare expenditure comes directly from patients' pockets, affordability remains a major barrier. Sustainable solutions must incorporate mechanisms that expand access for economically disadvantaged groups.

As the global burden of diabetes continues to rise, low- and middle-income countries can no longer rely solely on imported healthcare models. They must innovate, adapt and build systems that reflect local realities. India's experience demonstrates that even in resource-constrained settings, meaningful progress is possible through integrated care, workforce development, technology, research and community engagement. The challenges remain enormous. But if there is one lesson I have learnt over four decades, it is that solutions do not emerge from abundance. Sometimes they emerge from necessity. And those solutions may hold valuable lessons for the rest of the world.

Purnima Sah

FOR MOST of her life, Neeta Prasad* cleaned other people's homes. The 30-year-old domestic worker steps out of her one-room shack in an Ulhasnagar slum every morning and spends her day sweeping floors, washing utensils and mopping apartments across the city. By month's end, she earns about Rs 10,000 — barely enough to pay rent, buy medicines to remain fit and keep her household running. Her husband works as a cook at roadside eateries. Their son lives with relatives in their village, where he attends school.

Yet when the family moved to Ulhasnagar in 2022, they had hoped for a better future. Instead, they found themselves trapped in the cycle of urban poverty. That was when a relative told Neeta about what sounded like an easy way to earn money. "She said I could make Rs 20,000 by donating my *stree beej* (eggs). My body naturally produces them every month and since I had a child of my own and didn't want more, I could donate them and get paid," says Neeta. What she did not fully understand was the price her body would pay.

By the time authorities uncovered the illegal egg-harvesting network this year, Neeta had undergone at least 45 egg retrievals, a procedure which is legally allowed only once in a lifetime under the Assisted Reproductive Technology (ART) Act, 2021. That meant 45 rounds of hormone injections, 45 periods of recovery and 45 occasions on which a needle was inserted through the vaginal wall to collect eggs from her ovaries. Doctors say each cycle subjected her to hormonal manipulation designed to force her ovaries to produce multiple eggs, followed by an invasive retrieval procedure under sedation. Repeated stimulation carries risks of bleeding, infection and cysts. Yet for women like Neeta, the decision was about economics rather than their health.

The process began with daily hormone injections administered into her abdomen for nearly two weeks. Then came repeated pelvic ultrasounds to monitor egg development. Finally, she was given a trigger injection and taken to a clinic where doctors retrieved her eggs through a procedure performed under sedation. These became part of the donor egg pool at the clinic for use in assisted reproductive procedures among infertile couples. As the days passed, Neeta experienced fatigue, mood swings, irritability, bloating and pelvic pain. "The woman giving me the injections said it was normal. She told me I was helping women who could not have children," she says. When she woke up after her first egg retrieval, her stomach felt swollen and sore. "I was scared although I received Rs 20,000," she says. Initially, she decided she would never do it again. Then she began calculating school expenses, rent payments and household bills. The next time the agents called, she agreed. Then she agreed again. And again.

Poverty as recruitment strategy for donors

Neeta's story echoes across Maharashtra's slums. Roshani Shaikh*, a 35-year-old factory worker from Thane, entered the network after her husband abandoned her in 2023. Living alone and struggling financially, she was introduced to egg donation by a colleague. A woman known only as "madam" coordinated the process. Soon, Roshani too was receiving hormone injections and travelling for procedures. "I thought I could move to a better area and improve my life. My friends had been donating eggs for years and they were earning good money," she says. "When I held Rs 20,000 in my hand after every procedure, the pain my body had gone through suddenly felt very small," she adds. For Suman Patil*, 25, the choice came amid debts after her husband cheated on her and chose to live with another woman. Friends who were already donating eggs suggested she join them. "They told me I could make Rs 30,000 every month on the side. I experienced severe cramps and bloating, but the money kept me going."

Investigators say that financial vulnerability became the foundation of a network that systematically recruited poor women and transformed their reproductive capac-

ity into a commodity.

The racket is busted

The operation came to light on February 19 when Badlapur police received information that women were being administered hormone injections inside a residential apartment. Suspecting a health-related offence, police sought assistance from district health authorities. Acting on instructions from Civil Surgeon Dr Kailash Pawar, a team of government doctors joined officers during a raid.

What they discovered would expose a network stretching across multiple cities

Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJKH6oBd0F>



Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RG0f9m1jMzg1 and states. According to police, the apartment functioned as an illegal hub where women were called to receive fertility injections before being sent for egg retrieval procedures. Officers recovered Menotropin, a drug used to stimulate egg production.

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Deep DIVE



ILLUSTRATION: SUVAJIT DEY

● In India, donor egg IVF is a regulated process under the Assisted Reproductive Technology (ART) Act, 2021



Egg donors are aged between 21 and 35 and go through medical and psychological assessment. Donors can withdraw consent at any point before eggs are fertilised

	EGG FREEZING (FERTILITY PRESERVATION)	EGG DONATION (THIRD-PARTY REPRODUCTION)
Genetic Ownership	Retained entirely by the woman who provides the eggs	Relinquished completely to the recipient couple/woman
Marital Status	Legal for single, unmarried, divorced, or widowed women	Restricted to ever-married women
Usage Limits	Stored for personal use, generally capped at 10 years	Strictly capped at once per lifetime
Commercial Intent	Allowed for elective ("social") or medical preservation	Purely altruistic; commercial sales are criminalised

pliers, sonography operators, document forgers and fertility clinics. Police have booked 15 accused, including doctors, agents, pharmacists and alleged document forgers, under provisions relating to human trafficking, exploitation, forgery and violations of the ART Act.

How the system worked

The Assisted Reproductive Technology (Regulation) Act, 2021 allows a woman to donate eggs only once in her lifetime. Investigators allege the network bypassed that safeguard through forged identities. Women who had already donated eggs were allegedly provided fake Aadhaar cards and fabricated records so they could continue being presented as first-time donors. Police say donors were first given hormone injections to stimulate their ovaries. They were then sent for ultrasound scans to monitor follicle growth before being transported to fertility centres for egg retrieval procedures.

One donor identified during the investigation underwent 35 egg retrieval procedures in three years and was transported to clinics in Kerala and Tamil Nadu. She received Rs 35,000 for each cycle.

The economics reveal why the system flourished. Women were paid between Rs 20,000 and Rs 35,000 for each cycle. Intended parents seeking donor eggs reportedly paid between Rs 3 lakh and Rs 5 lakh. Agents allegedly earned between Rs 70,000 and Rs 1 lakh for arranging donors. Smaller participants earned commissions for scans, medicines and forged documents. At every stage, someone profited.

The hidden health toll

Medical experts say the case raises disturbing questions about the cumulative impact of repeated egg retrieval procedures. Dr Anjali Malpani, Professor Emeritus of KEM Hospital and founder-director of Malpani Infertility Clinic in Mumbai, described the practice as the worst form of physical abuse. "A woman's body is resilient. But calling the same woman back every month for hormonal injections, anaesthesia and egg retrieval takes a toll on her reproductive and hormonal systems," she says.

According to her, women can experience abdominal pain, bloating, nausea, weakness, constipation, emotional stress and discomfort. "The most serious complication is ovarian hyperstimulation syndrome, which in severe cases can become life-threatening. The ovaries swell up with fluid. Warning signs include severe abdominal pain, rapid weight gain (more than 1-2 kg in 24 hours), significant abdominal swelling, shortness of breath, reduced urination, severe nausea/vomiting, dizziness, or signs of blood clots. These symptoms require prompt attention and could become life-threatening. The procedure can compromise the liver, haematological, renal and respiratory systems. The woman has to regularly monitor her health parameters lifelong," she says.

Perhaps more troubling is what medicine still does not know. "There is little research on women undergoing 20-30 retrievals over a short period," she says. Dr Kailash Pawar, civil surgeon at Thane District Hospital, warns against the risks of infection and cyst formation.

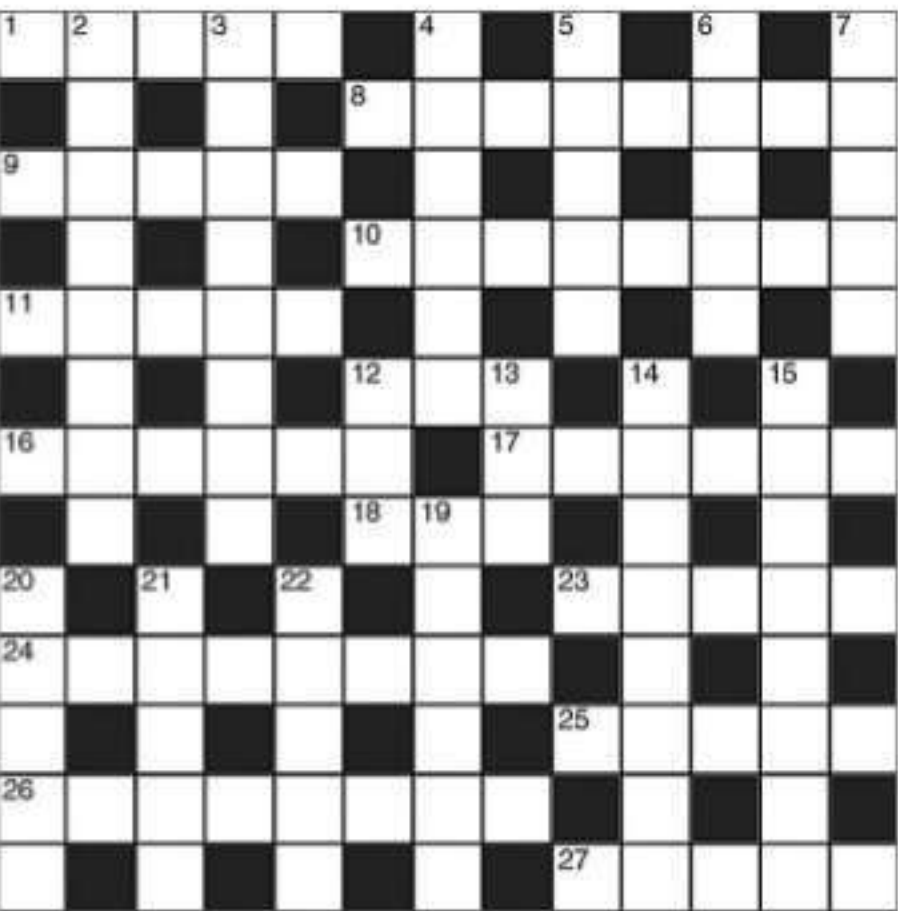
Beyond one criminal case

Fertility specialists argue that the case exposes broader structural failures. Dr Aniruddha Malpani, patient advocate and co-founder of Malpani Infertility Clinic, believes the racket reflects a system in which information and financial power are concentrated among intermediaries while the donors remain poorly informed.

"Weak oversight and the growing commercialisation of fertility services create conditions in which exploitation can thrive. Unless those incentives change, similar networks are likely to emerge elsewhere," he warns. For Neeta, however, the larger policy debate feels distant. What she remembers are the injections, the scans, the procedures and the envelopes of cash that followed. The money helped pay for her son's education. But it came at a cost that nobody fully explained to her. And one which she will never understand.

*Names changed to protect privacy

CROSSWORD



ACROSS
1 Point and scoff at old-fashioned garment (5)
8 Lively maiden at play (8)
9 This man is always outspoken (5)
10 Some rags woven into a very fine material (8)
11 A spell in the Dutch array (5)
12 Went ahead in a sledge (3)
16 People will mind if you dump your kids here (6)
17 Region possibly showing neglect (6)
18 As quiet as a snake (3)
23 It has branches in Lebanon (5)
24 Superior skill includes organ-playing (8)
25 It has set like a film (5)
26 We're glad to hear it goes down the wrong way! (4,4)
27 Silly Annie is upset (5)

DOWN
2 They take steps to protest perhaps (8)
3 Reduce length of one spade for example (8)
4 Pay in advance (6)
5 A nasty accident on the tennis court? (5)
6 One impression of the postal service (5)
7 Love to make a fuss about something (5)
12 Part of the arable acreage (3)
13 Thief who inevitably has to go down (3)
14 Trendy individual is here himself (2,6)
15 Production of Haydn's oratorio (8)
19 Southern wines blended for strength (6)
20 Push your way in and snatch up the key (5)
21 Smarten up a man on his wedding day (5)
22 Energy is used in any form of torture (5)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6026
ACROSS: 1 Broomstick, 6 Disc, 10 Major, 11 Centurion, 12 Scottish, 13 Lunge, 15 Mooting, 17 Article, 19 Risotto, 21 Capital, 22 Visor, 24 Tendered, 27 Say no more, 28 Trial, 29 Deed, 30 Press agent
DOWN: 1 Bump, 2 Objects, 3 Merit, 4 Tacking, 5 Cynthia, 7 Xion, 8 Cinderella, 9 Full stop, 14 Improvised, 16 Interior, 18 Catherine, 20 Outdoor, 21 Conkers, 23 Style, 25 Extra, 26 Plot

JUMBLLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

Broadly speaking, the _ words are the best, and the _ words best of all - Sir Winston Churchill (5,...,3)

ROWED

SOWED

DEFAULT

GOOTDH

SOLUTIONS:

Downer, Fluted, Hordog

ANSWER:

Broadly speaking, the show words are the best, and the old words best of all - Sir Winston Churchill

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 5s

INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6364

		4				1	2	
	5		1					
			3		4	5	9	
				9		4	8	
4								5
	9	1		3				
	4	2	8		6			
				5		8		
8	7					6		

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6363

5	4	7	2	6	9	3	1	8
8	3	2	5	7	1	6	4	9
6	1	9	4	8	3	7	5	2
2	5	8	7	4	6	9	3	1
4	9	1	8	3	2	5	7	6
7	6	3	1	9	5	2	8	4
9	2	4	3	1	7	8	6	5
1	7	5	6	2	8	4	9	3
3	8	6	9	5	4	1	2	7

Aavas Finance Limited

CIN:L65922RJ2011PLCO34297 Regd. & Corp. Office: 201-202, 2nd Floor, South End Square, Mansarovar Industrial Area, Jaipur. 302020

Demand Notice Under Section 13(2) of Securitisation Act of 2002

As the Loan Account Became NPA therefore The Authorised Officer (AO) Under section 13 (2) Of Securitisation And Reconstruction of Financial Assets And Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 had issued 60 day demand notice to the borrower as given in the table. According to the Notice if the Borrower does not deposit the Amount within 60 days, the amount will be recovered from Auction of the security as given below. As the demand Notice send to the borrower/guarantor has not been served, copy of demand notice has also been affixed on the secured assets as given below. Therefore you the borrower is informed to deposit the loan amount along with future interest and recovery expenses within 60 days, otherwise under the provisions of section 13 (4) and 14 of the said Act, the AO is free to take possession of the Security as given below.

Name of the Borrower	Demand Notice Date and Amount	Description of Mortgaged property
Sharlee Sharlee, Omkar Singh, Apporva Patel (A/C NO.) 211227302008913	25 Jun 26 Rs. 764601/- 25 Jun 26	East Part Of Khasara No 516 Gudaliya Data Ganj Budaan Uttar Pardesh Admeasuring 67.47 SQ. MTR.

Place : Uttar Pradesh Date : 29.06.2026 Authorised Officer Aavas Financiers Limited

AXIS FINANCE LIMITED

(CIN U05921MH1995PLC212675)

Axis House, C-2, Wadia International Centre, Pandurang Budhkar Marg, Worli, Mumbai - 400 025

E-Public Auction-cum-Sale Notice

E Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 read with provision to Rule 8 (6) and Rule 9 (1) of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower/s, Guarantor/s and Mortgagor/s, that the below described immovable properties mortgaged / charged to Secured Creditor, the PHYSICAL POSSESSION of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of Axis Finance Limited, Secured Creditor, will be sold on "AS IS WHERE IS", "AS IS WHAT IS", and "WHATEVER THERE IS" and "WITHOUT RECOURSE BASIS", on 20.07.2026 for recovery of Rs. 1,06,87,836/- (Rupees One Crore Six Lakhs Eighty Seven Thousand Eight Hundred and Thirty Six Only) as on 05.06.2026 [amount o/s as on the date of the demand notice dated 30.06.2025 issued u/s 13(2) of SARFAESI Act – INR. 95,77,358 /- (Rupees Ninety Five Lakhs Seventy Seven Thousand Three Hundred and Fifty Eight Only) due as on 05.06.2025] with further interest at the contractual rates, along with default/penal interest and other charges etc., till full payment / realization from the Borrower / Mortgagors / Guarantors, i.e., (1) MR. RAKESH KUMAR JAIN (2) RIDHI JAIN at Flat No B1/1640, Tower No. 10, Purvanchal Royal City, North West Delhi, Delhi – 110082 (3) MANISH HOISERY at 9-2492, Ground Floor, Kailash Nagar, East Delhi, Delhi – 1 10031. The Description of Assets, Reserve Price (RP), Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) and Details of Sale are as below:

SCHEDULE – I

Description of Immovable Secured Asset

BUILTUP PROPERTY BEARING PROPERTY NO. 995/49-B/7 (OLD) AND NEW NO. IX/2711, AREA MEASURING 41.80 SQ. MTS. BUILT ON PART OF PLOT NO. 32 OUT OF KHASRA NO. 311/36/36 SITUATED IN AREA OF VILLAGE SEELAMPUR, IN THE ABADI OF GALI NO. 17, KAILASH NAGAR, ILI, ADASHAHADARA, DELHI - 110031 AND BOUNDARIES OF THE HOUSE / PLOT: EAST – PROPERTY OF OTHERS WEST – GALI NORTH – PROPERTY OF OTHERS SOUTH – PROPERTY OF OTHERS

SCHEDULE – II

DETAILS OF E-AUCTION

Description of Property /s	As per SCHEDULE – I
Date & Time of e-Auction	On: 20.07.2026 Time: From: 11:00 AM to 12:00 NOON with unlimited extensions of 5 minutes each
Date & Time for Bid Submission	On: 17.07.2026 Before: 04:00 PM
Reserve Price:	
SECURED ASSET	Rs. 82,14,372/- Rupees Eighty Two Lakhs Fourteen Thousand Three Hundred and Seventy Two Only
* Price below which the Flat /property/s will not be sold	
Earnest Money Deposit (10% of RP):	
SECURED ASSET	Rs. 8,21,437/- Rupees Eight Lakhs Twenty One Thousand Four Hundred and Thirty Seven Only
Bid Increment Amount: Rs. 1,00,000/- (Rupees One Lac Only).	
Contact Person Details & Mob. Nos.: Mr. Ayan Bhattacharya, Mob: 9811710558	

For detailed terms and conditions of sale, please refer to the link provided in website i.e. "https://www.auction.infolarge.com" and www.axisfinance.in;

STATUTORY 15 DAYS SALE NOTICE UNDER RULE 8 (6) /RULE 9 (1) OF SECURITY INTEREST (ENFORCEMENT) RULES 2002.

This may also be treated as notice under Rule 8(6) and Rule 9(1) of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 to the borrower/s, guarantor/s and mortgagor/s of the said loan about the holding of E-Auction Sale on the above mentioned date.

Date: 27.06.2026 Place: New Delhi Authorized Officer Axis Finance Limited

AXIS FINANCE LIMITED

(CIN U05921MH1995PLC212675)

Axis House, C-2, Wadia International Centre, Pandurang Budhkar Marg, Worli, Mumbai – 400 025

E-Public Auction-cum-Sale Notice

E Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 read with provision to Rule 8 (6) and Rule 9 (1) of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower/s, Guarantor/s and Mortgagor/s, that the below described immovable properties mortgaged / charged to Secured Creditor, the SYMBOLIC POSSESSION of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of Axis Finance Limited, Secured Creditor, will be sold on "AS IS WHERE IS", "AS IS WHAT IS", and "WHATEVER THERE IS" and "WITHOUT RECOURSE BASIS", as on 20.07.2026 for recovery of the SARFAESI Act where under you can tender the entire amount of outstanding dues of Rs. 71,60,521/- (Rupees Seventy One Lakhs Sixty Thousand Five Hundred and Twenty One Only) as on 05.06.2026 [amount o/s as on the date of the demand notice dated 26.04.2025 issued u/s 13(2) of SARFAESI Act - INR. 64,60,699/- (Rupees Sixty Four Lacs Sixty Thousand Six Hundred and Ninety Nine Only) due as on 05.04.2025] with further interest at the contractual rates, along with default/penal interest and other charges etc., till full payment / realization from the Borrower / Mortgagors / Guarantors, i.e. (1) AMAN KUMAR JHA (2) RITA JHA and (3) INDRESH JHA. The Description of Assets, Reserve Price (RP), Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) and Details of Sale are as below:

SCHEDULE – I

Description of Immovable Secured Asset

MOHALLA KANPUR GALI, NEPALI KOTHI, THANA – CHOWK, PATNA CITY, SRO – PATNA CITY, ANCHAL SADAR PATNA, CIRCLE NO. 182, OLD WARD NO. 34/28, NEW WARD NO. 53, TAUZI NO. 139, KHATA NO. 546, PLOT NO. 1597, JAMABANDI NO. 169, DISTRICT – PATNA, STATE – BIHAR – 800008.

And Boundaries of the House / Plot: East – SELF HOUSE West – LATE SUBHASH CHANDRA KAPOOR HOUSE North – PCC ROAD 11 FT. South – LATE SUBHASH CHANDRA KAPOOR HOUSE

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Sunil Kumar Gupta, S/o: Niranjan Gupta, R/o: Il B-99, Nehru Nagar, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 1030/15 U/s 174A IPC, P.S.: Bhajanpura, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Sunil Kumar Gupta cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Sunil Kumar Gupta has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said Sunil Kumar Gupta accused of offence in case FIR No. 1030/15 U/s 174A IPC, P.S.: Bhajanpura, Delhi and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 10.08.2026.

By Order
Sh. Pankaj Rai
Judicial Magistrate First Class-01
Room No. 73, North East District
Karkardooma Court, Delhi

DP/8690/NE/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Rahul Kharawar, S/o: Rameshwar Kharawar, R/o: H.No. G-57, Gali No. 8, Gulshan Park, Mangloi, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 006358/2023, U/S 379/411 IPC, P.S.: Sarai Rohilla, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Rahul Kharawar cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Rahul Kharawar has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said Rahul Kharawar accused of offence in case FIR No. 006358/2023, U/S 379/411 IPC, P.S.: Sarai Rohilla, Delhi and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 29.07.2026.

By Order
Sh. Rangat Ghirra
Judicial Magistrate First Class-04
Room No. 37, Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/8727/NI/2026
(Court Matter)

Classifieds

PERSONAL

I, Manoj Kumar Mehra, S/o Dayanand Mehra, R/O MB-12, Gali No. 1, Shakar Pur Baramand, East Delhi, Delhi/110092 declare that that in my 10th Class Marksheet, my father's name is mentioned as "Dinesh KumarGupta" and in my Aadhaar Card, PAN Card, and my father's Aadhaar Card it is "Dinesh Kumar". so it is affirmed that Dinesh Kumar Gupta and Dinesh Kumar are one and the same person.

0020515794-1

LOST & FOUND

The general public is hereby informed that Mr. Ashok Law has lost/misplaced an agreement to sell for flat no. 302, Kanchenjunga building, 18 Barakhamba Road, New Delhi, dated 25.02.1972 executed in favour of Pragya Law. Any person finding it may contact at the address or phone numbers given below.

Ashok Law,
Gram Kanwali, Patti Kanwali,
Tehsil Sadar, District Dehradun,
Uttarakhand
Mobile: +91(43)994-6311, +9811306934

"IMPORTANT"

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WESTERN RAILWAY CONSTRUCTION WORKS

Deputy Chief Engineer (Construction) II, Western Railway, RATLAM (LMP) invites Tender No.RTM-RNQD-DyCE-C-II-02.

Name of Work: Construction of major and minor bridges, protection works & other miscellaneous works between proposed Nagda and Ratlam 3rd and 4th line section in connection with Nagda - Ratlam Quadrupling Project of Ratlam Division - Western Railway. NIT Cost: ₹ 92.51, 03, 149.43. Bid Security: ₹ 1,85,02,100/-.

Bid Submission Closing Date: On 20.07.2026 At 15:00 Hrs. Bid Opening Date: On 20.07.2026 At 15:30 Hrs. For further details please visit our website www.irps.gov.in

Like us on: Facebook.com/WesternRly

कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता

प्रथम मण्डल सिचाई कार्य, मेरठ।

ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या:-04/एस0ई0-1/2026-27

महामहिम राज्यपाल, उत्तर प्रदेश की ओर से सिंचाई विभाग निम्नानुसार श्रेणी के पात्र पंजीकृत निविदाताओं से आनलाईन टेंडरिंग के माध्यम से नीचे दशाईं गये कार्य हेतु निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है।

क्र. सं.	कार्य का नाम /लॉट संख्या	कार्य की अनुमानित लागत जीएसटीडीसी रीट (लाख रूप में)	अवधि कार्य को पूर्ण करने की अवधि	धरोहर धनराशि 2 प्रतिशत (लाख रूप में)	निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य (रूप में)	पंजीकृत श्रेणी	कार्य से सम्बन्धित अधिकारी का पता		
							अधीन अधीन मुख्या अधीन		
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8 9 10		
1	अनुपशहर शाखा नहर मेरठ के निम्नानुषाधीन राजवाहा लैण्ट अकनरपुर के किमी0 0.000 से किमी0 4.150 के मध्य व माईनर राजपुर के किमी0 2.110 से 11,350 के मध्य नहर सेवा मार्ग में खड्डा निर्माण का कार्य।	210.71	90 दिवस	4.22	रूप 300,00 + 18% G.S.T. नियमानुसार + रूप 2000 स्टेशनरी चार्ज	"ए" व इससे ऊपर	अधिसारी अधियन्ता, अनुपशहर शाखा खण्ड गंगा नहर, मेरठ।	अधीक्षण अधियन्ता प्रथम मण्डल, सिंचाई कार्य, मेरठ	मुख्य अधियन्ता (गंगा) सिंचिण्ड उडण्ड, मेरठ
2	राईट अकनर राजवाहा के किमी0 10.632 से किमी0 11.980, अकनरपुर माईनर के किमी0 0.135 से किमी0 7.800 व मवाना माईनर के किमी0 9.500 से किमी0 10.661 तक बायी पटरी पर खड्डा निर्माण का कार्य।	163.00	90 दिवस	3.26	रूप 300,00 + 18% G.S.T. नियमानुसार + रूप 2000 स्टेशनरी चार्ज	"ए" व इससे ऊपर	अधिसारी अधियन्ता, अनुपशहर शाखा खण्ड गंगा नहर, मेरठ।	अधीक्षण अधियन्ता प्रथम मण्डल, सिंचाई कार्य, मेरठ	मुख्य अधियन्ता (गंगा) सिंचिण्ड उडण्ड, मेरठ

विड डाक्यूमेंट वेबसाईट <http://etender.up.nic.in> पर दिनांक: 04.07.2026 की पूर्वाह्न 10:00 बजे से दिनांक:-13.07.2026 की अपराह्न 03:00 बजे तक उपलब्ध है, अपलोड किये जा सकते हैं। इसकी तकनीकी विड दिनांक:-13.07.2026 की अपराह्न 04:00 बजे खोली जायेगी। निविदा से सम्बन्धित अधिक जानकारी वेबसाईट <http://etender.up.nic.in> पर उपलब्ध है।

UPID-253096 Date 27/06/2026 www.upidadv.gov.in

अधीक्षण अभियन्ता प्रथम मण्डल सिंचाई कार्य, मेरठ। E-mail Id: se.jwel1@gmail.com

●RESULTS

GROUP L

Croatia 2-1 Ghana
Philadelphia Stadium
Panama 0-2 England
New Jersey Stadium

GROUP K

Colombia 0-0 Portugal
Miami Stadium
DR Congo 3-1 Uzbekistan
Atlanta Stadium

GROUP J

Algeria 3-3 Austria
Kansas City Stadium
Jordan 1-3 Argentina
Dallas Stadium

●MATCH SCHEDULE

ROUND OF 32

Brazil vs Japan
Houston, **10.30 pm**
(Monday)

Germany vs Paraguay
Boston, **2.00 am**
(Tuesday)

Netherlands vs Morocco
Monterrey, **6.30 am**
(Tuesday)

ZEE5 OTT & UNITE8 CHANNELS



Scotland coach Steve Clarke has resigned. AP

Scotland and South Korea eliminated

SCOTLAND AND South Korea were eliminated from the World Cup on Saturday after failing to make it into the top eight of the third-placed teams. Both teams exited after one win and two defeats. Scotland needed a big Ghana win against Croatia. However, Croatia beat Ghana 2-1 in Group L. Scotland beat Haiti 1-0 in their opener but lost 1-0 to Morocco and 3-0 to Brazil. South Korea opened the tournament with a 2-1 win over Czech Republic, before losing 1-0 to Mexico and 1-0 to South Africa. REUTERS

Late drama ends Iran's hopes of reaching last 32

IRAN'S HOPES of reaching the World Cup knockout phase for the first time came to an agonising end on Saturday after Austria's last-gasp equaliser against Algeria left them outside the eight best third-placed teams. Amir Ghalenoei's side completed their Group G campaign on Friday with a 1-1 draw against Egypt. That left them needing other results in group-stage matches to go their way, and for a few minutes on Saturday it looked as if Iran were going to squeeze through when Algeria struck in stoppage time to lead Austria 3-2. However, the Austrians equalised with almost the final kick of the game, salvaging a 3-3 draw that sent both teams through and denied Iran a place in the knockouts. REUTERS

party for all the games. For the Saudi Arabia match, it was organised in at Campanelli Stadium, a baseball ground. "From the first game, all of us watched every single moment of the game. We were not thinking of beating the big teams, or qualifying for the knockouts. We were just happy watching them, happy celebrating them. We always believed in the team and knew they could perform miracles. It means a lot for our community," she says.

For Joshua Carvalho, who works in the restaurant Sodade (which literally means nostalgia and a longing for home), he needn't explain to outsiders where, sometimes "what" Cape Verde is. "A lot of people ask me where it is. Most people think it's

Brazil, Portugal or the Netherlands — is the Round of 32 going to serve up an upset?

With seven goals apiece, averaging 2.33 per game, Brazil and Japan boast two of the most prolific attacks at the 2026 FIFA World Cup. From a purely statistical standpoint, there is little to separate them. Choosing the more potent attack, hence, would have been a matter of opinion, if they were not to meet in a round of 32 fixture on Monday. Brazil versus Japan headlines the first wave of knockout fixtures as the bracket for the last 32 is finally set following a captivating group stage.

Here's a quick look at five matches from those 16 that you can ill afford to miss:

Brazil vs Japan

Only five teams have scored more goals in the group stage than Brazil and Japan, which highlights the potency in their respective attacks. Seven of Brazil's eight goals have come from Vinicius Junior and Matheus Cunha. Japan, on the contrary, believes in the philosophy of decentralisation, having found five scorers so far.

29 June (Monday)
10.30 PM

Netherlands vs Morocco

There are several indicators that suggest this could be the most evenly balanced tie of the knockout stage. The Netherlands and Morocco have squared off thrice, with every encounter decided by a solitary goal. Moreover, they are placed adjacent to one another on the FIFA rankings — the African nation being in sixth place, with the Dutch breathing down their necks. Koeman's team are the joint top-scorers in this tournament so far, with 10 goals.

30 June (Tuesday)
6.30 AM

Portugal vs Croatia

Cristiano Ronaldo and his team might be wondering how they got to this place. A flawless group stage would have earned them a considerably kinder route through the knockout bracket. They were anything but flawless. What we have got instead is a delectable tie against Croatia, who finished fourth in 2022, and second in the edition before that.

3 July (Friday)
4.30 AM

● Full Schedule

29 June (Monday):
12:30 AM — S Africa vs Canada
30 June (Tuesday):
2 AM — Germany vs Paraguay
10:30 PM — Ivory Coast vs Norway
1 July (Wednesday):
2:30 AM — France vs Sweden
6:30 AM — Mexico vs Ecuador
9:30 PM — England vs DR Congo
2 July (Thursday):
1:30 AM — Belgium vs Senegal
5:30 AM — USA vs Bosnia and Herzegovina
3 July (Friday):
8:30 AM — Switzerland vs Algeria
11:30 PM — Australia vs Egypt
4 July (Saturday):
7 AM — Colombia vs Ghana

Spain vs Austria

Austria would not have been at this stage, if not for a dramatic 96th minute goal from Sasa Kalajdzic. Now, in their first World Cup knockout appearance since 1954, they face arguably the toughest assignment available — reigning European champions Spain. Cape Verde, however, have shown that Lamine Yarmal's team can be stopped in their tracks, if only one remains resolute. Austria must be so, for the entire 90 minutes, and a further 30 if need be.

3 July (Friday)
12:30 AM

Argentina vs Cape Verde

No fixture encapsulates the romance of the World Cup better. There are 63 places between the first-ranked Argentina and the 64th-ranked Cape Verde. The World Cup is as much about the underdogs as it is about the winners. Against the world champions, who are being led by Lionel Messi — currently leading the Golden Boot race with six goals — a tiny archipelago of 10 islands. The population of Rosario — the city where Messi was born — is more than thrice of Cape Verde's.

4 July (Saturday)
3:30 AM

WHO WILL WIN THE GOLDEN BOOT?

Messi, Haaland, Mbappe locked in a race for the ages

The cream has risen to the top in this tournament with three great goal poachers vying for the coveted honour



Sandip G
Boston, June 28

IT'S ABOUT the goals, yet it's not only about the goals. Four colossal figures of the game — Lionel Messi, Cristiano Ronaldo, Kylian Mbappe and Erling Haaland, each distinct from the other — are locked in a golden boot race for the ages. Yet, the wider meaning, the symbolism, is different for each, and intertwined with personal glory, identity, legacy, along the journey that takes them to the ultimate destination. The World Cup.

Lionel Messi leads the race, with six strikes in three games. Messi-26 is different from all previous iterations of his. Here is Messi with the crown, over his burnishing halo, liberated from the shadows of Diego Maradona, and gliding with joie de vivre. From 17 to 34, he played with a crushing burden in his heart, the love and loyalty for the country on the line, his greatness in the Argentine stripes a debate that never ended. He settled it all in Qatar, and in the US, he has reacquainted with the Messi that he lost when he made his first steps on the World Cup stage two decades ago.

This version is perhaps the most dangerous, when he walks with a free mind, when he is not smothered by the weight of the world's expectations, when the critics are not waiting for half a mistake, when he is purely soaking in the moments that he perhaps failed to enjoy fully.

Yet, he has not overstayed, the wit and wisdom, vision and intuition remain untarnished. No one perhaps sees the game as he sees it, stripped to its essentials, trimmed of its flourishes, football as a game of chess, of floating spaces and pieces. A title defence would make Argentina the only team that has retained the trophy since Pele in 1962. But

Messi would not pile an unsolicited burden on himself.

Nothing would provoke him — not the heir designates pushing to dethrone him and seize the sceptre, not his great rival pushing him into another duel to settle the greatest debate. The paths of Messi and Ronaldo were never meant to converge again, but here they are, from wonderkids to fierce competitors that defined this century, and now to two middle-aged men resisting the passage of time.

Ronaldo is 41, two years older than Messi, and he would feel the ticking seconds more acutely than Messi would. Not in the physical sense, but in how his biggest dream is slipping away from him.

Winning the World Cup is no longer about winning what Messi has won; it's not about legacies or inheritances, or stacking his mantelpiece with the only missing trophy. It could be about peace of mind, of sleeping with the trophy that has given him sleepless nights. He never felt the pressures Messi suffered in his pursuit of the World Cup, the shadows of past greats or the nearly games. The only shadow on Ronaldo is Ronaldo himself, the Ronaldo that refuses to leave without the last dome of gold that football can offer him. He would consider himself a failure if he leaves the stage without the crown.

For all the goals, trophies and individual awards, he knows his line to be remembered forever — the man that brought the World Cup to Portugal. He might not do it alone, as he would have dared in his magnificent youth. His spirit remained unconquered, although the athleticism has diminished. His biggest inspiration would be his biggest rival, Messi and how he did it in Qatar. He is still behind in the race, but only in numbers. In spirit, he always exists. In a tournament lit up by braces, it could take just a game for him to surpass all.

The World Cups have been unkind to Ronaldo. Six of them have mustered him only 10

goals. His spiritual successor in Real Madrid, Kylian Mbappe has already 16 in three editions. A goal-scoring behemoth has already risen, and the numbers he would end up dizzying.

For him, it wouldn't be about numbers, but regaining the paradise he lost. He was only 18 when he won the World Cup in Russia, in his maiden tournament. He was 22 when he netted a hat-trick in the final, inspiring the greatest comeback in the tournament's history. At 26, he needs a World Cup to ascertain that he is the world's best player. For eight years, he has been in the vicinity of this peak, but has stumbled at the final summit.

Mbappe is arguably the best player in the world, but he needs a blockbuster World Cup to reestablish his image, to revitalise himself and break away from the pack of pretenders after his fluctuating season with Real Madrid. If he could inspire France to another triumph, it could chart his path from being talked about as a generational great to an all-time great. At a ludicrous age of 26, Erling Haaland is only a year younger than him, and could be his biggest challenger to the throne. But his purpose is to give Norway, returning to the global tournament after 32 years, an identity that they are an emerging powerhouse, that they are no longer the tough losers, that they could vie for trophies. The goals they score would define them and their teams, decide the winner of the golden booty and perhaps the World Cup. But it is a race with wider meanings, like it is a play within a play. Or several plays within a play.

MESSI
6
GOALS

MBAPPE
4
GOALS

HAALAND
4
GOALS



Non-stop celebration at Brockton — ‘eleventh island of Cape Verde’ in the US

Sandip G

Boston, June 28

THE NIGHT of celebrations was endless in Boston's suburb of Brockton, when Cape Verde qualified for the World Cup's knockout stages. Roughly 5,000 kilometres away from the African archipelago's capital Praia, the locality has nearly 20,000 residents of Cape Verdean descent. "We call it the eleventh island of Cape Verde," says Tatiana Moniz, a member of the Cape Verdean Association in Brockton. "Except for the palm trees and beaches, it is like our islands, the restaurants, culture, everything. You see Cape Verdeans everywhere, and we are a bonded community," she says. Most streets had a watch

part of the Caribbean Islands. I have to show them on the map, and explain. Now I need not. Everybody knows where it is, and everybody seems to like our story. Wishes have been pouring on, and I have never felt prouder," he says. Brockton has a strong connection with the team too. The country's first World Cup goal-scorer Kevin Pina was born in Cape Verde but emigrated to Brockton, the first black-majority city in New England, in his childhood. "I remember him. He was struggling to get chances here. Ours is not a football town. We love boxing," he says. Brockton was home to legendary boxer Rocky Marciano, although he was of Italian descent.

Pina's dream was wilting, when the former Cape Verde captain, Carlos Morais, visited Brockton to meet his relatives. He chanced upon Pina playing a club game. The next day, he visited Pina's home and convinced his parents to take him to Portugal, where he was coaching. "I hope he will visit us after



Cape Verde fans in Boston's suburb of Brockton. EXPRESS

the World Cup. Our town has a World Cup hero," he says, hoping that he could host all of them in the restaurant and whip up dishes that bring sodade.

They have other heroes, too. The goalkeeper Vozinha tops the list. "He has become my favourite," says Moniz. "Our tiny island now has a lot of new heroes, and we can build on this culture," she says. She reproduces what has become the rallying cry of Cape Verdeans. "They gave us 1 per cent chance, but we gave 99 per cent faith."

Brockton and Cape Verde have a connection that predates the American Civil War, when Yankee whalers recruited young Africans from Cape Verde in the crew. For Cape Verdeans, whaling was a ticket out of these bleak

volcanic islands where drought and famine struck in regular succession. The character Daggoon in Herman Melville's Moby Dick is from the Cape Verdean island of Azores. The scattered islands, then part of the larger West Africa, had an American consul as early as the nineteenth century. "I have heard that till the 1960s, there were sailors who travelled in schooners to Cape Verde." Carlos's favourite is the captain, Ryan Mendes. "He is a fighter, leader," he says. Miles away, in Cape Verde museum in Rhode Island, the curator has managed a signed shirt from all the members of the squad and preserved it in the most prominent showcase. "It's the most exciting time in Cape Verde history, and we've

had some pretty exciting times," director Joe DaMoura told Boston Globe. The results did not surprise him. "It is just another evidence of our history of resilience and tenacity. That comes with our history of living on hope," he says. The Argentina game is three days away, and Carvalho says he has never felt the time move as slowly as he is feeling now. "That would be the greatest party Brockton has ever seen. Messi and our boys, is it a dream?" he asks. His lone fear is whether the party goes wild and people start brawling. "A few people got shot. I think after the Uruguay game. But if we lose or win, we will celebrate," he says. A win? "We will have an earthquake here!"

At 44, Serena gives herself pep talk ahead of Wimbledon



Serena Williams. AP
Ken Maguire
London, June 28

SERENA WILLIAMS had to talk herself into accepting Wimbledon's offer to play singles.

The All England club was holding one last wild card entry and the 23-time Grand Slam singles champion - who had already announced she'd play doubles with her sister Venus - had a decision to make.

"I thought I should really take this opportunity. Who knows if I'll ever make it here again. This could be it," the 44-year-old Williams said Sunday at a press conference.

"I was like, What's wrong with me, Serena? What are you thinking? Are you nuts? Like you really should do this," she added. "People live to be an athlete. I have this great opportunity to showcase what I do, what I do best, I suppose. Yeah, I think ultimately I was like that is pretty cool, so I should do it." Williams' first match at the grass-court Grand Slam since 2022 will take place on Centre Court on Tuesday evening when she faces 20-year-old Maya Joint of Australia as part of her evolving tennis comeback.

Williams had been away from the sport since her farewell at the 2022 US Open.

Her most-recent appearance at Wimbledon was in 2022 when she lost in the opening round to Harmony Tan, who was then-ranked 115th. The American great walked away from tennis - she described it as "evolving" away - after losing in the third round to Ajla Tomljanovic at Flushing Meadows.

After earlier accepting a wild card in doubles, Williams described the process of making her decision for singles.

"So I think it was on, I had until Monday to decide. I think it was like Sunday. I just wasn't sure up until then," she said. "Honestly, I'm still not even sure, but we'll see." Williams is a seven-time Wimbledon singles champion but said Sunday that "in general my expectations are definitely different for the first time in my career." Defending champion Iga Swiatek opens play on Centre Court on Tuesday (1:30 p.m. local time), in keeping with tradition, against Taylor Townsend. That's to be followed by Taylor Fritz vs. home favorite Jack Draper - in what is one of the most intriguing men's first-round matchups. AP

WOMEN'S T20 WORLD CUP

Aussie class proves too much as Harmanpreet & Co knocked out

India skipper took team to 170 and had Aussies in trouble before Perry & Gardner stepped on the gas

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, June 28

AT 85/3 AFTER 12 overs, India had Australia exactly where they wanted them. Defending 170 at Lord's in a must-win game for a place in the Women's T20 World Cup semi-final, Harmanpreet Kaur & Co had the favourites in a chokehold with the required rate climbing towards 11 an over, and Ellyse Perry and Ashleigh Gardner forced to rebuild rather than attack.

Then came Radha Yadav with the 13th over of the chase.

The left-arm spinner, who returned with figures of 3/28 in the previous match against Bangladesh, leaked 17 runs as Perry and Gardner finally broke free. Gardner drove and pulled with authority while Perry kept the scoreboard ticking, the over releasing all the pressure India had painstakingly built till then. The Indian skipper looked livid, the required rate dropped rapidly, Australia's dugout found belief, and suddenly it was India searching for answers.

Perry and Gardner never relinquished that momentum. Their 100-run partnership for the fourth wicket came off just 57 balls but was built in two distinct phases. Initially content with rotating strike against Deepti Sharma and Sree Charani, they targeted the loose deliveries



Ellyse Perry's 56 from 38 balls helped Australia chase down the target of 171 on Sunday. AP

once Radha's expensive over changed the game.

Charani gave away 16 runs in the 15th over, Shafali Verma then conceded 12 in her next over before Renuka Singh Thakur returned to be hit for 17, including Gardner's straight six as Perry reached her half-century.

Deepti, who had conceded just 19 runs in her first three overs, could not produce the goods late in the innings as the Australian pair added the finishing touches to the chase.

Until Radha's over, India's bowlers had executed their plans superbly. Renuka struck with the second ball by trapping Georgia Vull LBW after a successful review, Charani removed Phoebe Litchfield for 24, and when Deepti dismissed Beth Mooney to become the leading wicket-taker in women's inter-

national cricket, India were on top at 68/3. India's fielding matched the bowling effort, with Richa Ghosh tidy behind the stumps, and safe catching and energetic work in the ring preventing boundaries. But one over undid 12 overs of disciplined effort. Although Charani eventually dismissed Perry for 56, it came with Australia needing only a handful of runs, and the six-time champions completed the chase with an over to spare to knock India out of the tournament, allowing South Africa to enter the semifinals.

Harmanpreet shines

Harmanpreet had looked scratchy through much of the tournament. Runs had come in patches, timing had deserted her, and fluency had been hard to find. But on Sunday, with In-

dia's Women's T20 World Cup campaign hanging in the balance against familiar rivals Australia, the captain smashed a 27-ball 56 to propel India to 170/4.

For much of the innings, India appeared headed towards a sub-par total. Australia's disciplined bowling and sharp fielding had kept the scoring in check, leaving Harmanpreet with plenty to do at the death. She responded with a final flourish, taking apart Sophie Molineux in the last over with three successive sixes.

She first charged down the ground before stepping across to clear long-off and then hammered another over extra cover that burst through Litchfield's hands for six. Although she holed out off the next ball, the late assault proved pivotal in lifting India to a competitive total.

Stokes announces retirement from int'l cricket

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 28

ENGLAND CAPTAIN Ben Stokes will retire from international cricket after the third Test against New Zealand, the England team announced on Sunday. The shock announcement was made mid-way through the fourth day of the ongoing Test at Trent Bridge.

According to a report by BBC, Stokes was actually in the middle of a bowling spell when a statement on his behalf was released. And right after the announcement, with his first delivery, Stokes picked up the wicket of Zak Foulkes (caught at second slip by vice captain Harry Brook, who could replace Stokes at the helm).

On its social media handles, the England and Wales Cricket Board (ECB) posted a clip of an

emotional Stokes breaking the news of his impending retirement to his England teammates in a speech.

Retirement means Stokes will pull curtains on a 15-year international career that peaked when he starred for England in its win over New Zealand in the 50-over World Cup final in 2019. In his career, Stokes played 122 Tests for England. Of these, 44 of which were as captain of the national side. Stokes also played 114 one-day internationals and 43 T20Is, this includes the role he played in the T20 2022 World Cup final.

He also was a key player in England T20 World Cup-winning team in 2022, the same year he became Test captain.

Stokes was dropped from the second Test of the current series for disciplinary reasons after a



The announcement came in the middle of England's third Test against New Zealand. AP

night out after the first Test. The England captain and pacer Gus Atkinson had broken a midnight curfew and were embroiled in an incident at a London night-

Retirement means Stokes will pull curtains on a 15-year international career that peaked when England defeated New Zealand in the 50-over World Cup final in 2019.

club, following England's series-opening win at Lord's. In 2017, Stokes was arrested over a brawl outside a Bristol nightclub and was indefinitely suspended by the ECB.

Despite the off-field controversies, Stokes has also had a huge on-field influence, helping implement a cultural reset in the England team, partnering with coach Bren-

dan McCullum to introduce an aggressive brand of cricket quickly nicknamed "Bazball."

With Stokes dropped for the second Test, the England side led by Joe Root suffered a 253-run thrashing at The Oval, as New Zealand levelled the series at 1-1 heading into the Nottingham finale at Trent Bridge.

"That (apologising) was one of the first things I had to do as a captain. You look at a situation and it obviously affects more than just myself. It affects a lot of people, Joe Root, the squad, people outside of the playing environment. It no doubt had an effect on people making their debuts. That should have been all about them, but unfortunately a situation outside of their control took precedent over their big days. It would be stupid and naive of me not to acknowledge and address that," said Stokes.

ANOTHER LOSS TO IRELAND

Batting goes to shambles as India lose by one run vs Irish



Tilak Varma's 55 was not enough for India to win on Sunday. CREIMAS

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, June 28

HAVING GONE 16 consecutive series without losing, which included laying hands on two T20 World Cups in 2024 and 2026, India's proud run came to a grinding halt at Belfast against Ireland. If the defeat in the first T20I on Friday came as a shock, on Sunday Ireland held their nerve when Harshit Rana threatened a heist as they won by one run to take the series 2-0.

Prior to Friday, India hadn't lost any match to Ireland. In three days they have lost two and a series. And it is another ignominious feat for head coach Gautam Gambhir, who has seen a few lows in his stint so far. Next up lies England on Wednesday and to recover the lost face, India may well have to turn to 15-year-old Vaibhav Sooryavanshi.

For the second outing in a row, the India batting unit failed to chase a target within reach. Troubling them again was Jai Moondra, the left-arm seamer who is waiting to know the fate of his visa. Employed with Intel, his time with the tech giants has ended and if he doesn't find another employment opportunity, he may have to leave Ireland. The software engineer might have something else lined up. Having already made an impression on his debut on Friday, he went a step ahead on Sunday, running through India's top-order to stun them.

Sanju Samson was trapped in front by what is a dream delivery for left-arm seamers. It pitched on middle-and-off and shaped back in. For Abhishek Sharma, he kept it outside off and made it go away from him and the left-hander ended up having a swing at it and the top-edge was pouched wonderfully by Matt Holland. He had overruled the ball, but still managed to hold on to it by diving backwards. And then came the wicket of Shreyas Iyer. The new T20I captain had two confident boundaries to show to his name in his brief stay, and as Moondra slanted one across, he went for an expansive drive, only to inside edge it to the stumps.

19/3 inside four overs, made the chase of 155 even more steep.

Ishan Kishan departed soon after, courtesy a direct hit from Ross Adair to a non-existent single. Tilak Varma fought hard, labouring to 55 off 46, showing his intention to take the game deep with the hope that one of the others end up doing the heavy lifting.

Prince arrives

India had let the game drift away from them with the ball. The luxury that the think-tank showed with the batsmen in terms of faith wasn't shown to the attack as Prasadh Krishna, who leaked 57 in his four overs, was benched. So was Washington Sundar, who has appeared to be caught without a proper role clarity. So both made way for Suryansh Shedge and Prince Yadav, who have shown promise in recent times in the IPL.

Between the two it was Prince who impressed straightaway. Like in the first T20I, Arshdeep Singh and Harshit Rana played their part, making early inroads, taking two wickets in the powerplay. Last May, he had left a red-hot Virat Kohli clueless with a sharp inswinging that the batsmen wondered how he delivered later on. Right through this IPL and in the lead-up he has been working alongside renowned bowling coach Bharat Arun. The plans have been simple: Arun would put him under pressure and watch how Prince responds with his execution. Through the sessions Arun had seen Prince respond in the way he expected. At the IPL, he showed it in the middle.

On Sunday, after getting his India cap, he proved his mettle in the middle, showing why he is a talent to persist with. Even at the death, he showed the maturity to not get predictable by relying on yorkers, mixing it up with short deliveries and well-disguised slower balls. Three wickets to his name on debut was a reward for the work he did and his scalps included Harry Tector, who top scored with 53. **BRIEF SCORES: Ireland 154 for 8 in 20 overs (Harry Tector 53; Prince Yadav 3/22, Shivam Dube 2/25) beat India 153/9 in 20 overs (Tilak Varma 55, Jai Moondra 3/32, Matt Holland 3/26) by 1 run.**

{ INTER-STATE ATHLETICS }

At 31, Kushare ends 4-year wait for NR

Prithish Raj
Bhubaneswar, June 28

SARVESH ANIL Kushare, who started jumping in a makeshift pit of corn husks in his village Devargaon, Nashik, took 14 steps and a smooth lift to clear the 2.31m bar and set the new men's high jump national record.

A simple harmonic motion to break the previous national record of 2.29m held by Tejaswin Shankar. As he threw his hands up in celebration, every other competing jumper embraced him and clapped in admiration, showing the magnanimity of the occasion.

But the story of Sarvesh breaking the high jump national record is more of a resilient work horse than a flamboyant superstar. The 31-year-old is the oldest athlete among the active national record holders.

"Bas ho gaya (it just happened). I have been chasing this mark for four years now. I jumped 2.27m in 2022 but was stuck with this mark for so many years," Sarvesh told *The Indian Express*. After jumping 2.27m in 2022 at the National Games, Sarvesh chased the elusive national record for three years before he improved to 2.28m at the World Championships. "Whenever



Sarvesh Kushare is the oldest athlete among active national record holders. AFI

the 2.30 mark used to come, he used to think a lot. I also used to think a lot. Today, none of us were thinking and that is why it happened," his coach Jithin Thomas said.

Jithin, who is an Asian silver medallist, worked on Kushare's mindset while attempting a mark above national record.

"He used to lose control of his run-up while going for the national record. Today, his run up was top notch. I guess he was too eager in the first two attempts but then as he

calmed down, the jump came," said Jithin.

Jithin told him that if he achieves the national record, everybody will remember him whenever high jump is mentioned in the country. "I told him that if you become the first Indian jumper to break the 2.30m mark, you'll be remembered forever in Indian athletics history," he said.

Mental barrier broken

When Tejaswin Shankar did 2.29m in 2018, it looked like Indian high jumpers would be soon competing at global stages as 2.30m is the globally accepted standard.

"With this mark achieved, it is a mental barrier broken and the 2.34m or 2.35m mark is not far now," Tejaswin tweeted on X. Sarvesh acknowledged that it was a barrier and with him jumping 2.31, it might open the floodgates. To put in context, the 2.31m mark would have earned him a bronze medal at the 2025 Worlds.

"Tejaswin first did 2.26m and we all followed him. If he wouldn't have done that, none of this was possible. Now that I have gone past the 2.30m, you will see more Indian jumpers going past that mark," said Sarvesh.

It is not the first time Sarvesh attempted a mark more than 2.30m but every time, he used to fail. "It was more like a psychological barrier. I always used to fail at the 2.30m mark. That is why I decided to go ahead and jump 2.31m. I think that worked for me," said Sarvesh.

The village celebrates

Sarvesh has come a long way from his village in Nashik to becoming the national record holder.

Devargaon, a village with 3,000 people on the way to Nashik, watches every time Sarvesh jumps. "I am always nervous when he jumps. The village stops to watch him. Yesterday, it was evening and we were a little busy. But once everyone realized that he is going for the national record, we started watching," his father Anil Kushare told *The Indian Express*.

Immediately after Sarvesh was done with his media duties, he got on a video call with his father. "Chehra toh dekhna hi tha iska time bade din ke baad (I had to see his face after such a big day)," Anil quipped.

Kushare Sr once wanted his son to become an engineer, but today he can't stop boasting how his son engineered one of the world class national records.

Rohit Yadav becomes third Indian to throw javelin over 87m, qualifies for Asian Games

Prithish Raj
Bhubaneswar, June 28

AS THE final day of the Inter State Athletics Championships moved to a gloomy end, 25-year-old javelin thrower Rohit Yadav produced the best throw of the season by an Indian to record a 87.05m mark and confirm his berth for the Asian Games, besides double Olympic medallist Neeraj Chopra.

He was placed third before the last attempt but turned it around with the throw that puts him second in the World top list just behind Sri Lankan Rumesh Pathirage. The thrower from Uttar Pradesh has been a consistent name on the Javelin circuit with personal bests hovering around 82-83m. With his latest mark, he became the third Indian to cross the 87m mark after Neeraj and Asian Games silver medallist Kishore Kumar Jena.

"Dusro ko dekh ke sochta tha ki main bhi yahi kar raha hu, patanahi throw kaba aayega (I always used to look at others and wonder when I would get this kind of throw)," Rohit told *The Indian Express*. "I was consistently crossing 85m in my train-



Rohit Yadav has the leading mark among Indian javelin throwers this season after recording a 87.05m effort. AFI

ing but it was not translating into big throws, but today it finally happened."

The confidence preceded the competition day. Before coming to Inter-State Athletics he changed his phone wallpaper to a picture of him beside the 85m mark. "When I went to South Africa in 2019, I took this picture thinking that someday I will break this mark," he said.

Rohit has been around the Indian javelin scene since the past six years but the journey for him has been filled with a lot of ups and downs. "My journey as

a javelin thrower hasn't been smooth. I came through early as a youngster and then suddenly an injury put brakes on all my progress," said Rohit.

Breaking early as an 18-year-old on the circuit, Rohit threw 82.54m in 2022 and put himself on the javelin map in India. In the same year, he played in the World Championships, final finishing tenth and Commonwealth Games, finishing sixth. He improved to 83.40m in 2023 and was well on the course to Asian Games in Hangzhou before an injury in his throwing arm ruled him out.

"I felt that my world has crashed. I had played at World Championships final and was on the course for Asian Games. The injury came during training and I felt my heart breaking slowly," said Rohit.

The comeback was not smooth at all as the surgery didn't go as plan. "The surgery didn't help me really and my rehabilitation was really slow. The year after my comeback, I only threw less than 80m," said Rohit. The fear of again injuring the throwing arm troubled Rohit. But once the rehabilitation picked pace, he started improving. "In 2025, I started my season with 80m throw and it gave me confidence that I still have in it me. My doubt and fear was gone," he said.

Rohit has a knack of performing at the Inter State Championships. He has won the national title four times and his personal bests have come in the tournament. "Last year, I did my personal best of 83.65m at the Chennai Inter State which gave me confidence for the World Championships. Though, I didn't play well in Tokyo, it was a good year for me overall," said Rohit.